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Philippians

Philippians 1:1

Section 1:1–2: Paul began his letter to the Christians in Philippi

In New Testament times it was the custom for writers to put their names at the beginning of a letter. Then they put the name of the person or group they were writing to. They usually included some kind of blessing. All of these are in the first two verses of this letter to the Philippians. In some languages the recipients are always mentioned first. If it is not polite to put the author's name first, it may be necessary to reorder this introduction so that the Philippians are mentioned first, and then Paul and Timothy. However, try to maintain the original order if possible in order to accurately reflect how Paul actually began his letter.

1:1a

Paul and Timothy, servants of Christ Jesus,

- ¶ This letter is from Paul and Timothy, slaves of Christ Jesus. I, Paul,
- ¶ I, Paul, together with Timothy, as servants of Christ Jesus,
- ¶ This letter is from Paul, and from Timothy too. We^(excl) serve Christ Jesus.

Paul and Timothy: Commentators agree that only Paul was the author of the letter to the Philippians. The reason is that the author used the first person singular “I” and “me,” not “we,” throughout the rest of the letter, and he referred to Timothy in the third person as “he” or “him” or “Timothy.”

The fact that Paul mentioned Timothy's name here may imply that Paul consulted Timothy when he wrote the letter. Or perhaps Timothy wrote the letter while Paul told him what to write. Certainly Timothy was with Paul and agreed with what Paul said in the letter. Two ways of showing this in the translation are:

Timothy joins me in writing to you.

I and Timothy are sending this letter to you.

Timothy: In some languages it is necessary to introduce a new participant such as a secondary author with a short phrase such as “our brother Timothy.”

servants: The Greek word *doulos* means “slave.” Most English versions translate it here as “servant,” but the term refers to a worker who was not paid and who was not free to leave his employment. It may therefore be

better to use your word for “slave” here. Paul was not saying that he and Timothy were servants or slaves of people. He meant that they belonged to Jesus and served him as their master. This was not degrading to them but was a position of honor and dignity.

Christ Jesus: There are seven Greek forms of Jesus' name or title in Philippians. A literal translation of these is:

1. Christ Jesus,
2. Jesus Christ,
3. Lord Jesus,
4. Lord Jesus Christ,
5. Jesus,
6. Lord, and

- Christ.

You need to decide how you will translate each of these seven names or titles so you can use them consistently throughout the New Testament. The two phrases “Jesus Christ” and “Christ Jesus” mean the same thing. However, the New Testament writer may have had a reason to put one name first in each case, perhaps for emphasis. A common way to put emphasis on a word in Greek is to put that word first. If the word “Christ” comes first in the phrase, there may be an emphasis on the title Messiah. If the word “Jesus” comes first, the author may have been thinking of the phrase “Jesus Christ” as a name, or perhaps he was thinking of Jesus as a human being. But there is no explicit example in the New Testament showing that this was the emphasis intended by the author. However, there is no way to be sure this is what the authors meant. The Translator's Notes on Philippians follows the literal order of the Greek in such phrases. But in your language, you must decide whether to translate the phrase Christ Jesus literally as “Christ Jesus” or whether to translate it as “Jesus Christ.”

Christ: The word Christ is used in two ways in the New Testament. In the Gospels it is used as a title for Jesus. It was the Greek equivalent of “Messiah,” which literally means “the person who has been anointed.” However, by the time Paul was writing his letters, it had become a name for Jesus rather than a title. So here and in the other New Testament letters, you should simply spell Christ according to the rules of your language.

1:1b

To all the saints in Christ Jesus at Philippi,

- am writing to all God's people in the town of Philippi, those who belong to Christ Jesus.

- This letter is to/for all of you who live in the town of Philippi who belong to God because of what Christ Jesus has done.

To: The Greek does not have a verb here, and in some languages it is necessary to supply one. For example: “Paul and Timothy...write to all the saints...” Another possible verb is “send,” implying “send this letter.” In the context of the whole letter, it seems most likely that “write” is the implied verb here. No commentary support has been found for the idea that the implied verb here is “greet” or “send greetings.” Also, if the translator used “greet” here, the resulting phrase “greet to all the saints” would not fit grammatically. The greetings are in 4:21–22. Paul’s greetings normally came at the end of his letters. If a verb is supplied, it may also be necessary to supply a first person pronoun (“I” or “we”) as the subject.

the saints: This is literally “the holy ones” or “the holy people.” It refers to those whom God has set apart for himself. Some versions avoid the word saints because this word has come to be used only for a few special people. But the word saints in the New Testament in fact refers to all Christians. See “holy”, sense A3a in KBT. Possible translations are “God’s people,” “God’s chosen people,” “Christians,” “people who belong to God” or “people whom God has set apart for himself.” This word appears again in 4:21–22.

in Christ Jesus: The phrase in Christ Jesus and similar phrases such as “in the Lord” and “in him” occur twenty-two times in Paul’s letter to the Philippians. Most English translations keep the literal wording in Christ Jesus here, and this is also possible in many other languages. This phrase means to be united with Christ, to personally relate to him and to belong to him. A book that Hale wrote (1991) specifically about this topic is helpful (see Bibliography).

1:1c

together with the overseers and deacons:

- This letter also goes to those who are leaders among you and those who help you.

together with: Paul probably meant that he was including the overseers and deacons among “the saints” to whom he was writing.

overseers and deacons: Most commentators agree that at the time Paul wrote this letter, the church did not yet have clearly defined leadership positions or titles, but they did have leaders. Although their exact duties are not certain, it is clear that overseers and deacons were the recognized leaders within the church.

overseers: The word that the BSB translates as overseers is translated by some English versions as “bishops.” It refers to teachers, leaders and others in positions of authority. In some languages it can be translated by an expression meaning “leaders,” “those who watch over the believers,” or “church elders.”

deacons: The word deacons refers to people who served as assistants to the overseers and managed practical matters. You could translate the word deacons as “helpers,” “those who work for God among the believers,” or “those who help the believers.” In some languages there is already an accepted church term for “deacon,” so the translator must decide whether he will use that term or another term.

In some languages the BSB order (“saints,” “overseers,” deacons) might imply that the elders and deacons were not among the saints. If this is true in your language, you could reverse the order and translate it as:

to the overseers and deacons and to all the other saints.

Philippians 1:2

Section 1:1–2: Paul began his letter to the Christians in Philippi

In New Testament times it was the custom for writers to put their names at the beginning of a letter. Then they put the name of the person or group they were writing to. They usually included some kind of blessing. All of these are in the first two verses of this letter to the Philippians. In some languages the recipients are always mentioned first. If it is not polite to put the author’s name first, it may be necessary to reorder this introduction so that the Philippians are mentioned first, and then Paul and Timothy. However, try to maintain the original order if possible in order to accurately reflect how Paul actually began his letter.

1:2

Grace and peace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

- We^(excl) pray that God who is our^(incl) Father and Jesus Christ who is our^(incl) Lord will be gracious to you and will give you peace.
- May God our^(incl) Father and Jesus Christ our^(incl) Lord be kind to you and help you to continue to live peacefully.

Grace and peace to you: In the early days of Christianity many people used this sort of Christian greeting. It was like a prayer or a blessing. You may need to use

the verb “pray” or “ask/request God” in your translation. For example:

We pray that God will give you grace and peace.”

Even if in your language you normally translate Grace or peace as a long phrase, you may want to use something shorter in a Christian greeting like this. Here Paul was not actually teaching about Grace and peace, and so it may not be necessary to include all the elements normally associated with these terms.

Grace: The Greek word *charis* that the BSB translates as Grace here means “favor, goodwill, kindness, blessing.” See “grace” in KBT. Paul wanted God to show kindness and favor to the Philippian Christians. This is an important term in the New Testament, although it appears only three times in Philippians (see also 1:7 and 4:23). In some languages it may be necessary to translate the noun Grace as a verb. So you might translate the phrase “Grace...to you” in the following ways:

I pray that God will be very good to you.

May God act favorably toward you.

peace: The Greek word *eirēnē* that the BSB translates as peace means “well-being” or “absence of conflict.” It refers mainly to peace with God but may also have the secondary meanings of peace with man and peace of heart (a person’s own inner peace). See “peace” in KBT.

you: The Greek form here is plural. This pronoun appears frequently throughout the book of Philippians and (except for 4:3) is always plural, because Paul was addressing the letter to all the Philippian Christians.

our Father: God is called our Father because he is the one who gives us both physical and spiritual life. He loves us as a father does and has adopted us as his children. We are to love, trust and obey him as children do their earthly fathers.

our: In this letter Paul almost always includes the Philippian Christians as well as himself when he says “us” or our. See the note on “we” in 3:17b for an exception to this.

Philippians 1:3

Section 1:3–11: Paul thanked God for the Philippians and prayed for them

In 1:3–11 Paul thanked God for the Philippian believers. He told them that he prayed for them and loved them very much.

Paragraph 1:3–8

Paul told the Philippians that he often thanked God for them and prayed for them. They were a great help to him in preaching the gospel, and Paul loved them deeply.

1:3

I thank my God every time I remember you.

- ¶ Every time I think of you, I thank my God for you.
- ¶ I Paul thank the God whom I worship whenever I think of you.

I thank my God: In some languages it is not possible to say “I thank God.” What a person says to God must be in direct speech. For example:

I say ‘thank you’ to God.

I: If you used “we” as the subject of any verbs in 1:1 and 1:2, make sure that it is clear that the subject of this verse is Paul alone.

my God: This refers to the God Paul worshiped, the God to whom he belonged. In many languages it is not possible to say my God, as if a person could own God. Possible ways of translating this are “the God I worship” and “God, my Lord.”

every time I remember you: The word remember here does not mean for someone to remember someone he had forgotten. It means to think about someone again.

Philippians 1:4

Section 1:3–11: Paul thanked God for the Philippians and prayed for them

In 1:3–11 Paul thanked God for the Philippian believers. He told them that he prayed for them and loved them very much.

Paragraph 1:3–8

Paul told the Philippians that he often thanked God for them and prayed for them. They were a great help to him in preaching the gospel, and Paul loved them deeply.

1:4

In every prayer for all of you, I always pray with joy,

- Every time I pray for you all, I rejoice

- Whenever I ask God to help you all, I always pray joyfully.

In 1:3–4 Paul strongly emphasized that he was happy and thankful for the Philippians. In Greek emphasis could be shown by repetition, and in these verses Paul repeated the idea of “all” (every time, all my prayers, all of you, always) and the idea of “prayer.” Try to find a natural way to show this emphasis in your language.

In every prayer for all of you, I always pray with joy:

Paul meant that whenever he prayed for the Philippians, he prayed for all of them with joy. The emphasis of the verse is on Paul’s joy. Make sure your translation does not imply that sometimes Paul only prayed for some of the Philippians and then he was not joyful. It may be necessary to make the meaning clear by saying something like:

Every time I pray for you, I ask God to help all of you and I always rejoice.

In every prayer: This is literally “in every prayer of mine.” It could be translated as “every time I pray.” It may indicate that Paul prayed for the Philippians at each of his set times of prayer.

prayer...pray: In Greek these are both the noun meaning “supplication.” It may be necessary to translate both of them with a verb meaning “to pray, beg, ask God for help.” Paul was asking God to help the Philippians. The word you use for prayer should include the concept of asking God for something.

Although the word for prayer occurs twice in the original Greek, in your language it may be unnatural to repeat the word. If that is the case, perhaps the same meaning can be obtained by using one verb or two synonyms (see Display).

with joy: This means “with happiness,” “joyfully” or “because I am happy.”

Philippians 1:5

Section 1:3–11: Paul thanked God for the Philippians and prayed for them

In 1:3–11 Paul thanked God for the Philippian believers. He told them that he prayed for them and loved them very much.

Paragraph 1:3–8

Paul told the Philippians that he often thanked God for them and prayed for them. They were a great help to him in preaching the gospel, and Paul loved them deeply.

1:5a

because of your partnership in the gospel

- because you have been my partners in the work of proclaiming the good news.
- I feel joyful because you have helped me to tell people the good news about Jesus Christ

because of your partnership in the gospel: This phrase has been understood in two ways:

1. It gives the reason why Paul prayed with joy. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, NJB, REB, GW, NLT)
2. It gives the reason why Paul thanked God (in 1:3). Many commentaries follow this interpretation. (RSV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

Commentators agree that the phrase your partnership in the gospel refers to the Philippians helping Paul to proclaim the gospel through giving money, praying, encouraging others and by proclaiming it themselves. See “fellowship“, sense A2 in KBT.

gospel: The Greek word translated as gospel means “good news.” See “gospel“ in KBT. Look for a common phrase in your language that means “good news.” Other ways to translate it are:

God’s good news

the good message

1:5b

from the first day until now,

- You have done this from the first day you believed this good news, and you continue to do it.
- starting from the time when you began to believe, and you have not stopped.

from the first day until now: This means “from the first time you heard the gospel and believed it until now.” There is a similar reference in 4:15b (literally, “in the beginning of the gospel”). The two phrases both mean that as soon as they had accepted the gospel, the Philippians immediately began to cooperate with Paul in spreading the gospel to others. It will probably be helpful for you to make explicit in your translation the implied information that the first day means the time the Philippians first believed the gospel. For example:

from the first day you believed (NCV)

until now: This means “you are still doing it.” It does not mean they stopped helping Paul at the time when he wrote the letter. They were continuing to help him at that time.

General Comment on 1:5

In some languages it may be better to reverse 1:5a and 1:5b, and put the time phrase earlier in the verse. For example:

I pray with joy because ever since you first accepted the gospel and until now, you have been partners with me in spreading the gospel.

Philippians 1:6

Section 1:3–11: Paul thanked God for the Philippians and prayed for them

In 1:3–11 Paul thanked God for the Philippian believers. He told them that he prayed for them and loved them very much.

Paragraph 1:3–8

Paul told the Philippians that he often thanked God for them and prayed for them. They were a great help to him in preaching the gospel, and Paul loved them deeply.

1:6a

being confident of this, that He who began a good work in you

- I am sure about what I am about to say: God, who has begun doing good in your hearts,
- And of this I am certain: God has started to do something good within you, and he

being confident: This means “being sure” or “strongly believing.” In many languages it may be helpful to begin a new sentence here and to translate this as “I am confident” or “I am certain” or “I am convinced.”

of this: This is an emphatic phrase, literally, “of this very thing.” This phrase is pointing forward to what follows: Paul is sure about what God will continue to do. Some English translations (for example, RSV, GNT, NCV, CEV, NLT) either do not translate this phrase or understand it as emphasizing “confident.” For example:

quite confident (NJB)

I’m convinced (GW)

But most commentators and translations understand this phrase to be emphasizing what Paul is confident

about (BSB, NET, NIV, REB, NRSV, NASB, KJV). If in your language it is possible to place emphasis on what Paul is sure of, that would be appropriate here.

He who began a good work in you: He refers to God. There are two interpretations of the good work that he began:

1. The good work that God began was the salvation and new life that God gave them when they believed the gospel. When the Philippians received the gospel, God did something in them that changed who they were.
2. The good work that God began was their work of cooperating in the spread of the gospel. This understanding is signaled by the insertion of the word “this” in GNT, CEV, and GW. For example:

God, who began this good work in you (GNT)

Most translations do not insert the word “this” and so are probably following the first interpretation. It is recommended that, along with the majority of commentators, you also follow first interpretation (1).

In some languages it may be necessary to translate the noun work with a verb:

The one who has begun to do something good in you....

In some languages it may also be necessary to express the idea began as a marker on the following verb (“work,” “make” or “do”) instead of as a separate word.

1:6b

will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus.

- will keep doing it until he has completely finished it when Christ Jesus comes back again.

will carry it on to completion: In the Greek this is a single verb meaning “will complete, finish, accomplish.” God began the good work of salvation within the Philippians and would continue to work in them to change them into godly people. In some languages the best way to express the idea of “complete” or completion will be to put it in a sentence at the end of the verse. For example:

God will continue doing this good work in you until Christ Jesus returns. At that time it will be complete.

until the day of Christ Jesus: The Greek word *achri* translated by the BSB as *until* has been understood in two ways:

1. It means “until.” God will keep on finishing what he has begun until the time when Christ returns. At that time his work will be complete. (BSB, KJV, NIV, NASB, NJB, NET)
2. It means “at” or “on.” God will complete his work on the day that Christ returns. (RSV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Compare a similar phrase in 1:10 and the notes there.

the day of Christ Jesus: This refers to the time Christ will come back. You could translate it as “when Christ Jesus returns to the earth.” This phrase occurs three times in Philippians (see also 1:10 and 2:16) and in several other New Testament passages.

Christ Jesus: There is a textual problem with this part of the verse. Different Greek manuscripts say different things. The two possible readings are:

1. Some versions have Christ Jesus (BSB, NIV, GNT, NASB, REB, CEV, NLT, NET)
2. Some versions have “Jesus Christ”. (RSV, NCV, NJB)

The meaning is the same, but the reading Christ Jesus has the best manuscript support and it is recommended that you follow it (1).

General Comment on 1:6

It may be necessary in some languages to put the words of this verse in a different order. For example:

God has begun a good work in you, and I am confident that he will keep on completing it until the day of Christ Jesus.

I am sure that God will keep on doing this good work that he has started in you until Christ Jesus returns. Then it will be complete.

Philippians 1:7

Section 1:3–11: Paul thanked God for the Philippians and prayed for them

In 1:3–11 Paul thanked God for the Philippian believers. He told them that he prayed for them and loved them very much.

Paragraph 1:3–8

Paul told the Philippians that he often thanked God for them and prayed for them. They were a great help to him in preaching the gospel, and Paul loved them deeply.

1:7a

It is right for me to feel this way about all of you, since I have you in my heart.

- It is good that I think like this about you all because I love you very much.
- I love you all very much. That is why it is natural for me to think about you in this way.

In Greek this verse begins with a conjunction meaning “just as, for.” The BSB moves it to the beginning of 1:7b to make more natural English, but if it is more natural in your language to use such a connection in 1:7a, you should do so.

It is right: This means “it is proper, it is appropriate, it is good.” In some languages it may be better to put it in the negative; for example, “it is not strange.”

feel this way: The Greek word that the BSB translates *feel* is translated as “think” in most contexts. It refers to the activity of the mind and will, and is not just an emotion. The phrase *this way* refers back to all the things that Paul had said about why he was thankful for the Philippians in 1:3–6.

I have you in my heart: This Greek idiom means “I love you very much.”

1:7b–c

For in my chains and in my defense and confirmation of the gospel: The Greek is literally “in my chains and in the defense and confirmation of the gospel.” Neither the Greek nor the BSB translation means that Paul was in prison at one time and proclaimed the gospel at another time. Even while he was in prison, he was proclaiming the gospel. It is therefore better not to follow the GNT here (“both now that I am in prison and also while I was free to defend...”).

1:7b

For in my chains

- For while I am chained here in prison,
- While I am a prisoner

in my chains: The phrase *in...chains* translates a Greek idiom for being in prison. But it also implies that the guards literally tied Paul up or chained him to something so he could not escape.

1:7c

and in my defense and confirmation of the gospel,

- and while I have been answering criticisms of the gospel and demonstrating that the gospel is true,
- and when I am in court defending the good news about Jesus Christ and proving/showing that it is true,

my defense and confirmation of the gospel: It is possible to interpret this phrase two ways:

1. It refers to a court trial. Paul defended the gospel and proved its truth in a Roman court.
2. It refers more generally to any time Paul was explaining the gospel and showing why it was true.

Paul may have had both of these in mind, and in some languages the translation can allow for both interpretations. However, if you must choose, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

my defense...of the gospel: This means that Paul was explaining why the gospel was not false. He tried to remove objections and to show that criticisms of the gospel were wrong.

confirmation of the gospel: This means basically the same thing as “defense...of the gospel,” but from a positive angle: Paul was explaining why the gospel was true. In your translation, you may need to combine the ideas “defense” and confirmation into one phrase. For example:

explaining to enemies of the good news why it is true beyond doubt

1:7d

you are all partners in grace with me.

- God is graciously causing us^(incl) all to be partners in the work of telling the good news.
- God is kindly allowing all of us^(incl) to work together to tell the good news.

you are all partners in grace with me: In Greek this literally says “sharers of me of grace.” It is therefore not clear how the word meaning “of me” (or “my”) is connected to the rest of the phrase. There are two possibilities:

1. It is connected to the word “sharers.” This means that Paul and the Philippians shared together in God’s grace. The word grace thus refers to God’s goodness toward Paul and the Philippians, a goodness that he showed in letting them work for him. For example:

We have shared together the blessings of God (NLT) (RSV, NIV, NLT, NASB, NET, GW, NCV)

1. It is connected to the word grace. In this case “my” grace means the special grace that God gave to Paul as an apostle. The Philippians shared in Paul’s grace by supporting him financially. For example:

All of you have helped in the work that God has given me (CEV) (GNT, NJB, REB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1). God was kind to both Paul and the Philippians and gave them the privilege of working together to spread the gospel.

General Comment on 1:7b–d

It may be clearer in some languages to alter the order of the phrases in 1:7b–d and to place 1:7d before 1:7b–c. One way to do this would be:

God is kindly allowing us to work together in telling the good news about Jesus Christ, whether I am in prison or whether I am defending the good news and proving/showing that the good news is true.

Philippians 1:8

Section 1:3–11: Paul thanked God for the Philippians and prayed for them

In 1:3–11 Paul thanked God for the Philippian believers. He told them that he prayed for them and loved them very much.

Paragraph 1:3–8

Paul told the Philippians that he often thanked God for them and prayed for them. They were a great help to him in preaching the gospel, and Paul loved them deeply.

1:8

God is my witness how I long for all of you with the affection of Christ Jesus.

- God knows it is true that I want very much to see you all again because I love you the way Christ Jesus loves you.
- I yearn for you all very much with the love that Christ Jesus has given me for you. God knows this is true.

In the Greek this verse begins with a connecting word meaning “for.” The BSB does not translate this word, but if it is natural in your language, you may use such a connecting word here.

God is my witness: Paul used this phrase when there was no human witness, and especially when he was referring to his thoughts, feelings and attitudes. He meant that God was his witness and could verify that he was telling the truth. He said this five times in his letters when he was talking about how he felt, or when he was showing that he was dedicated to his Lord (also in Romans 1:9; 2 Corinthians 1:23; 1 Thessalonians 2:5, 2:10). You could translate the phrase God

is my witness as “God will tell you” or simply as “God knows.” In some translations this phrase is at the end of the verse. See 1:8 in the Display.

I long for all of you with the affection of Christ

Jesus: Just as Jesus cared for the Philippians, so Paul cared for them. He cared so deeply for them that he strongly desired to be with them again.

I long for all of you: This refers mainly to Paul’s desire to see the Philippians again. He wanted to visit them again in order to help them grow in their faith, but this reason is probably not the focus here.

the affection of Christ Jesus: The Greek word *splanchna*, which the BSB translates as affection, literally means “insides of the body,” that is, heart, liver, lungs, kidneys. Greek people considered that these parts of the body were the source of emotions and feeling. They used *splanchna* to refer to their emotions, much as English-speaking people use the word “heart.”

The entire Greek phrase used here refers to the deep, sincere love that Jesus Christ had for other people. Christ gave Paul the ability to love others in the same way. Therefore, by saying, “I long for all of you with the affection of Christ Jesus,” Paul was saying, “I long for all of you with the love that Jesus Christ has given me.” Another possible translations is:

I long for you because Christ Jesus has caused me to love you.

Philippians 1:9

Section 1:3–11: Paul thanked God for the Philippians and prayed for them

In 1:3–11 Paul thanked God for the Philippian believers. He told them that he prayed for them and loved them very much.

Paragraph 1:9–11

Paul prayed that the Philippians would love one another more and more, and would be pure and blameless so that other people would honor and praise God.

1:9a

And this is my prayer: that your love may abound more and more

- ¶ This is what I am praying for you: that you will continue to love even more than you do already.
- ¶ I pray that you will love one another more and more.

And this is my prayer: In 1:4 Paul said he prayed for the Philippians. Here in 1:9–11 he told them specifically

what he was praying. If in your language it is necessary to translate prayer with a verb, use a verb tense that gives the idea of habitual action in the present: “I pray (regularly, habitually, repeatedly)....”

that your love may abound more and more: Some languages have a special way to mark the content of a wish or a prayer. For example, in English we use the auxiliary verb *may*. If you have such a marker, you should use it here.

love: The Greek text, like most English translations, does not make it clear whom the Philippians were to love. The text could refer to loving one another or it could refer to loving God. Paul was probably including both ideas. Therefore, if possible you should not say in your translation whom the Philippians were to love. Then your readers will understand that it includes both these ideas. However, if you must provide an object, it is recommended that you say that the Philippians were to love one another.

abound more and more: The verb *abound* here means “grow” or “increase.” In some languages love cannot “grow,” but there may be another idiom for love becoming stronger or more intense. Or, if you cannot use an idiom, you could try expressing this meaning as

You already love each other a little, now love each other a lot.

Paul used the phrase *abound more and more* to emphasize that he desired the Philippians’ love to grow.

1:9b

in knowledge and depth of insight,

- And I pray that you will know more and more of what God is really like, and will be able in every situation to tell the difference between what is right and what is wrong.

knowledge and depth of insight: Commentators understand this phrase in two main ways:

1. The phrase *knowledge and depth of insight* refers to two things that Paul wanted to see increase along with the Philippians’ love. (GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV)
2. The phrase *knowledge and depth of insight* shows the way in which their love needed to grow, that is, the Philippians were to grow in love that had knowledge and depth of insight. (BSB, NIV, NASB, REB, NET)

Either interpretation is possible. The Display follows the first interpretation (1). However, if you prefer to follow the second (2), you could say:

that you will continue loving more and more in a way that is wise and discerning

knowledge: The Greek word that the BSB translates as knowledge is related to a verb that means “to know something truly or completely.” Paul did not specify what sort of knowledge he was talking about. It could refer to:

1. understanding God and how he wants us to behave. For example:

that you will fully know and understand how to make the right choices (1:9b-10a, CEV)

1. knowledge of the truth in general. For example:

true knowledge (GNT)

If you must be explicit, then choose the first option (1), that is, Paul was referring to knowing God and what God wants us to do.

depth of insight: This is literally “all judgment/discernment.” This phrase means to understand all kinds of things in a spiritual sense, to know what is true and right in every situation. This idea continues in 1:10.

Philippians 1:10

Section 1:3–11: Paul thanked God for the Philippians and prayed for them

In 1:3–11 Paul thanked God for the Philippian believers. He told them that he prayed for them and loved them very much.

Paragraph 1:9–11

Paul prayed that the Philippians would love one another more and more, and would be pure and blameless so that other people would honor and praise God.

1:10a

so that you may be able to test and prove what is best

- In that way, you will be able to choose what is the good/right thing to do.
- And the result will be that you will test and approve the best things.

so that: The phrase so that shows that 1:10a gives the purpose of Paul’s prayer in 1:9; that is, as the Philippians’ love, knowledge and insight grew, they would be better able to discern what was best.

you may be able to test and prove what is best: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as able to test

and prove implies not only that the Philippians would know what was best, but also that they would accept and approve it. This same Greek phrase that the BSB translates as “to test and prove what is best” appears also in Romans 2:18. If you look at several Bible versions you will notice that most of them do not have the same translation in Philippians 1:10 and Romans 2:18. This shows that words and phrases must be translated according to their meaning in the context in which they appear.

what is best: This refers to things that are truly good, things that are very important and worthwhile. This can include things people do, say and believe. Try to make it clear that the believers are to choose that which is very good.

1:10b

and may be pure and blameless for the day of Christ,

- so that you will be free from evil and without blame from now until Christ returns.
- I pray this in order that you will be good and innocent people from now until Christ returns.

and: At the beginning of 1:10b there is a Greek word hina that means “that” or “in order that.” The BSB translates this word as and. This is a different Greek word than the Greek phrase eis to at the beginning of 1:10a, which the BSB translates as “so that.”

There are three basic interpretations as to what ideas the author was relating when he used the Greek connecting word hina here at the beginning of 1:10b:

1. hina shows the purpose or intended result of the preceding clause. For example:

you will choose what is the right thing to do so that you may be genuinely good and not do anything wrong...” (NJB, NASB, NET, NLT, CEV)

1. hina shows another result (besides choosing what is best) of love abounding together with knowledge. (BSB, RSV, NIV)
2. hina shows another thing Paul prayed for. For example:

I pray that you will know more about what God is really like and will be able to tell the difference between right and wrong, and I pray that you may be genuinely good and not do anything wrong...” (NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

pure: The Greek word translated pure means “separate from evil, innocent, free from wrong.”

blameless: The Greek word translated blameless means “without offense or guilt.”

The words that the BSB translates as “pure” and blameless have almost the same meaning. Perhaps “pure” may emphasize internal goodness and purity, and blameless may emphasize outward actions. However, in some languages it may not be possible to use two separate words. If this is true in your language, you could use one term and add a word like “completely” to give extra emphasis. So you could translate this part of the verse as “completely pure” or “completely free from evil.”

for: The Greek word *eis* that the BSB translates as for can have one of two meanings:

1. Many English translations state that Paul hoped the Philippians would be pure and blameless until Christ returns. These versions tend to use the word “until” or a word with a similar meaning. This also implies that they (and other believers) would continue to be pure and blameless after he returns. (NIV, NASB, GW, NLT, KJV)
2. for/on: Paul hoped that the Philippians would be blameless at the time of Christ’s return. These versions tend to use a word such as “for” or “on”. For example:

you will be free from all impurity and blame on the Day of Christ (GNT) (BSB, GNT, RSV, NJB, CEV, NEB, NET, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

the day of Christ: See the note on 1:6b.

Philippians 1:11

Section 1:3–11: Paul thanked God for the Philippians and prayed for them

In 1:3–11 Paul thanked God for the Philippian believers. He told them that he prayed for them and loved them very much.

Paragraph 1:9–11

Paul prayed that the Philippians would love one another more and more, and would be pure and blameless so that other people would honor and praise God.

1:11a

filled with the fruit of righteousness

- As a tree produces fruit, so you will produce righteous deeds

- That is, I pray that you will be characterized by good qualities and actions

filled with the fruit of righteousness: This further explains the meaning of being “pure” and “blameless.” While “pure” and “blameless” imply the absence of sinful thoughts and actions, filled with the fruit of righteousness implies the presence of good thoughts and actions. Some translations (for example, GNT) begin a new sentence with this phrase. For example:

Then you will be filled...

The idea of filled is figurative in this verse. It means “to be characterized by.” You may not be able to keep this figure of speech. Ways to translate this verb non-figuratively will be discussed after the note on fruit of righteousness.

fruit of righteousness: The expression fruit of righteousness can be understood in two ways:

1. fruit that consists of righteousness; righteousness is used in an ethical sense and refers to right conduct/behavior. (GNT, CEV, NCV)
2. fruit that is produced by righteousness; righteousness is used in a legal sense and refers to a believer’s right standing before God (GW, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

General Comment on 1:11a

In many languages if the expression “filled with the fruit of righteousness” is translated literally it will not give the correct meaning. If this is true in your language, you should translate this part of the verse nonfiguratively. For example:

righteousness will characterize all you do

you will behave in a completely righteous manner

1:11b

that comes through Jesus Christ,

- through the power of Jesus Christ.
- because Jesus Christ is helping/enabling you,

through Jesus Christ: This means that a person’s life is righteous because of the power that Jesus Christ gives. A believer can only be righteous because Jesus Christ helps him to be.

General Comment on 1:11a–b

In some languages it may be better to make Jesus Christ the subject of 1:11a–b. For example:

Jesus Christ will fill you with the fruit of righteousness.

Jesus Christ will help you to do every good/right thing.

1:11c

to the glory and praise of God.

- This will bring honor and praise to God.
- so that when people see your good deeds, they will honor God and praise him.

to the glory and praise of God: Biblical scholars do not agree about how this phrase relates to the rest of the verse. There are three possible interpretations:

1. It relates to the phrase “filled with the fruit of righteousness.” For example: “I pray that you may be filled with the fruit of righteousness for the glory and praise of God.” (GNT, NLT, GW, CEV, NCV)
2. It connects with Paul’s prayer in 1:9a–11b. For example: “I pray that all of this may happen in you for the glory and praise of God.” This seems to be the interpretation of the NIV. (NIV)
3. It relates to all of Paul’s thanksgiving and prayer (1:3–11) and is like a doxology. For example: “I end my thanksgiving and prayer with the desire that people glorify and praise God.”

Many English versions do not make a clear choice. However, it is recommended that you follow option (1), which has the best support among versions and commentators.

to the glory...of God: This means that the purpose is that people would honor God and tell others that he is great. See “glory”, sense A3 in KBT.

to the...praise of God: This means that the purpose is that people would thank God and speak well of him. Praise comes from those who are grateful that God is great and that he blesses them.

In some languages it may be necessary to combine the ideas of “glory” and praise into one phrase. Consider how, in your language, you would refer to giving respect to an honored guest, such as a king or a president. Some of those words may be appropriate in this phrase.

This phrase is at the end of Paul’s prayer, and in some languages it is necessary to clearly show where the prayer ends. In English we do this with “Amen.” You may need to end this verse with a phrase like:

That is what I am praying for you.

Philippians 1:12

Section 1:12–18d: Paul rejoiced that people continued to preach the gospel even though he was in prison

Paul explained in 1:12–18d the way the fact that he was in prison had affected other people. Paul believed that God was working in everything that happened to him. He saw something good happening when people preached about Christ, even when they preached for the wrong reasons. Some of the Christians apparently taught about Christ because they were jealous of Paul’s reputation as a teacher. But Paul was still happy because people were telling the good news about Christ.

Paragraph 1:12–14

Paul wrote that even though he was in prison, the gospel message was spreading.

1:12a

Now I want you to know, brothers,

- ¶ Brothers and sisters in Christ, I want to be sure that you know
- ¶ You who like me believe in Christ, it is important for you to know

Now I want you to know: Paul pointed out that things had happened opposite to what the Philippians might have expected.

Now: Paul is starting a new subject or topic. In Greek this is marked by a particle, *de*, that the BSB has translated *Now*. If in your language there is a way to mark a transition or change of topic, you should use it here. Several English translations have left it implicit (NRSV, REB, GNT), and this may be acceptable in your language. However, avoid translating the word literally. Its sense here is not as a time word.

brothers: The term *brothers* occurs here and also in 3:1, 3:13, 3:17, 4:1, 4:8. It refers to other Christians, fellow believers, not to literal brothers. You might translate this as “brothers and sisters,” “older and younger siblings” or “relatives.” But in some languages people use kinship terms only in the literal sense. If this is true in your language, a phrase such as “fellow Christians” or “fellow believers” would be better here. Whatever term you choose should be used consistently throughout the Bible whenever *brothers* is used to address other Christians.

In some languages it is necessary to put a term of address such as *brothers* at the beginning of the sentence. You should place this term wherever it is most natural in your language.

1:12b

that my circumstances have actually served to advance the gospel.

- that the bad things that have happened to me have caused more people to believe the good news.

my circumstances have actually served to advance the gospel: The bad things that had happened to Paul did not prevent people from hearing the good news about Jesus Christ. Rather, they caused more people to hear the good news.

my circumstances: Paul did not specify what events he was thinking of here. Perhaps he was referring to his imprisonment generally or to something more specific. However, there is no way to be certain, so you should not try to make this event explicit here.

Philippians 1:13

Section 1:12–18d: Paul rejoiced that people continued to preach the gospel even though he was in prison

Paul explained in 1:12–18d the way the fact that he was in prison had affected other people. Paul believed that God was working in everything that happened to him. He saw something good happening when people preached about Christ, even when they preached for the wrong reasons. Some of the Christians apparently taught about Christ because they were jealous of Paul's reputation as a teacher. But Paul was still happy because people were telling the good news about Christ.

Paragraph 1:12–14

Paul wrote that even though he was in prison, the gospel message was spreading.

1:13

As a result, it has become clear throughout the whole palace guard and to everyone else that I am in chains for Christ.

- As a result of what has happened to me all the soldiers who are guarding the emperor's palace and all the others here know that I am in prison because I serve Christ.

As a result: Paul gave a specific example of how the gospel had advanced as a result of what had happened to him (1:12).

the whole palace guard: The palace guard was a group of soldiers who guarded the official houses of governors and other important Roman officials. The term was especially used for those who guarded the palace of the Roman emperor in Rome itself. This suggests that Paul was probably writing from Rome.

everyone else: It is not clear to whom this refers. Paul may have been thinking about other prisoners or other servants in the place where he was imprisoned. Perhaps he was referring to other important people in the palace or even to all the people that he had met in that city. You should not try to make this more explicit.

chains: This is a figurative term referring to Paul's imprisonment (see note on 1:7b–c).

for Christ: You could translate this phrase several ways. For example:

because I follow Christ

because I am a servant of Christ

because I preach about Christ

Philippians 1:14

Section 1:12–18d: Paul rejoiced that people continued to preach the gospel even though he was in prison

Paul explained in 1:12–18d the way the fact that he was in prison had affected other people. Paul believed that God was working in everything that happened to him. He saw something good happening when people preached about Christ, even when they preached for the wrong reasons. Some of the Christians apparently taught about Christ because they were jealous of Paul's reputation as a teacher. But Paul was still happy because people were telling the good news about Christ.

Paragraph 1:12–14

Paul wrote that even though he was in prison, the gospel message was spreading.

1:14a

And most of the brothers,

- As for most of the believers here,

In the Greek this verse begins with a conjunction that could be translated as “and”. This verse tells another good thing that happened because Paul was in prison. If you need to make this connection clear, you could begin with a phrase like: “And that is not all.”

the brothers: See note on 1:12a.

1:14b

confident in the Lord by my chains,

- because I am in prison, the Lord has caused them to be confident that he will help them.

confident: This comes from the Greek word *peithō*. The form of the verb used here means “to be confi-

dent” or “to trust.” The BSB translates this same Greek word as “confident” in 1:6 and “trust” in 2:24, and as “convinced” in 1:25. It is recommended that you translate it with a term meaning “have been made confident” or “have been given confidence.”

in the Lord: It is not clear in the Greek text which part of the verse this phrase connects to. There are two possibilities:

1. It should be connected to what follows it in the Greek text, that is, the verb that the BSB translates as “confident.” In this case the phrase “confident in the Lord” would mean “the Lord has caused them to be confident.” The brothers were more bold to tell about Christ because of this confidence that the Lord had given them. The majority of commentators support this interpretation. (RSV, GNT, NASB, NET, GW, NCV)
2. It should be connected to what precedes it in the Greek text, that is, “the brothers.” This would then mean “believing brothers” or “Christians.” (NIV, KJV, REB, NLT, CEV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

by my chains: Paul said that his chains had given the other Christians courage, but he did not say how this was done. He may have meant that they gained courage by seeing the way God had helped him while he was in prison.

1:14c

now dare more greatly to speak the word without fear.

- They have become brave enough to speak the word of God without fear.
- And they are proclaiming more and more boldly the message that God gave us^(incl) and are not afraid to do so.

more greatly: In the Greek this is a verb form, literally “much more to dare.” The believers became much bolder/braver than they had been before. They knew some people were against the Christian message. That is why Paul was in prison. But when they saw Paul continue to speak about his Savior even though he was in prison, this increased their courage. If you have a verb meaning “to be brave,” you may use it here. In some languages it will be necessary to use an adjective meaning “bold, courageous” or an adverb meaning “boldly, courageously.”

the word: Some Greek texts have the full phrase “the word of God” and other Greek texts have simply the word. However, these two phrases clearly refer to the same thing, that is, “the message from God.” There-

fore, it is recommended that you include the words “of God.”

without fear: This describes the way in which the believers preached. You may need to translate this as a separate sentence at the end of the verse. For example:

They are not afraid.

In some languages it may be necessary to provide an object specifying of whom the brothers were not afraid. If this is the case in your language, you may supply an object such as “unbelievers.”

General Comment on 1:14

In some languages it may be best to give the reason (1:14b) at the end of the verse. For example:

The Lord has caused the brothers to be more confident and to preach the word of God more boldly and without fear. This has happened because I have been in prison.

Philippians 1:15

Section 1:12–18d: Paul rejoiced that people continued to preach the gospel even though he was in prison

Paul explained in 1:12–18d the way the fact that he was in prison had affected other people. Paul believed that God was working in everything that happened to him. He saw something good happening when people preached about Christ, even when they preached for the wrong reasons. Some of the Christians apparently taught about Christ because they were jealous of Paul’s reputation as a teacher. But Paul was still happy because people were telling the good news about Christ.

Paragraph 1:15–18d

Some Christians were jealous of Paul, but this caused them to proclaim the good news more, and so he was rejoicing.

1:15–17 contains a figure of speech called a “chiasmus.” A chiasmus is the ordering of information in a mirror image, like the pattern a-b-b-a. The chiasmus in 1:15–17 refers to two groups of people. The first part of the passage refers to the same people as the fourth part does, and the second part refers to the same people as the third part does. Here is an example using summary statements:

See “General Comment” on 1:15–17 regarding the possible need to reorder this section in your translation.

1:15a

It is true that some preach Christ out of envy and rivalry,

- ¶ Certainly some people preach about Christ because they envy me and want to appear more important than me.
- ¶ On the one hand, some of these believers proclaim the message about Christ because they are jealous of me, and they want people to follow them rather than me.

It is true that: This translates a Greek particle used at the beginning of a contrast. Another such particle is used in 1:15b for the other half of the contrast (see “but”). Together they mean “on the one hand...on the other hand.” Do not try to translate this statement as referring to the truth of Paul’s words. Instead, use an expression that indicates the first half of a contrast.

some preach Christ out of envy and rivalry: Paul referred here and in 1:17 to certain Christians who were causing him trouble. These are probably some of the same people mentioned in 1:15. Apparently they wanted to have more followers than Paul.

preach Christ: This means to preach about Christ. Despite their wrong motives these people were believers who were announcing the message about Jesus Christ. Since Paul rejoiced that they were preaching, it appears that what they were saying about Christ was true (1:18d).

out of: This means “because of, motivated by” and introduces the reasons why some people were preaching about Christ.

envy: This refers to feeling ill-will toward someone because of his good fortune. These people were jealous of what Paul had done and that he had been more successful than they were.

rivalry: The Greek word that the BSB translates rivalry refers to the strife that envy causes. These people wanted to gain more disciples than Paul had. They wanted to surpass him and appear to others as more successful and important.

1:15b

but others out of goodwill.

- But others of the believers proclaim the message about Christ intending to help me spread the gospel.
- But on the other hand, some other believers are preaching with a right attitude.

but: This represents the second of two Greek particles that indicate the contrast between the two groups of people. See the “It is true that” note in 1:15a.

out of: This again means “because of, motivated by.” The reason for their preaching was these believers’ goodwill toward Paul.

goodwill: The word goodwill means that these believers liked Paul and wanted to help him spread the gospel. They were preaching with good intentions.

One way you could translate 1:15b is:

Others preach about Christ to help me and the work of the gospel.

Philippians 1:16

Section 1:12–18d: Paul rejoiced that people continued to preach the gospel even though he was in prison

Paul explained in 1:12–18d the way the fact that he was in prison had affected other people. Paul believed that God was working in everything that happened to him. He saw something good happening when people preached about Christ, even when they preached for the wrong reasons. Some of the Christians apparently taught about Christ because they were jealous of Paul’s reputation as a teacher. But Paul was still happy because people were telling the good news about Christ.

Paragraph 1:15–18d

Some Christians were jealous of Paul, but this caused them to proclaim the good news more, and so he was rejoicing.

1:15–17 contains a figure of speech called a “chiasmus.” A chiasmus is the ordering of information in a mirror image, like the pattern a-b-b-a. The chiasmus in 1:15–17 refers to two groups of people. The first part of the passage refers to the same people as the fourth part does, and the second part refers to the same people as the third part does. Here is an example using summary statements:

See “General Comment” on 1:15–17 regarding the possible need to reorder this section in your translation.

1:16

The latter do so in love, knowing that I am appointed for the defense of the gospel.

- These people preach because they love me and because they know that God has placed me here in prison to defend the good news about Christ.
- These people love me and they know that the reason why God allowed people to imprison me was so that I should have opportunities to explain why the gospel is true. And that is why they are preaching about Christ themselves.

The latter: This refers to the same group of people Paul was talking about in 1:15b, that is, those who preached about Christ because of their goodwill toward Paul.

in: This is a different Greek word from that translated by the BSB as “out of” in 1:15a–b. However, it has a similar meaning (“out of, from”) and gives the cause of the actions.

love: The main meaning of love here is that these believers loved Paul, and if you need to supply an object you should supply “me.” This does not mean that they did not also love Christ and the gospel.

I am appointed: There are two ways to understand the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as I am appointed:

1. God placed Paul where he was—in prison. He wanted him to be a witness there. (NIV, RSV, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, NET)
2. God appointed Paul to the ministry of preaching and defending the gospel, wherever he went. (BSB, GNT, NJB, NASB)

The first interpretation seems to fit the context best, so it is recommended that you follow it (1).

defense: For ideas on translating defense see the note on 1:7b–c about “defending the gospel.”

Philippians 1:17

Section 1:12–18d: Paul rejoiced that people continued to preach the gospel even though he was in prison

Paul explained in 1:12–18d the way the fact that he was in prison had affected other people. Paul believed that God was working in everything that happened to him. He saw something good happening when people preached about Christ, even when they preached for the wrong reasons. Some of the Christians apparently taught about Christ because they were jealous of Paul’s reputation as a teacher. But Paul was still happy because people were telling the good news about Christ.

Paragraph 1:15–18d

Some Christians were jealous of Paul, but this caused them to proclaim the good news more, and so he was rejoicing.

1:15–17 contains a figure of speech called a “chiasmus.” A chiasmus is the ordering of information in a mirror image, like the pattern a-b-b-a. The chiasmus in 1:15–17 refers to two groups of people. The first part of the passage refers to the same people as the fourth part does, and the second part refers to the same people as

the third part does. Here is an example using summary statements:

See “General Comment” on 1:15–17 regarding the possible need to reorder this section in your translation.

1:17a

The former, however, preach Christ out of selfish ambition, not sincerely,

- But those who are jealous of me proclaim the good news about Christ because they want to become more important than I am. They do not have the right reasons.
- But the first group of people do not preach about Christ from good motives but for selfish reasons.

The former, however: This refers back to the group of people Paul was talking about in 1:15a, that is, those who preached about Christ because they envied him and were his rivals. See comments on chiasmus at the beginning of this paragraph.

out of: This is the same Greek word that the BSB translated as “in” in 1:16 and indicates the cause of these people’s preaching.

selfish ambition: The Greek word translated by the BSB as selfish ambition is also found in Romans 2:8; Galatians 5:20 and 2 Corinthians 12:20. Here Paul meant that these people wanted to be important. They wanted people to respect them and obey them rather than Paul, so they tried to get more people to follow them than Paul had.

not sincerely: These people preached for the wrong reason, selfishly, for their own advancement rather than for the good of others and the glory of God.

In some languages it may be clearer to reverse the ideas of not sincerely and “selfish ambition.” For example:

They do not proclaim the message about Christ sincerely, but they preach about him with selfish ambition.

1:17b

supposing that they can add to the distress of my chains.

- They wrongly expect that they will add to the sorrows I am already having here in prison.
- They intend to increase my problems here in prison.

supposing that they can add to the distress of my chains: The Greek literally says “thinking to raise up affliction.” This means that these jealous believers intended to cause trouble for Paul. However, it is implied

that what they thought was wrong. Paul continued to rejoice because the gospel was preached.

they can add to the distress of my chains: This refers not to physical suffering but to inward suffering. These rival preachers probably thought that their success would make Paul jealous of them.

of my chains: As in 1:7, this means “in prison.”

General Comment on 1:15–17

These verses form a chiasmus, as explained in the introductory note to this paragraph. If your language does not naturally use chiasmus, you should use what is a natural order in your language. For example:

^{15a}Some preach about Christ out of envy. ^{17a}They do so because they have selfish ambition.... ^{15b}Others preach about Christ out of goodwill. ¹⁶They preach because they love me....

Philippians 1:18

Section 1:12–18d: Paul rejoiced that people continued to preach the gospel even though he was in prison

Paul explained in 1:12–18d the way the fact that he was in prison had affected other people. Paul believed that God was working in everything that happened to him. He saw something good happening when people preached about Christ, even when they preached for the wrong reasons. Some of the Christians apparently taught about Christ because they were jealous of Paul’s reputation as a teacher. But Paul was still happy because people were telling the good news about Christ.

Paragraph 1:15–18d

Some Christians were jealous of Paul, but this caused them to proclaim the good news more, and so he was rejoicing.

1:15–17 contains a figure of speech called a “chiasmus.” A chiasmus is the ordering of information in a mirror image, like the pattern a-b-b-a. The chiasmus in 1:15–17 refers to two groups of people. The first part of the passage refers to the same people as the fourth part does, and the second part refers to the same people as the third part does. Here is an example using summary statements:

See “General Comment” on 1:15–17 regarding the possible need to reorder this section in your translation.

1:18a

What then is the issue?

- But does this matter?
- But is this important? Not at all.

- But it does not matter very much.

What then is the issue?: The Greek here is an idiomatic expression something like the English slang “So what?” It does not expect an answer. In the BSB it is translated as a rhetorical question implying the answer “It doesn’t really matter.” Paul meant that he was not disturbed and troubled (as his rivals expected he would be) because some believers were preaching the gospel out of envy. Instead, he was just glad that they were preaching the good news.

If you have rhetorical questions in your language and you can use one here, make sure the answer is clear to the reader. If it is not clear, you may need to add an explicit answer, such as “It doesn’t matter.” Or, you may need to avoid the rhetorical question (see the third Meaning Line in the Display).

1:18b

Just this: that in every way, whether by false motives or true,

- Whether they do it for the wrong reasons or for the right reasons, the important thing is that either way
- All that matters is that, whether they do it sincerely or not, in both cases

that in every way: If your language uses different words to distinguish between two alternatives and more than two alternatives, you should choose the word indicating two alternatives.

whether by false motives or true: Some people were preaching the gospel for the wrong reasons and some for the right reasons.

false motives: The Greek word translated by the BSB as false motives means doing something just for appearance or show, or hiding the real reason for doing something. This refers to the people mentioned in 1:15a and 1:17.

true: The Greek word translated by the BSB as true is literally “in truth.” It refers to doing something for the reason you say you are doing it; that is, genuinely or sincerely. This refers to the people mentioned in 1:15b and 1:16.

1:18c

Christ is preached.

- the message about Christ is announced.
- they are still proclaiming the message about Christ.
- Christ is still the one they are preaching about.

Christ is preached: In some languages it will be necessary to use an active verb and supply a subject for the verb “preach.” If this is necessary for you, you should choose something that clearly refers back to

those about whom Paul had just been speaking. See second and third Meaning lines in the Display.

General Comment on 1:18a–d

In some languages it may be necessary to alter the order of the parts of the verse. Here are two sample translations:

^aBut this is not important. ^cWhat is important is that people are preaching the good news about Christ, ^bwhether they have the right reason or not. ^dAnd I am very glad about that.

^aThey are doing this, but I am not upset. ^bMaybe they are preaching because they want to help me, or maybe they are preaching because they don't want to help me. But either way ^dI am happy, ^cbecause they are preaching the good news about Christ.

Section 1:18e–26: Paul rejoiced because he expected that what was happening would lead to good, whether he lived or died

Paul wanted to bring honor to Christ whether he lived or died. He knew that dying and being with Christ would be the supreme good, but he also wanted to be with the Philippians to help them grow in their faith. And he expected that God would let him continue living and helping others.

Paragraph 1:18e–20

Paul rejoiced because he knew that the result of what was happening to him would be good, whether he continued to live or he died.

1:18d

And in this I rejoice.

- And for that reason I am happy.

1:18e

Yes, and I will continue to rejoice,

- ¶ Furthermore I will continue to be happy

Yes, and I will continue to rejoice: This phrase connects this section with the previous one. Paul was happy, not only because people were preaching the gospel, but also because he believed that what was happening to him would turn out for good.

Some translations put the phrase Yes, and I will continue to rejoice at the beginning of 1:19 rather than at the end of 1:18 (RSV, NJB). You should consider making this adjustment to the verse numbers if this is what your national language version does.

Philippians 1:19

Section 1:18e–26: Paul rejoiced because he expected that what was happening would lead to good, whether he lived or died

Paul wanted to bring honor to Christ whether he lived or died. He knew that dying and being with Christ would be the supreme good, but he also wanted to be with the Philippians to help them grow in their faith. And he expected that God would let him continue living and helping others.

Paragraph 1:18e–20

Paul rejoiced because he knew that the result of what was happening to him would be good, whether he continued to live or he died.

1:19a

because I know that

- because I know that

1:19b

through your prayers and the provision of the Spirit of Jesus Christ,

- because you are praying for me and because Jesus Christ's Holy Spirit will help me,

through your prayers: This refers to the fact that the Philippians had been praying for Paul. So you could also translate this as:

because you are asking God to help me

the Spirit of Jesus Christ: Commentators agree that the Spirit of Jesus Christ refers to the Holy Spirit. Similar expressions occur in Acts 16:9; Romans 8:9 and 1 Peter 1:11. Your translation should be clear enough that those who read your translation do not think that the Spirit of Jesus Christ is different from the Holy Spirit. They are two names for the same Spirit. You could translate the Spirit of Jesus Christ as “the Spirit who comes from Jesus Christ” or as “the Spirit sent by Jesus Christ.”

1:19c

my distress will turn out for my deliverance.

- this will result in God saving me.
- the result of what is happening will be that God will rescue me from sin.

my distress will turn out for my deliverance: These words are a quotation from Job 13:16 in the Septuagint, the Greek translation of the Old Testament.

my distress: The Greek word *touto*, which the BSB translates as my distress, literally means “this.” Paul probably had the whole situation in mind. “This” refers

to what was happening to Paul at the time he was writing the letter, that is, the fact that he was in prison and waiting for a court trial, and also to the fact that people were preaching about Christ.

will turn out for: This is an idiom meaning “will lead to” or “will result in.”

my deliverance: The Greek word that the BSB translates deliverance is *sōtēria*, the word often translated “salvation.” So there are two ways to interpret *sōtēria* here:

1. It means “salvation.” Paul was saying that the result of what was happening would be that God would save him. Paul would persevere in the faith and would be saved from sin, evil, Satan’s attacks and final spiritual death. Whether he lived or died, the enemies of the gospel would not destroy him. Many commentaries follow this option. (KJV, NJB)
2. It means deliverance. Paul was confident that the authorities would release him from prison. So he would be delivered or set free from his imprisonment and would not be put to death (at least at that time). (GNT, RSV, NIV, GW, NET, CEV, NCV)

Interpretation (1) seems to fit better here because of the context of 1:20. Paul was determined to honor Christ, whether it was by the way he lived or the way he died. Paul evidently considered death a genuine possibility, and interpretation (2) does not appear to allow for this. Therefore, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul believed that the result of what was happening to him (being in prison and facing a court trial) would be that God would bring him safely through both life and death to complete salvation in the presence of Jesus.

General Comment on 1:19b–c

In some languages it may be better to reorder 1:19 by putting 1:19c before 1:19b. You could translate it as:

^aI know that ^cthis will result in God saving me
^bbecause of your prayers and the help of the Spirit
 who comes from Jesus Christ.

Philippians 1:20

Section 1:18e–26: Paul rejoiced because he expected that what was happening would lead to good, whether he lived or died

Paul wanted to bring honor to Christ whether he lived or died. He knew that dying and being with Christ would be the supreme good, but he also wanted to be with the Philippians to help them grow in their faith.

And he expected that God would let him continue living and helping others.

Paragraph 1:18e–20

Paul rejoiced because he knew that the result of what was happening to him would be good, whether he continued to live or he died.

1:20a

I eagerly expect and hope that I will in no way be ashamed,

- I anticipate eagerly and hope that I will not be disgraced in any way.
- I am keenly expecting and hoping that I will never have to be ashamed of what I have done.

I eagerly expect and hope: There are two ways to interpret the Greek here:

1. expect and hope are two related but separate concepts. (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, NASB, NJB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)
2. expect and hope are parts of the same concept, where one part modifies the other. You could translate this as “I eagerly and hopefully expect...” (NET, REB)

Interpretation (1) has stronger support in commentaries and English versions and is recommended.

eagerly expect: The Greek term that the BSB translates as eagerly expect can also mean “eagerly desire.” However, most scholars agree that the meaning here is “eagerly expect.”

hope: The word hope here refers not to what Paul wished for but to what he confidently expected.

I will in no way be ashamed: The Greek word that the BSB translated as ashamed can mean one of two things:

1. “put to shame, disgraced.” Paul hoped he would not do anything that would bring him into disgrace. He wanted to be approved by God. Specifically, he trusted that he would continue to please God by glorifying Christ. (NASB, GNT, GW, CEV, NCV, REB, NLT)
2. “feel ashamed.” Paul hoped that he would never be ashamed of Christ and the gospel. He expected that he would continue to be bold in proclaiming the gospel of Christ.

The BSB, NIV, RSV and NET are ambiguous here. But it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul did not want to disappoint God. He trusted God would give him courage to keep on doing what was right (see the rest of 1:20). In this way God would protect him from disgrace.

1:20b**but will have complete boldness**

- I want/expect to speak to the authorities without being at all afraid
- I want to speak out boldly

will have complete boldness: This is literally “in all boldness.” It may be necessary for you to translate boldness or “courage” with a verb or adjective. For example:

will be brave enough to...

boldness: Most commentators agree that the boldness Paul was concerned about was the boldness to speak about Christ during his trial. You could translate this as:

I will speak boldly/bravely.

1:20c**so that now as always Christ will be exalted in my body,**

- so that, as I always have, I will continue to bring honor to Christ by the way I act,
- so that everything I do will bring glory to Christ, as it always has,

now as always: This means that Paul hoped to go on speaking as boldly for Christ as he had in the past.

Christ will be exalted: The Greek does not say who would exalt Christ, and there are two ways to understand what Paul was saying here:

1. God, Christ himself, or the Spirit would bring honor to Christ through Paul. People would praise and honor Christ when they saw how Paul served God while he was alive or by the way he died because he believed in Christ. In this way God would glorify Christ through Paul’s body. (REB)
2. It was Paul himself who would exalt Christ. For example:

with my whole being I shall bring honor to Christ (GNT) (GW, CEV, NLT, NCV)

Most translations do not explicitly say who would exalt Christ. If you can use the passive (be exalted), that would be appropriate. But if you must use an active verb with an explicit subject, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of commentators and say, “God will exalt Christ.”

in my body: The phrase in my body is a figure of speech meaning “through all I do.” Paul wanted to honor Christ whether he lived or died. In many languages it may not be possible to translate literally and give this meaning. If that is true in your language, you could translate this phrase:

in everything I say and do

with my whole being

1:20d**whether by life or by death.**

- whether it is by the way I live, or whether it is by the way I die.

by life or by death: By this phrase Paul explained what he meant by “in my body.” He included two ideas:

General Comment on 1:20

1. If I continue to live, I want to honor Christ by the way I live.
2. If I die, I want to honor Christ by the way I die.

In some languages it may be necessary to reorder the words of 1:20. This can help to clarify what Paul meant here:

I earnestly expect and hope that I will be brave enough to continue to glorify Christ by the way I live and the way I die, as I always have done, so that I will not be ashamed.

Philippians 1:21**Section 1:18e–26: Paul rejoiced because he expected that what was happening would lead to good, whether he lived or died**

Paul wanted to bring honor to Christ whether he lived or died. He knew that dying and being with Christ would be the supreme good, but he also wanted to be with the Philippians to help them grow in their faith. And he expected that God would let him continue living and helping others.

Paragraph 1:21–26

Paul wanted very much to go and be with Christ, but it was more necessary for the Philippian believers that he continue living.

1:21a**For to me, to live is Christ,**

- ¶ For as for me, I live only to honor Christ,
- ¶ This is because as far as I am concerned, the purpose of living is to glorify Christ,

For: This word introduces the reason why Paul hoped that he would always glorify Christ. It means “since” or “because.”

to me: In Greek this is an emphatic pronoun. In this verse it is put at the beginning of the sentence for added emphasis. It indicates a change in topic. Paul was now focusing on his personal situation. If you have emphatic pronouns in your language, you may be able to use one here.

to live is Christ: In Greek this is a short and dramatic statement. For Paul, the whole purpose of being alive was to know Christ, to love him, to serve him and to honor him. In some languages, however, a literal translation of the phrase to live is Christ will be meaningless or it may even have a wrong meaning. If this is a problem in your language, it may be possible to say:

If I continue to live it will be to honor Christ.

The meaning of my life is to know Christ.

1:21b and to die is gain.

- and when I die, it will be even better than living on earth!
- and when I die, it will be better than if I continue living!

to die is gain: Paul meant that for him to die would be better than continuing to live because then he would be with Christ. However, if you translate the phrase to die is gain literally, your readers may not understand this. You could restate it as:

dying will be even better for me

Other possible translations that include more implicit information are:

when I die, that will be better for me because then I will be with Christ

when I die, it will result in something that is better than living on earth.

Philippians 1:22

Section 1:18e–26: Paul rejoiced because he expected that what was happening would lead to good, whether he lived or died

Paul wanted to bring honor to Christ whether he lived or died. He knew that dying and being with Christ would be the supreme good, but he also wanted to be with the Philippians to help them grow in their faith. And he expected that God would let him continue living and helping others.

Paragraph 1:21–26

Paul wanted very much to go and be with Christ, but it was more necessary for the Philippian believers that he continue living.

1:22–24

In 1:22–24 Paul discussed the advantages of dying and the advantages of living. He was making an emotional statement. He said that he deeply loved Christ and the Philippians. So he wanted very much to be with Christ in heaven, yet he also wanted to be with the Philippian believers on earth. But he knew that he could not do both at the same time. So it was very hard for him to know what would be best.

1:22

The grammar of 1:22 in the Greek is difficult, perhaps because Paul was expressing himself emotionally. The verse has an “if...then” structure, but it is not clear where the “if” clause ends. There are two possibilities:

1. The “if” clause covers only the words “if I go on living in the body.” For example: “If I continue to live in the body, then that means fruitful labor for me. I do not know which to choose”. (RSV, NIV, NET, REB, NASB, NLT, NCV, GW)
2. The “if” clause also covers the concept of fruitful labor. For example: “If continuing to live means fruitful labor for me, then I do not know which I will choose”. (GNT, NJB, CEV)

The difference in meaning between the two interpretations is actually very small, but the first one is recommended (1).

1:22a

But if I go on living in the body, this will mean fruitful labor for me.

- But if I continue to live in this body, I will be able to do productive work for Christ.
- But if I keep living in this world, I will have useful work to do.

living in the body: The Greek word that the BSB translated as body literally means “flesh.” Paul was referring to staying alive on earth in his present phys-

ical body. One way to translate this is as “living in this world.” See “flesh”, sense A2 in KBT.

fruitful labor: The Greek is literally “fruit of work” and refers to work that has useful results, work that is productive and worthwhile. Paul was specifically thinking about helping more people to know Christ and helping the Philippians and others to continue growing in grace. Some ways to translate the phrase “fruitful labor for me” are:

I can continue to get results from the work I am doing.

I will be able to help more people.

1:22b

So what shall I choose? I do not know.

- But I do not know what I prefer/want, that is, to continue to live or to die.

So: Although the BSB translates it as So, the Greek connecting word, *kai*, means “and, yet, but.” It can show either continuation or contrast. Here it may indicate:

1. the beginning of a further independent or even contrasting thought. (NIV, RSV, GW, NLT, NCV, REB)
2. the continuation of the thought of the earlier part of the verse. (BSB, NET)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1).

what shall I choose: You could restate this as “Which do I prefer?” Paul was not trying to decide what would happen to him. Only God could do this. Paul was trying to decide which of God’s choices would be better. He explained these two choices further in 1:23–24.

I do not know: The Greek verb *gnōrizō* has been interpreted in two ways:

1. It means “know, perceive.” This is the common meaning in most classical Greek literature. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, NASB, GW, NCV, CEV, NJB, KJV)
2. It means “make known, declare, tell.” This is the most common meaning elsewhere in the New Testament, and some commentators say that is what it also means here.

Although RSV and REB translate it as “I cannot tell,” this expression can be an English idiom that means “I do not know” or “I cannot decide.” So it is not possible to be certain which interpretation these two versions follow.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Philippians 1:23

Section 1:18e–26: Paul rejoiced because he expected that what was happening would lead to good, whether he lived or died

Paul wanted to bring honor to Christ whether he lived or died. He knew that dying and being with Christ would be the supreme good, but he also wanted to be with the Philippians to help them grow in their faith. And he expected that God would let him continue living and helping others.

Paragraph 1:21–26

Paul wanted very much to go and be with Christ, but it was more necessary for the Philippian believers that he continue living.

1:23a

I am torn between the two.

- I am uncertain as to which of the two I prefer.
- It is difficult for me to decide between the two.

Paul was not thinking about killing himself in this verse. He was not the one who would decide whether he lived or died. God would decide that. Even the Roman court could only put Paul to death if God permitted it. But Paul had time in prison to think about dying, and here he expressed his deepest feelings about how he loved Christ and wanted to be with him.

I am torn between the two: A literal translation of the Greek is “I am constricted/enclosed by the two.” This means that it was hard for Paul to know which of these two things he preferred. The BSB has used an equivalent English idiom to translate this meaning. Another similar idiom is “I am pulled in two directions.” Some languages have idioms with this same meaning, but if you do not have such an idiom, it may be better to say simply:

It is hard for me to choose

I don’t know which would be better.

1:23b

I desire to depart and be with Christ, which is far better indeed.

- I want to leave this life and be with Christ in heaven, because that would be much better
- I want to die and live with Christ in heaven, because that would be much better than continuing to live on earth.

I desire to depart: This means “I want to leave this life,” that is, to die. Paul felt that it would be wonderful

if he could die and be with Jesus as a result of his trial in the Roman court. There may be some appropriate idiom in your language such as “I want to leave this life.” Or you may need to say simply “I wish to die.” However, make sure that your translation does not imply that Paul was discouraged and tired of living. He was not. He was happy to continue living and serving Christ (as 1:24 makes clear). But he would be even happier to go and be with Christ in heaven.

and be with Christ: Paul wanted to die in order to go and live with Christ in heaven. In some languages it may be necessary to avoid implying that Christ is dead. If when you test your translation, you discover that people think that Paul meant Christ was dead, you could say:

so that I can go and live with Christ in heaven

which is far better indeed: The phrase far better indeed shows how deeply Paul felt about this. If in your language you must make explicit what Paul considers dying to be better than, then you could translate it as “much better than continuing to live on earth.” If your language does not use comparative expressions like “better” or “better than,” you could perhaps translate this as “which would be extremely good.”

Philippians 1:24

Section 1:18e–26: Paul rejoiced because he expected that what was happening would lead to good, whether he lived or died

Paul wanted to bring honor to Christ whether he lived or died. He knew that dying and being with Christ would be the supreme good, but he also wanted to be with the Philippians to help them grow in their faith. And he expected that God would let him continue living and helping others.

Paragraph 1:21–26

Paul wanted very much to go and be with Christ, but it was more necessary for the Philippian believers that he continue living.

1:24

But it is more necessary for you that I remain in the body.

- But it is more important that I continue to live because you need me.

more necessary: Although Paul considered it better to die and be with Christ, he also recognized that at that time it was more important or urgent for Paul to continue living. The Philippian believers had a need for Paul’s advice and encouragement.

for you: That is, “for your sake” or “so I can help you.”

remain in the body: That is, “continue to live.” See 1:22a for the same phrase.

Philippians 1:25

Section 1:18e–26: Paul rejoiced because he expected that what was happening would lead to good, whether he lived or died

Paul wanted to bring honor to Christ whether he lived or died. He knew that dying and being with Christ would be the supreme good, but he also wanted to be with the Philippians to help them grow in their faith. And he expected that God would let him continue living and helping others.

Paragraph 1:21–26

Paul wanted very much to go and be with Christ, but it was more necessary for the Philippian believers that he continue living.

1:25a

Convinced of this,

- And so since I am sure that it is more important that I continue to live because you need me.

Convinced of this: Paul meant “Since I am sure of this....” Most commentators think that the word this refers to Paul’s conclusion in 1:24. The phrase would then mean “Since I am sure that it is more important for your sake that I continue to live.” See 1:25a in the Display.

1:25b

I know that I will remain and will continue with all of you

- I know that I will remain alive and that I will continue to be with you all
- I am sure that I will continue to live and that I will be able to continue my ministry/work/teaching among you all

will remain and will continue: The two Greek words that the BSB translates as remain and continue are from the same basic Greek word. Some commentators think that the word continue only adds emphasis to the word remain. But there are two main ideas here: Paul expected to remain alive and Paul expected to be able to remain with the Philippian believers. So in most languages this phrase is translated using two separate verbs. Some ways to do this are:

...my life will not end yet and I will still be with you

...I will continue living and I will still be able to help you.

1:25c

for your progress and joy in the faith,

- in order to help you to trust God more and to rejoice because you trust him

for your progress and joy in the faith: This means “[I shall remain with you] in order that your faith and your joy in the faith will progress.” Paul believed that he would continue living in order to help the Philippian believers believe more and be more joyful as they trusted Christ. Another way you could express this is:

I shall continue to live to help you believe more strongly and to help you rejoice because of your believing.

See also the Display for 1:25c.

progress...in the faith: Paul wanted to help the Philippians believe and trust more strongly in Christ.

joy in the faith: Paul also wanted them to have the joy that results from trusting Christ.

Philippians 1:26

Section 1:18e–26: Paul rejoiced because he expected that what was happening would lead to good, whether he lived or died

Paul wanted to bring honor to Christ whether he lived or died. He knew that dying and being with Christ would be the supreme good, but he also wanted to be with the Philippians to help them grow in their faith. And he expected that God would let him continue living and helping others.

Paragraph 1:21–26

Paul wanted very much to go and be with Christ, but it was more necessary for the Philippian believers that he continue living.

1:26

so that through my coming to you again your exultation in Christ Jesus will resound on account of me.

- so that when I am with you again you will boast even more about Christ Jesus because of me.
- My purpose is that you will praise Christ Jesus very much when you see that he has brought me back to you again.

so that: The phrase so that can be understood in two ways:

1. in order that: 1:26 is the purpose of 1:25;
2. with the result that: 1:26 is the result of 1:25.

The first interpretation is the most likely to be correct, and it is recommended that you follow it (1).

through my coming to you again: When Paul went to see them again, his visit would cause them to boast more about Christ. Compare with 1:27b.

your exultation in Christ Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as exultation here means “cause for glorying” or “reason for boasting or being proud.” In this context this is a good kind of boasting or being proud. Therefore, another way to translate your exultation in Christ Jesus is: “you will be proud/boast about Jesus Christ.”

In some languages it may be necessary to use a direct or indirect quote here. For example:

you will say, “Christ Jesus is very good”

you will say that Christ Jesus is very good

will resound: The phrase will resound means “will increase, will be more abundant.”

on account of me: The Greek phrase en emoi that the BSB translates as on account of me literally means “in me.” There are two ways to understand it here.

1. It means “because of me”; that is, the Philippians would boast about Jesus Christ because of Paul or on account of Paul. (BSB, NIV, REB, NET, GW, CEV, NJB)
2. It means “about me”; that is, the Philippians would boast about Paul or be proud of Paul. (GNT, NASB)

The first interpretation is recommended (1).

The phrase on account of me repeats in part the meaning of the phrase “through my being with you again.” If it is unnatural in your language to include both phrases, you may need to combine the two phrases into one. See 1:26 in the Display.

Philippians 1:27

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since they lived among many people who were opposed to the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith. They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

1:27a

Nevertheless, conduct yourselves in a manner worthy of the gospel of Christ.

- ¶ What is really important is that you act in a way that is appropriate for people who believe the good news about Christ.

Nevertheless: You could translate this as “no matter what happens” or “whatever may happen.”

conduct yourselves in a manner worthy of the gospel of Christ: Paul meant that he wanted the Philippians to behave in a way that was suitable to or conformed to the gospel. Their behavior should match their beliefs.

conduct yourselves: The Greek word that the BSB translates as conduct is a verb that literally means “to live as a citizen.” Here it is used figuratively and means “to behave/act.” Some commentators say it implies to live or behave as citizens of heaven or of the kingdom of God. However, you should not put this in your translation.

in a manner worthy of the gospel of Christ: You could translate this as:

[act/behave] as you should because you believe the gospel of Christ

[act/behave] as people who believe the gospel of Christ should act/behave.

the gospel of Christ: The phrase the gospel of Christ here could mean one of two things.

1. It could mean “the good news about Christ”. (GW, NLT, CEV)
2. It could mean “the good news from Christ,” “the good news that Christ gave us.”

The first meaning is recommended (1).

1:27b

Then, whether I come and see you or only hear about you in my absence,

- Do this whether I come and see you or whether I only hear about you while I am away from you,

Then: The Greek word hina that the BSB translates as Then means “in order that” or “so that.” So the following clause gives the purpose of Paul’s instructions in 1:27a. A new sentence could start here. For example:

I want you to do this in order that...

The word “this” in the above translation refers to 1:27a.

whether I come and see you or only hear about you in my absence: The Greek in this clause is difficult to understand. The two main ways to understand the Greek are:

1. It means “whether I come and see you, or whether being absent I hear about you.” In this interpretation the phrase only hear about you only goes with the second part of the clause in my absence. This interpretation requires the translator to supply “I will/may know that” in the next clause. (BSB, NIV, NLT, NJB).
2. It means “whether I come and see you, or whether I am absent, I will/may hear that...” In this interpretation the phrase only hear about you goes with both I come and see you and in my absence (RSV, GNT, NET, NCV, CEV, KJV, REB, NASB).

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul wanted to see the Philippians again, but even if he only heard news about them, he wanted them to be united in believing the good news.

come: Some languages use the directions “come” and “go” in different ways from Greek or English. So it may be necessary in these languages to use “go” or “return” here instead of come. Use the verb that is most natural for your language.

1:27c

I will know that you stand firm in one spirit,

- so that I will know that you are standing firm, united against all who oppose you.
- so that I will know that you are united together.

1:27d

contending side by side

- I will know that you are all struggling together against those who oppose the gospel

1:27c-d

I will know: This phrase is not in the Greek, but has been supplied in the BSB to make a natural English sentence.

stand firm: The Greek word translated by the BSB as stand firm literally just means “stand.” It is used figuratively here to mean “be steadfast.” Paul wanted the Philippians to be strong in their faith and not let others change their minds about trusting Christ.

in one spirit, contending side by side: The phrases in one spirit and side by side are not expressing different ideas. They both emphasize unity. It is important to get the meaning of unity in your translation. Possible phrases are:

with one common purpose

with one heart A few say the phrase “in one spirit” refers to the Holy Spirit, but there is little support for this view.

not divided

contending: The Greek here refers to striving or struggling together against a common enemy. Be careful that in your translation the word contending does not imply that the believers were to fight against each other. Paul did not say specify against whom the Philippians were to contend. It is, however, clear from the rest of the letter that people in Philippi, perhaps Jews, were opposing them. Do not try to specify who these enemies were unless it is necessary to do so in your language. If you do need to say something, you should use a general expression, for example, “against those who oppose the gospel.”

Obviously Paul did not mean that he wanted to hear that the Philippians were fighting people physically for the gospel. So avoid using a verb which would only refer to hitting or shooting someone. Here he was referring to speaking very strongly or very emotionally to another, or acting in a strong way but without physical fighting. See the note on 4:3b.

side by side: The Greek here is literally “with one soul.” Many translations understand this to refer to the way people think and translate this as “with one mind” (RSV, NET, KJV, NASB, REB).

1:27e

for the faith of the gospel,

- to defend what the good news about Christ teaches.
- to promote what the gospel tells us^(incl) about all that Christians believe.

for the faith of the gospel: This phrase appears only here in the New Testament. Paul urged the Philippians believers to energetically defend and proclaim the faith that the good news has brought them. They are to struggle for the sake of maintaining and preserving that faith.

faith: The Greek word *pistis*, faith, refers here to the things that Christians believe.

gospel: The gospel is the source or origin of that faith. The faith of Christians is based on the good news about Jesus Christ. See “gospel” in KBT.

Philippians 1:28

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since they lived among many people who were opposed to the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith. They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

1:28a

without being frightened in any way by those who oppose you.

- Do not be at all afraid of those people who are against you.

without being frightened: It may be helpful to translate this as a command. For example:

Do not have [any] fear [of those who oppose you.]

Do not [let your enemies] frighten you [at all.]

in any way: The phrase in any way gives emphasis. The GNT shows this emphasis by using two verbs:

don't be afraid...always be courageous (GNT)

Two translation suggestions that express this emphasis are:

Do not let your enemies find any way to frighten you.

Do not be afraid of them at all.

those who oppose you: This refers to people who were enemies of the gospel and therefore opposed those who believed in Christ. Possible translations are:

those who persecute you

those who cause you trouble

The enemies mentioned here in 1:27–28 were probably non-Christians who were persecuting the believers in Philippi as they had persecuted Paul when he was in Philippi (Acts 16).

1:28b

This is a clear sign of their destruction but of your salvation,

- By acting like this you will prove to them that God will destroy them and that he will save you.

This is a clear sign: In other words: “This is proof to your enemies.” The word This refers back to the phrase “without being frightened” in 1:28a. The believers were not afraid to be faithful to God even though they suffered. This fearlessness was a sign that God controlled their lives and therefore that those who opposed the believers were opposing God.

their destruction: This implies that God would eternally destroy them. The word destruction refers to spiritual ruin. It means that they would not live eternally with God.

of your salvation: This implies that God would give the Philippians eternal life.

It may be more natural in your language to reverse these last two clauses. For example:

God will save you but he will destroy them.

1:28c

and it is from God.

- God controls all of this.
- God causes all this to happen.

and it is from God: This can be understood in three main ways:

1. God was the one who caused all this to happen. In this case the word it (Greek touto) refers in a general way to all of 1:28, to the courage of the believers and what their courage proved. God caused them not to be afraid and so gave evidence that he would destroy the enemies and save the believers. (GNT, CEV, NRSV)
2. God is the one who gave the sign. The Greek word touto specifically refers back to the word “sign”. (BSB, RSV, NET, REB, GW)
3. God is the one who will save the believers and destroy their enemies. (NLT, NCV and NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Philippians 1:29

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since

they lived among many people who were opposed to the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith. They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

1:29

For it has been granted to you on behalf of Christ not only to believe in Him, but also to suffer for Him,

- For God has given you the privilege not only of believing in Christ but also of suffering because you believe in him.
- I say this because God has shown you favor by allowing you to suffer for Christ’s sake as well as to believe in him.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For joins the text in 1:29 to what Paul said in 1:27–28. It gives the reason for what Paul had just been saying there.

it has been granted to you: Commentators agree that the word granted implies that God had given the Philippian believers a special privilege or favor. God was being good to them by allowing them to suffer for Christ.

Some languages have different words for giving gifts and giving privileges. The choice of words may also depend on how the status (or importance) of the one who gives relates to the status of the one who receives. Consider how your people view the status of God in relation to the status of people.

on behalf of Christ: The phrase on behalf of Christ may relate to 1:29 in three ways. Therefore, there are three possible interpretations:

1. The phrase relates primarily to the word “suffer.” This can be expressed, for example, as “It has been granted to you to suffer for Christ, not only to believe in him.” Many commentators hold this view.
2. The phrase relates to both “believe” and “suffer.” This can be expressed, for example, as “It has been granted to you to believe in Christ and to suffer for him.” This is very close in meaning to the first interpretation. In fact, it is not possible to know which of these views a number of English versions follow. (GW, CEV, REB, NET, NLT)
3. The phrase relates to the phrase “it has been granted to you.” This can be expressed, for example, as “For Christ’s sake this has been granted to you: to believe in him and to suffer for him.” (NIV, RSV, KJV, NASB, NCV, NJB)

The first interpretation is recommended (1), but in translation there may be no difference between that and the second.

believe in Him: This means the same as “believe on him” or “put your trust in him.” You could also translate it as “trust him” or “believe what he says.”

suffer for Him: The phrase suffer for Him means that a person is persecuted because he believes in Christ. It means to experience pain (physical or emotional) for Christ’s sake.

It is possible to rephrase the whole sentence (1:29) as:

God not only has allowed you to believe in Christ but also has given you the privilege of suffering for Christ.

Philippians 1:30

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since they lived among many people who were opposed to the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith. They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

1:30a

since you are encountering the same struggle you saw I had,

- The conflict you now have with those who oppose you is just like the conflict you saw I had when I was with you in Philippi

1:30b

and now hear that I still have.

- and like the conflict you now hear I still have here in prison.

1:30a–b

the same struggle you saw I had: People were persecuting the Philippian believers because of what they as Christians believed. This was similar to the way they had persecuted Paul when he had been in Philippi. See Acts 16:19–24.

struggle: The Greek word used here refers to a conflict, a contest or a fight. This includes the idea of suffering.

you saw I had: The Philippians had witnessed what Paul had suffered for Christ in Philippi. He was beaten and put in prison.

hear that I still have: Here Paul was referring to the suffering he was experiencing while in prison in Rome. The Philippians would have heard about this from Epaphroditus, who carried the letter to them. In both Philippi and Rome Paul continued preaching the good news about Jesus, even though this was why the authorities put him in prison in both of those cities.

Philippians 2:1

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since they lived among many people who were opposed to the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith. They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

Paragraph 2:1–4

Since Christ has shown the Philippians how much he loves them, they should love one other, agree with one another and be humble.

2:1–4 is one long sentence in the Greek. In your translation you may need to divide this into several shorter sentences.

2:1

There is no verb in 2:1 in the Greek text. BSB has supplied “have” in the first phrase, but you may need to supply a verb for each of the four parts of the verse. Paul used these four conditional or “if” clauses (or phrases) to make his appeal to the Philippians very strong. What he was asking them to do is in 2:2a: “make my joy complete.”

Paul used the Greek word *ei* in each of the four parts of 2:1. It literally means “if.” But in this context Paul was not expressing any doubt that these things were true. He was assuming that they were true. If your word for “if” is only used in a conditional sense, you will need to use another connecting word here, for example, “since.” See the first Meaning Line in the Display for 2:1a, 2:1b, 2:1c, and 2:1d.

These four phrases have a strong emotional effect, and Paul’s basic aim in writing them was to motivate the readers to follow his instructions in 2:2–4. Look for a way in your language to express the emotional appeal and the strong feeling that Paul showed here. Try not to lose the emotional force by making long sentences in an attempt to explain the exact meaning. One possibility is to use rhetorical questions. For example, in 2:1a:

Does being united to Christ encourage you? Of course it does!

If you use rhetorical questions, you will need to use them in each part of this verse. See the second Meaning Line in the Display for 2:1a, 2:1b, 2:1c, and 2:1d.

Another way to translate 2:1 is to use short statements. For example:

¹You are united to Christ and this encourages you. Christ loves you and this gives you comfort. You have fellowship with the Spirit. And there is tenderness and compassion.

If you do this, you will need to begin 2:2 with a phrase to connect it with all these statements in 2:1. For example:

²Since all these things are true, make my joy complete....

2:1a

Therefore if you have any encouragement in Christ,

- ¶ Since/if you are encouraged because you belong to Christ,
- ¶ Does it encourage you that you belong to Christ? Of course it does!
- ¶ You live in union with Christ and he/this encourages you.

Therefore: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as Therefore indicates that what follows is the result of what preceded. Some English versions do not use a connector here. Use the expression that is most natural in your language.

if you have any encouragement in Christ: A literal translation of the Greek here is “If any encouragement in Christ...” But in many languages, a verb will be needed (as it is in English). The context implies you have (as the BSB uses) or “you receive” here.

encouragement: The Greek word that the BSB translates as encouragement comes from a verb that means “to comfort, encourage, cheer up.” It is not possible to translate encouragement as a noun in every language. If you need to translate it with a verb, you could say:

if you are encouraged/comforted because you are united with Christ

if being united with Christ encourages/comforts you

if Christ has encouraged you by uniting you with himself

in Christ: The BSB translates the Greek phrase literally as in Christ. People who are joined with Christ because they trust him are in Christ. They belong to him, they let him have control of their lives.

2:1b

if any comfort from His love,

- since/if you are comforted by Christ’s love for you,
- Do you get any comfort from knowing that he loves you? Yes, you do!
- Christ loves you and this comforts you.

comfort from His love: In Greek, the noun love has no possessive pronoun (His). This means that commentators disagree about what love Paul was talking about here. There are four main possibilities: Another possibility is that it refers to God’s love for the Philippians. Some commentators suggest this so that this would then complete the Trinity in 2:1. That is: 2:1a—Christ encourages, 2:1b—God loves, and 2:1c—the Spirit provides fellowship.

1. Christ’s love for the Philippians.
2. Paul’s love for the Philippians.
3. The Philippians’ love for Paul.
4. The Philippians’ love for one another.

Many English versions do not make it clear what love is being referred to (for example, RSV, NJB, NASB), but those which do make it clear, follow the first option—Christ’s love for the Philippians (BSB, NIV, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV). Since the exact meaning of the Greek is not clear, it may be preferable to leave it more general in your translation, if you can do so. However, if in your language you must provide a subject and an object for love, it is recommended that you also follow option (1). Believers do not have to worry even in difficult times because they know that Christ loves them.

2:1c

if any fellowship with the Spirit,

- since/if you have fellowship with the Spirit,
- Do you share together with God’s Spirit? Yes, of course!
- The Holy Spirit shares together with you.

fellowship with the Spirit: The Greek is literally “fellowship of the spirit.” This may refer to

1. the fellowship that believers have with the Spirit. (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, GNT)

2. the fellowship that the Spirit helps believers to have with each other. (CEV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

fellowship: The Greek word here is *koinōnia*, which means “sharing,” “participating,” “having a part in something.” This Greek word has several related meanings. For example, it can refer to people sharing with one another or doing something with one another, or people joining together with others in some way. The sense in this verse has to do with participation in the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit dwells within and ministers to all believers.

the Spirit: Most commentators and versions agree that this refers to the Spirit of God. You may need to translate the phrase the Spirit as “the Holy Spirit” or “the Spirit of God” or “God’s Spirit” in order to make it clear to whom it is referring.

2:1d

if any affection and compassion,

- and since/if Christ has been tender and compassionate toward you,
- Has Christ been kind and merciful toward you? Of course he has!
- Christ has been kind to you and has shown you pity.

affection and compassion: These two words can refer to two different feelings or to a way of expressing a single emotion. Most commentaries interpret the two words as two distinct but related ideas. The phrase affection and compassion has been understood as describing

1. how Christ felt toward the Philippians (SSA, O’Brien);
2. how the Philippians felt toward one another or toward Paul. (GNT, REB, GW, NLT, CEV)

If you need to translate affection and compassion as verbs, you will probably need to give a subject. Interpretation (1) is the most likely to be what Paul meant, and it is recommended that you follow it. Christ loved the Philippians and pitied them. He demonstrated this when he died on the cross to save them.

affection: This is the same word as was used in 1:8. The Greek word literally refers to the “insides of the body.” It means the “affections,” “the feelings of the heart,” “the center of a person’s emotions.” In this verse it means to be tender toward someone, to be kind and gentle to them.

compassion: The Greek word here means “pity, mercy, sympathy.”

Philippians 2:2

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since they lived among many people who were opposed to the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith. They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

Paragraph 2:1–4

Since Christ has shown the Philippians how much he loves them, they should love one other, agree with one another and be humble.

2:1–4 is one long sentence in the Greek. In your translation you may need to divide this into several shorter sentences.

2:2

After the subordinate clauses in 2:1, where Paul was stating things that were true about the Philippians, in 2:2, he stated what he wanted the Philippians to do as a result of what was true in 2:1. In 2:2a, Paul told the Philippians what they were to do and in the rest of the verse how they were to do it.

Remember that, if you split 2:1 into a number of short sentences, you may need to include an introductory phrase like “Since all these things are true...” in order to connect 2:2 correctly to 2:1.

Several translations supply a phrase like “I urge you” at the beginning of 2:2 to help bring out some of the emotional force of Paul’s appeal.

2:2a

then make my joy complete by

- make me completely joyful by
- Therefore, I urge you to make me even more joyful by doing as follows:
- Since all these things are true, make me truly happy by doing this:

make my joy complete: Paul was already joyful, but he meant that he would have more joy or complete joy if the Philippians did as he instructed in the rest of this verse. Some translations make this clearer by saying “make me even more joyful.”

2:2b

being like-minded,

- Agree with one another,

2:2b means almost the same as 2:2d. They repeat the same main idea to emphasize Paul’s desire that the Philippians should be united spiritually.

being like-minded: A literal translation is “think the same thing.” Paul wanted the Philippians to agree with one another and to have the same intentions and purposes. What Paul said in the following clauses (2:2c–4b) may make it clear what he meant by the phrase being like-minded.

If your language has one way to talk about an outward agreement (in words) and another way to talk about agreement in feeling or truly agreeing in the heart, you should choose the second way here.

2:2c

having the same love,

- and love one another with mutual affection,

having the same love: This seems to imply that Paul wanted all the Philippians to love each other deeply.

2:2d

being united in spirit and purpose.

- being united in heart and mind.
- thinking in the same way and aiming for the same goal.

being united in spirit: The phrase being united in spirit means “having the same attitude, agreeing together from the heart.”

and purpose: This literally means “thinking the one thing.” It has essentially the same meaning as “being one in spirit.” Paul wanted them all to have the mind of Christ; that is, to think like Christ did.

General Comment on 2:2b–d

A way of combining these parts of the verse could be:

Agree together in your hearts and souls by the way you think and by the way you love one another.

General Comment on 2:2

In some languages it may be helpful to reorder this verse. For example:

I urge you ^bto agree completely with one another, ^clove one another equally ^dand be united in your hearts and minds. ^aIf you do this, I will be completely happy.

Philippians 2:3

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous

when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since they lived among many people who were opposed to the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith. They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

Paragraph 2:1–4

Since Christ has shown the Philippians how much he loves them, they should love one other, agree with one another and be humble.

2:1–4 is one long sentence in the Greek. In your translation you may need to divide this into several shorter sentences.

2:3a

Do nothing out of selfish ambition or empty pride,

- Never try to make yourselves more important than others, and never do anything just because you want to boast about it.

Do nothing out of: This means “Do not do anything from,” that is, “Never act in accord with” or “...in a spirit of.”

selfish ambition: The Greek word that the BSB translates as selfish ambition also occurs in 1:17a. See note there. You may need to translate it with a verb. For example, “trying to make yourself [or yourselves] seem more important than others.”

empty pride: The Greek word that the BSB translates as empty pride can also be translated as “conceit” or “vanity.” A person who has empty pride is one who is proud and who boasts. He praises himself and thinks that his ideas are always the best.

2:3b

but in humility consider others more important than yourselves.

- Instead, be humble and think of others as more important than yourselves.

humility: The word humility is the opposite of “selfish ambition” and “empty pride” in 2:3a. The Greek word refers to someone who has the characteristics of meekness or lowliness. If you need to translate this as a verb, you could say:

act as if you were not important

submit yourselves to others

consider others more important than yourselves: A believer should not think of himself as more important than or superior to others, as some in Philippi may have been doing. Each believer should think of other

people as more important than himself. This is another way of saying “be humble.” Another way to say this could be:

give more honor to others than you give to yourselves

General Comment on 2:3

In some languages it may be helpful to reverse this sentence in order to make the negative command “Do nothing” into a positive command “Do everything.” A suggested model is:

Do everything in humility and by considering others better than yourselves. Do not be ambitious for yourself or try to make yourself look great.

Philippians 2:4

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since they lived among many people who were opposed to the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith. They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

Paragraph 2:1–4

Since Christ has shown the Philippians how much he loves them, they should love one another, agree with one another and be humble.

2:1–4 is one long sentence in the Greek. In your translation you may need to divide this into several shorter sentences.

2:4a

Each of you should look not only to your own interests,

- Each of you should not be concerned only with what is best for yourself.
- Each person among you should not think only about what is good for him/her.

2:4b

but also to the interests of others.

- Look out also for what is good for one another.
- You each should also think about what is good for other people.

2:4a–b

look not only to your own interests, but also to the interests of others: This is literally “Look not only to your own [things] but also to the [things] of others.”

People are naturally concerned about what they themselves need and want. But believers also should be concerned about the needs of others and how to help others.

look...to: The Greek word means “to watch something,” “to care about something or someone,” “to be concerned for someone.” It means more than just looking with the eyes.

interests: This word is not in the Greek but all translations require some word or words to be supplied. The BSB has chosen to use interests as have most English versions. The English word interests here does not refer to things people are interested in, but to whatever is to their benefit or advantage. Believers should not seek only their own profit or good, but also the good of others.

General Comment on 2:4

In some languages it will be helpful to reverse 2:4a and 2:4b. For example:

Think about how you can be of help to others, not just about how you can help yourself.

Philippians 2:5

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since they lived among many people who were opposed to the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith. They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

Paragraph 2:5–8

Believers should think as Jesus did when he gave up his special place with God and humbled himself by becoming a man and dying on the cross.

Paul here turned the attention of his readers to Jesus Christ. Jesus was and is the supreme example of being humble and considering the needs of others more than his own.

2:5

Let this mind be in you which was also in Christ Jesus:

- ¶ You should have the same attitude that Christ Jesus had.
- ¶ You should think the way Christ Jesus thought, which was like this:

Let this mind be in you which was also in Christ Jesus: There are two ways to understand this:

1. Paul was saying that the Philippians should have the same attitude that Christ Jesus had. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NASB, NET, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)
2. Paul was saying that the Philippians should have this attitude among them, which is appropriate for those who are in Christ Jesus. A literal translation of the Greek in this verse is “Let this thinking be in you which was also in Christ Jesus.” The Display reflects the traditional interpretation. Some recent commentaries have arguments for an interpretation which is slightly different: “Have this attitude among you, which is appropriate for those who are in Christ Jesus” (interpretation 2 in the Notes). The traditional interpretation says that the implied verb or action (was) allows for the following meaning: “have this attitude which Christ Jesus had” (interpretation 1 in the Notes). Interpretation 2 says that the literal phrase “in Christ Jesus” means “in union with Christ Jesus.” This could imply that it has the same meaning in 2:5 that it has in many other places, including several places in Philippians (1:1, 1:13; 2:1; 3:14; 4:7). The interpretation of this verse does not affect the overall meaning or theme of the paragraph. However, this is a popular passage and people often memorize it. So if you change the traditional rendering, some readers may think that you have translated it badly. Therefore, before you translate, consider how you can make the best translation and still have the people accept it. (RSV)

The following verses (2:6–11) describe the attitude that Christ Jesus had. Interpretation (1) fits better in this context. So it is recommended that you follow it in your translation.

Let this mind be in you: A person’s mind is the way he thinks about something. A person with a proud attitude is someone who thinks that he is more important than others. Someone with a humble attitude is one who does not think proudly about himself. Instead, he thinks about how important others are. 2:6–8 show that Jesus’ attitude was humble.

Christ Jesus: See note on 1:1a.

Philippians 2:6

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since they lived among many people who were opposed to

the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith. They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

Paragraph 2:5–8

Believers should think as Jesus did when he gave up his special place with God and humbled himself by becoming a man and dying on the cross.

Paul here turned the attention of his readers to Jesus Christ. Jesus was and is the supreme example of being humble and considering the needs of others more than his own.

2:6

This passage is often called a Christ hymn, and it may have been an early Christian hymn or poem, used in the early church. Paul then used it at this point because it was appropriate to his message. Or Paul may have composed it himself when he wrote this letter to the Philippians. Try to translate these verses not as a prose description but as a hymn or as a poem. Some of the English versions print these verses in lines like a poem (BSB, NIV, GNT). If you have a special way of printing poetry in your language, you could use it here.

2:6a

Who, existing in the form of God,

- Even though he had the same nature as God,
- Although he was like God in every way,

existing in the form of God: This could be literally translated as “being in the form of God.” The Greek word that the BSB translates as form is *morphē*. It refers to a form that accurately reflects the essential qualities of someone or something. Christ has always had the same nature as God (see the GNT).

2:6b

did not consider equality with God something to be grasped,

- he did not think that he should try to hold onto his equal place/position with God.
- he did not insist on keeping all the power and privileges of being equal with God.

did not consider equality with God something to be grasped: There are two main ways to understand this clause. The difference is in the interpretation of the rare Greek word *harpagmos* that the BSB translates as something to be grasped.

1. The word *harpagmos* refers to a person holding on to something he already has. This would mean that, before he was born as a human, Christ was equal with God. But in order to become man, he did not try to hold on to the privileges that came with being equal with God. He was willing to give them up.

This is probably the most common interpretation of 2:6b. (GNT, NLT, CEV)

2. The word *harpagmos* refers to a person snatching or taking by force something he does not yet have. This interpretation would mean that Jesus as a man was not equal with God, but he did not use force to try and become equal with God while he was a man.

Most English translations, like the BSB, are ambiguous, though they most likely follow the first interpretation. The context of 2:6 is Christ's preparation for becoming man. So interpretation (1) fits better with this context.

In some languages it may be necessary to use a direct quote here. For example:

He didn't say, "I must hold on to my equal status with God."

Try to make it clear in your translation that this was the attitude that Jesus Christ had.

equality with God: This means "being equal with God" or "having the same power and privileges that God has." It probably refers to outward status and the display of greatness. When he became man, Christ remained truly God, but he gave up the outward display of his power and glory.

Philippians 2:7

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since they lived among many people who were opposed to the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith. They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

Paragraph 2:5–8

Believers should think as Jesus did when he gave up his special place with God and humbled himself by becoming a man and dying on the cross.

Paul here turned the attention of his readers to Jesus Christ. Jesus was and is the supreme example of being humble and considering the needs of others more than his own.

2:7–8

There are six verbs in 2:7–8 (underlined below). These verbs can relate to each other in several ways. This is how they would appear in a literal translation of the Greek:

1. He emptied himself,
2. taking the form of a slave,
3. being born in the likeness of men,
4. being found in form as a man,
5. he humbled himself,
6. becoming obedient unto death.

(a) and (e) are the main verbs and the others depend on these two. The second meaning line in the Display arranges this passage in two sentences: A-B-C (2:7) and D-E-F (2:8), with the second sentence following chronologically after the first. First Christ humbled himself by becoming like a slave (that is, he became a man), and then he humbled himself further by dying.

Some translations have divided this into three sentences, A-B, C-D and E-F. Look at the GNT for one example of this.

2:7a

but emptied Himself,

- Instead, he left everything behind,
- Rather he willingly gave up his privileges as God and came to earth

emptied Himself: The BSB translates the Greek literally as emptied Himself. It means he humbled himself. Christ was still truly God in his character, attributes and nature. But he willingly gave up the power and privileges that were rightfully his and completely humbled himself in order to become human.

2:7b

taking the form of a servant,

- accepting the same nature as a slave,
- and he became the same as a slave,

taking the form of a servant: As Christ before his incarnation was truly God, now he became truly man as well. He took the form of a servant, that is, he became the same as a servant. This includes the implied meaning "he came to earth." For example:

He came to earth and became the same as a servant/slave.

form: The Greek word that the BSB translates as form is *morphē*, the same Greek word that Paul used in 2:6a when referring to Christ having the same nature as God. See the note there. When Jesus became a man, he submitted himself to other people and experienced pain, hunger and thirst. If in your translation you can use the same word to speak about Jesus being in the form of God and Jesus taking the form of a servant, you should do so. However, if it is not possible to use

the same word, try to still keep the parallelism in some way.

servant: See note on “servants” in 1:1a. Look for the word or phrase in your language that implies the lowest social position or the position of a servant. Jesus, who had had all the rights and privileges of God himself, now voluntarily becomes someone with no rights at all.

2:7c being made in human likeness.

- that is, he became a human being.
- by being born as a human being.

The Display shows how the clause in 2:7b relates to the previous clause in 2:7a. It shows how Jesus took the form of a slave.

being made: This means “becoming” or “being born.”

in human likeness: A literal translation is “in the likeness of human beings.” Some English versions translate as “man” the Greek word that the BSB translates as human. But the Greek word used here does not mean “male.” It refers to a human being of either sex.

Your translation should not imply that Christ was like humans but not really human. So you may need to translate the phrase “being made in human likeness” as, for example, “he became a human being.”

Philippians 2:8

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since they lived among many people who were opposed to the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith. They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

Paragraph 2:5–8

Believers should think as Jesus did when he gave up his special place with God and humbled himself by becoming a man and dying on the cross.

Paul here turned the attention of his readers to Jesus Christ. Jesus was and is the supreme example of being humble and considering the needs of others more than his own.

2:8a

And being found in appearance as a man,

- And when he had appeared in human form,

- And after he had become a man,

Some possible translations for the clause in 2:8a are:

After he became a human being...

While he was a human being...

While he lived here on the earth as a man...

Some versions place this phrase (2:8a) at the end of 2:7. However, it is recommended that you place it at the beginning of 2:8 as the BSB has done. 2:8 then begins by repeating the same idea in different words with which 2:7 ended:

7b...being made in human likeness.

8a...being found in appearance as a man....

And being found in appearance as a man: This does not mean that Christ was found by someone. It means that people could see that he looked like a man.

appearance: The Greek word that the BSB translates as appearance refers to the outward or external shape of something. But Christ did not just look like a man, he really was a man.

2:8b

He humbled Himself

- he made himself humble
- he accepted an even lower place

He humbled Himself: In the context of 2:7–8 this means that Christ gave up even more of his own rights and advantages. He took the next step of humbling himself. He had lived as a human, and now he also died as a human.

2:8c

and became obedient to death—

- and, in obedience to God, he was willing to die,
- and obeyed God not only to the extent that he allowed people to kill him,

became obedient to death: This does not mean that Jesus obeyed death. It means that he obeyed God completely, even though this led to his death. There are several ways you could translate this. For example:

He did what God wanted to the extent that he was willing to die.

He obeyed God even though it resulted in people killing him.

death: In many languages translators must render this as a verb. For example: “he died” or “people killed him.”

2:8d

even death on a cross.

- even to die on a cross just like those who are very evil.
- and not just kill him but even to kill him like a criminal by nailing him on a cross.

even death on a cross: Dying on a cross was the most shaming and painful kind of punishment the Romans gave. It was the kind of punishment they used only for dangerous criminals and slaves. So the phrase even death on a cross shows how far Jesus was willing to humble himself.

Possible translations are:

even dying in a disgraceful way on a cross

dying like a criminal on a cross

Philippians 2:9

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since they lived among many people who were opposed to the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith. They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

Paragraph 2:9–11

After Christ had obediently humbled himself, God exalted Christ and gave him the highest possible honor and authority. By using this example, Paul implied that God would also honor those of his people who obediently humbled themselves.

2:9a

Therefore God exalted Him to the highest place

- So God raised him to the position above everything
- Because of this God after causing Jesus to live again lifted him to the place/position of highest possible honor.

Therefore: In 2:6–8 Christ humbled himself. In 2:9–11 God exalted him. So the main connection between 2:6–8 and 2:9–11 is that 2:9–11 is the result of 2:6–8:

Christ obediently humbled himself, and as a result God exalted him.

However, a literal translation of the Greek here is “therefore also.” This is an unusual combination of Greek words that shows that there is also a contrast between 2:6–8 and 2:9–11. This contrast is highly dramatic. Look for a way to make this contrast exciting in your language.

God exalted Him to the highest place: God gave Jesus the highest honor he could give anyone. He gave him the position of the greatest possible honor and authority.

The speakers of some languages have incorrectly imagined that God put Jesus’ dead body in an important position. If the readers of your translation might think this, you will need to make explicit the information that God first caused Jesus to live again. See the Display on 2:9b.

Look for an expression in your language that indicates the greatest possible honor. Other translation ideas are:

God gave him greatness beyond measure.

God made him very, very great.

In some languages it is necessary to show who or what Jesus is greater than. (2:9b and 2:10 indicate this.) For example:

God made him greater than everything and everyone.

2:9b

and gave Him the name above all names,

- by giving him the name that has greater honor and authority than all other names.
- That is he gave him the title/rank of lordship that is greater than any other title/rank.

and gave Him the name above all names: God gave Jesus the name that has greater honor and authority than all other names. God gave him a title or rank that is greater than that of anyone or anything else. He made him to be Lord of all.

name: This may refer to a specific name or to the reputation or rank that God gave Jesus. There are several interpretations of what the word “name” here refers to: (1) Lord (see 2:11) (2) Not a literal name, but his rank and position (Banker) (3) Jesus (see 2:10) (4) Jesus

Christ (see 2:11) Most commentators understand that the “name” Paul is referring to here is “Lord.” “Lord,” kurios, was used in the Septuagint as a substitute for the personal name of God, Yahweh, which was considered too holy to be spoken. Thus Jesus may be here identified with Yahweh. This may be implied by the fact that the OT quote in Philippians 2:10–11 is from Isaiah 45:23. In the context of Isaiah 45:21–24, God referred to himself as Yahweh, which is translated “Lord” in English. But even if name refers to a specific or literal name, the idea of rank or position is also included. See Romans 1:5; 1 Timothy 6:1 and Hebrews 1:4 for other examples of the word name. The position God gave to Jesus was one of lordship, authority, power and dignity.

In some languages a person’s name is not associated with his position or authority. If this is so in your language, you will need to make this clear in another way. See the second Meaning Line in the Display on 2:9b for another suggestion.

General Comment on 2:9

There are two ways to understand how the two clauses in 2:9 (“God exalted Him...and gave Him the name”) relate to each other:

1. God exalted Jesus to the highest place, that is, he gave him the name that is above every name (see SSA). This also has good support in the commentaries. One way to translate this would be:

God exalted him by giving him the greatest name.
(GW)

1. God exalted Jesus to the highest place, and he also gave him the name that is above every name. “Exalting” and “giving a name” are thus two separate things God did for Jesus. This is not stated explicitly in most translations but is the natural reading. (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, REB, NET, NLT and CEV)

It is likely that the two actions in 2:9 are two ways of speaking about the same thing. So interpretation (1) is preferred here.

Philippians 2:10

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since they lived among many people who were opposed to the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith.

They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

Paragraph 2:9–11

After Christ had obediently humbled himself, God exalted Christ and gave him the highest possible honor and authority. By using this example, Paul implied that God would also honor those of his people who obediently humbled themselves.

2:10a

that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow,

- God did this so that every being will kneel down in submission to Jesus,
- God did this in order that everyone will bow in respect to the person of Jesus,

that: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word hina here:

1. It indicates purpose. God gave Christ the highest authority in order that every knee should bow to him. 2:10–11 shows the purpose for 2:9. (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NET, GW)
2. It indicates result. God gave Christ the highest authority with the result that every knee will bow. (GNT, CEV)

Interpretation (1) has much stronger commentary support, and it is recommended that you follow it.

at the name of Jesus every knee should bow: The name Jesus refers to the person Jesus, who is Christ, the Lord of lords and the King of kings. God desires that everyone should acknowledge that Jesus is Lord of all.

at the name of Jesus: There are at least three ways to interpret this expression. These interpretations depend on two things:

1. what the Greek word en means (translated as at in the BSB);
2. whether Paul was referring to the literal name Jesus here, or to the person that the name represents, or to both.

The three main interpretations are:

1. The phrase means “in honor of Jesus.” People should bow to honor the person Jesus. Jesus himself is the one to whom they show respect.
2. The phrase means “at the name of Jesus.” When people hear the name Jesus they should bow, because they will know whom it represents.
3. The phrase means “in the name of Jesus.” People should bow and worship in Jesus’ name on the basis of all that his name implies: he is the person God has exalted above all others.

Most English versions are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The phrase the name of Jesus is probably a figure of speech referring to Jesus himself.

every knee should bow: This is a Hebrew way of saying that everyone should kneel down. It implies that they bow to show that they are submitting to someone or worshipping someone.

every knee: This refers to all people and all beings capable of bowing to someone. God's desire is that all people willingly bow and submit to Jesus. But willing or not, one day everyone will submit to Jesus. The knee that bows represents the person who submits himself, his whole person, to a greater authority.

should bow: The verb that the BSB translates as should bow is a form of the Greek word which shows purpose. In this context God is the one whose purpose it is that all should bow. So it is certain that it will happen.

In the Old Testament culture, the act of kneeling implied that a person especially needed something or was showing a very humble and respectful attitude. However, in some cultures people do not kneel to show respect. So in some languages it is necessary to say "humble themselves" instead of the literal bow or kneel. In other languages it is necessary to include both the action and the attitude. For example:

kneel down to show respect

Here are two ways to translate this entire clause:

God did this so that everybody will show respect to Jesus.

God did this so that every person will humble himself before Jesus.

2:10b

in heaven and on earth and under the earth,

- whether they are in heaven or on earth or under the surface of the earth.
- including those in heaven, those on earth, and those in the world of the dead.

in heaven: The literal Greek here means "of those in heaven." The Greek does not say what kind of beings or creatures. The phrase most likely refers to angels and possibly to people who have died and gone to heaven.

on earth: The phrase on earth means "of those] on earth." This refers mainly to people on earth. But some commentators include also animals and other living things, and evil spirits who have authority in the world.

under the earth: This phrase means "of those under the earth." There are many different suggestions about what this refers to. The most widely supported view is that it refers to people who have died. It may include evil spirits. Other views are: Some say the phrase "under the earth" refers to all dead people, including both the good and the bad. Others say that the phrases "in heaven...on earth...under the earth" represent all spiritual beings, including humans. A few say that these phrases should not be limited to living things, but that all that God has created will acknowledge that Jesus is Lord. This includes things that have life and things that do not have life.

This third phrase under the earth is probably the hardest of the three phrases in 2:10b to translate. In some cultures a literal translation is meaningless. Possible translations are:

those in the deep places of the earth

those who are dead

spirits of dead people

General Comment on 2:10b

The three groups of beings listed in 2:10b clearly are intended to cover all beings everywhere that God has created. The point is to make it clear that all creatures everywhere will submit to Jesus Christ, not to describe the three different groups in detail. One possible way of making this clear would be:

All created beings, whether in heaven, on the earth or beneath the earth.

General Comment on 2:10

It will not be grammatically possible in all languages to end a sentence with a list, as in 2:10b. So it may be necessary to move 2:10b to the middle or the beginning of 2:10a. For example:

...so that at the name of Jesus everybody—in heaven and on earth and under the earth—will kneel

...so that all beings in the heavens, on earth and in the underworld, should bend the knee at the name of Jesus. (JB)

General Comment on 2:10

Remember that this is a kind of poetry in Greek and is rich in word pictures (knee, tongue, earth, heaven). Try to keep as many of these word pictures as you can, but be sure the meaning remains the same.

Philippians 2:11

Section 1:27–2:11: Paul encouraged the Philippians to live as true followers of Christ

Paul encouraged the Philippians to act as believers should, to agree with each other and to be courageous when they spoke to other people about Christ. Since they lived among many people who were opposed to the gospel, they should expect to defend their faith. They should also expect to suffer because they trusted in Christ.

Paragraph 2:9–11

After Christ had obediently humbled himself, God exalted Christ and gave him the highest possible honor and authority. By using this example, Paul implied that God would also honor those of his people who obediently humbled themselves.

2:11a

and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord,

- God did this so that every being will publicly acknowledge that Jesus Christ is Lord of all.

every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord: 2:11a repeats the same basic meaning that is in 2:10a but uses a different figure of speech. It means that everyone will acknowledge that Jesus Christ is the supreme Lord over all creation. In order to honor Jesus two things will happen: everyone will bow to Jesus Christ as Lord and everyone will say that Jesus Christ is Lord.

In some languages this requires a direct quote. For example:

everybody will say, “Jesus Christ is Lord of all”

everyone will say, “Jesus Christ is the one who rules us^(incl).”

every tongue: The phrase every tongue is a figure of speech that represents every created being that is able to think and speak. It is parallel to the phrase “every knee” in 2:10a.

confess: Here confess means “to say something openly and publicly.” It means to acknowledge something that is true, or to tell others something you know that is true. The word confess here does not mean to confess sin.

This does not mean that everyone will happily or gladly acknowledge Jesus as Lord. But God will force Satan and all who previously have refused to acknowledge Jesus as Lord to admit that Jesus is Lord.

2:11b

to the glory of God the Father.

- By doing this they will honor God our^(incl) Father.
- This will result in people praising and honoring God the Father.

to the glory of God the Father: People will say “Jesus Christ is Lord,” and by saying this they will give glory to God, the Father of Jesus Christ. The statement “Jesus Christ is Lord” will not mean that Jesus is taking glory away from the Father. He has the lordship (authority) that the Father has given him. Jesus will be Lord of all creation but will still be under the authority of his Father, God. This is God’s plan, and so this will glorify God the Father.

There are several possible ways to translate the phrase to the glory of God the Father. For example:

...and therefore all people will praise our^(incl) Father, God.

...and this will result in people saying that God the Father is very, very great.

...and his Father, God, will receive honor when this happens.

Philippians 2:12

Section 2:12–18: Believers should obey God so that they show other people how God wants people to behave

Paul reminded the Philippian believers that when they obeyed God as Jesus did (2:6–8), God would help them to give the gospel to those in spiritual darkness. As long as they were faithful, Paul knew that his work and even his suffering would not be in vain.

Paragraph 2:12–13

The Philippian believers should follow the example of Christ by continuing to obey God and by acting as people whom God has saved. God would give them the power to do this.

In these verses Paul taught about what God does and what Christians do in relation to being saved and doing what is pleasing to him.

The wording in 2:12–13 in the Display is based partly on the SSA.

2:12a

Therefore, my beloved, just as you have always obeyed,

- ¶ Because of all this, my dear friends, just as you have always obeyed God,
- ¶ My dear friends, because Christ obeyed God and God exalted him, in the same way that you have always done what God told you to do,

Therefore: This connecting word seems to refer back to Christ's example of obeying God and God exalting Christ (2:6–11). So it means: "In view of Christ obeying God and God exalting Christ, you also work out...."

my beloved: The Greek literally means "my beloved ones." This phrase shows Paul's affection for the Philippians. There are three ways that Paul addressed the Philippian believers. In the BSB they are translated as "saints" (1:1), "brothers" (1:12, 3:1, 3:13, 3:17, 4:1, 4:8), and "my beloved," and "whom I love" (2:12, 4:1). In some languages the translations of beloved and "brothers" are almost the same. You could translate the Greek phrase here as:

my dear friends

my dear fellow believers

brothers and sisters whom I love

In some languages a term of address such as this must come at the beginning of the sentence.

obeyed: It is not clear what the implied object of the verb obeyed is. There are three possible interpretations as to whom the Philippians had always obeyed:

1. God. This would mean that Paul was saying "you have always obeyed God". (NCV)
2. Paul. This would be translated as "you have always obeyed me" or "...my instructions". (GNT, NRSV, NLT)
3. The gospel. This could be translated as "you have always obeyed the good news."

Paul may have meant any (or all) of these. If your language requires an object to the verb, you will need to choose here. In this case it is recommended that you choose "God" as the object.

2:12b

not only in my presence, but now even more in my absence,

- therefore, not only when I am with you, but even more now when I am not with you

not only in my presence, but now even more in my absence: In the Greek it is not clear how these two phrases connect to the rest of the verse. There are three possibilities:

1. They relate only to the verb "work out" (2:12c). One way to translate this would be:

Therefore, my dear friends, since you have always obeyed God, therefore continue to work out your salvation with fear and trembling. Do this working out not only when I am with you, but much more now that I am not with you. (RSV)

1. They relate only to the verb "obeyed" (2:12a). One way to translate this would be:

"So then, dear friends, since you always obeyed God when I was with you, it is even more important that you continue to obey now, while I am not with you. Continue to work out your salvation with fear and trembling. (GNT, NIV, REB, NJB, GW, CEV, NCV)

1. The first phrase relates to "obeyed" and the second to "work out." One way to translate this would be, as JBP:

"So then, my dear friends, since you always obeyed God while I was with you, now in my absence, continue to work out your salvation with fear and trembling. (JBP) (NLT, JBP)

Interpretation (1) has stronger support from the commentaries and seems to be preferable in this context. It is therefore recommended that you follow it.

2:12c

continue to work out your salvation with fear and trembling.

- continue to strive with fear and trembling to complete your salvation
- each of you should reverently strive to completely do those things which are right/appropriate for people whom God has saved.

continue to work out your salvation: There are two interpretations of this phrase:

1. Each believer had an individual responsibility to work out the salvation that he had already received.
2. The believers were responsible to work out their salvation as a community.

Interpretation (1) has stronger support. This does not mean that the Philippians should save themselves. They should live in a way that showed to others that God had already saved them.

Be sure you make the verb you use here a command and make it clear that it is the main verb in this verse. This is important because 2:13 relates back to this command.

your salvation: Three passages in Philippians (1:6; 2:12; 3:7-14) show how Paul understood the way God saves people and what their responsibility is. In this verse, salvation includes the whole process of salvation. It starts with God bringing people to repent and believe, continues with him making them holy, and will conclude when he brings them to heaven.

It may be possible to translate this whole phrase as “Work hard so your salvation will be complete.” But in some languages it may be necessary to translate salvation as a verb. The second Meaning Line in the Display shows a way to do this.

with fear and trembling: This phrase is not talking about two separate things. The trembling is a sign of the fear. Using trembling as a verb, the phrase could be translated as “trembling with/from fear.” This means that all believers should be afraid of sinning. They should fear that they might disobey God and fail him. This phrase also suggests that they should revere God and highly respect him.

Philippians 2:13

Section 2:12–18: Believers should obey God so that they show other people how God wants people to behave

Paul reminded the Philippian believers that when they obeyed God as Jesus did (2:6–8), God would help them to give the gospel to those in spiritual darkness. As long as they were faithful, Paul knew that his work and even his suffering would not be in vain.

Paragraph 2:12–13

The Philippian believers should follow the example of Christ by continuing to obey God and by acting as people whom God has saved. God would give them the power to do this.

In these verses Paul taught about what God does and what Christians do in relation to being saved and doing what is pleasing to him.

The wording in 2:12–13 in the Display is based partly on the SSA.

2:13a

For it is God who works in you

- You can do this because God himself is working in you.

For: This connecting word indicates that what follows shows how the believers can do what they are instructed in 2:12. They can work out their salvation because God is working within them.

works in you: God causes things to happen in and among his people.

in you: The Greek phrase usually translated as in you has been understood in two ways:

1. God works within individual believers;
2. The emphasis is not on individual believers but on the community of God’s people. God works among them.

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

2:13b

to will and to act on behalf of His good purpose.

- He makes you willing to do what he wants you to do, and also enables you to do it.

to will and to act: This means to want to do something (or to be willing to do it) and also to actually do it. Some ways to translate along with 2:13a are:

God makes you willing to obey...

God renews how you think so you are willing to do what he wants.

God makes you want to do his purpose, and able to do it.

on behalf of His good purpose: His refers to God. The Greek is literally “for his [God’s] good pleasure.” Commentators do not agree about how this phrase relates to the rest of the verse. There are two possibilities:

1. It relates to the verbs “will” and “act.” God both causes his people to want to do what pleases him and enables them to do what he wants. (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, KJV, NASB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)
2. It relates to the verb “works” in 2:13a. God works in us in accordance with his own purpose. (NET, NJB, REB)

The main difficulty with the second interpretation is that it does not say what God makes believers able and willing to do. It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1). God works within each believer to enable him both to want to do and to actually do what pleases him.

Philippians 2:14

Section 2:12–18: Believers should obey God so that they show other people how God wants people to behave

Paul reminded the Philippian believers that when they obeyed God as Jesus did (2:6–8), God would help them to give the gospel to those in spiritual darkness. As long as they were faithful, Paul knew that his work and even his suffering would not be in vain.

Paragraph 2:14–16

Theme: Believers should be different from those who are evil and should show people the message of life.

2:14

Do everything without complaining or arguing,

- ¶ Everything you do, do without complaining or arguing with each other,
- ¶ Don't grumble or quarrel with other people in whatever you do

complaining or arguing: This means for a person to say bad things about his own situation and to argue with other people. Perhaps some of the Philippians were acting like this toward God or toward one another. Paul was probably thinking about the attitude of the Israelites while Moses led them through the desert (Exodus 16:2).

In some languages 2:14 has been translated as:

Live without complaining or arguing.

Philippians 2:15

Section 2:12–18: Believers should obey God so that they show other people how God wants people to behave

Paul reminded the Philippian believers that when they obeyed God as Jesus did (2:6–8), God would help them to give the gospel to those in spiritual darkness. As long as they were faithful, Paul knew that his work and even his suffering would not be in vain.

Paragraph 2:14–16

Theme: Believers should be different from those who are evil and should show people the message of life.

2:15a

so that you may be blameless and pure,

- so that no one can accuse you of doing evil, and so that you will become righteous.
- in order that you may become so good that no one can say you have done wrong.

so that: The Philippians should not complain and argue. This was in order that they could become blameless. 2:15 gives the purpose for 2:14.

blameless: The Greek word that the BSB translates as blameless means to behave in such a way that a person cannot be criticized for doing wrong. Paul said that the Philippians should behave in such a way that people could not call them evildoers. A common English expression for blameless is “no one can find fault with you.” Some people might still try to say the Philippian believers had done wrong, but if the believers were blameless, no one could criticize them honestly or justly.

pure: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pure means “sincere, upright.” It means that a person does not intend to do evil.

General Comment on 2:15a

The words “blameless” and “pure” mean almost the same thing and are intended to strengthen each other. If you do not have two words similar in meaning in your language, then use one word or phrase and add extra emphasis. For example:

truly righteous

2:15b

children of God without fault in a crooked and perverse generation,

- That is, you will be God's children having done nothing wrong in the midst of people who are very evil and who habitually do what is bad.
- That is, as God's children, you may live in a way that is completely good among people who are completely evil.

without fault: The Greek literally means “without blemish.” This term was used to describe the sort of animals the priests were commanded to offer as sacrifices to God in the temple in Jerusalem. These animals could not have anything wrong with them or any ugly marks on them. Here the term is used figuratively and means for a person to have nothing morally wrong with him.

The Greek words that the BSB translates as without fault here and “blameless” in 2:15a are different, but they have almost exactly the same meaning. Some translators have omitted the phrase without fault because it is awkward to repeat the same idea. But it is better to try to show Paul’s emphasis on the fact that God’s children should be morally upright. One way to do this is to translate the phrase “children of God without fault” using a word such as “perfect”:

God’s perfect children (GNT)

perfect children of God (JB)

crooked and perverse generation: This refers to people who did evil continually. The two words crooked and perverse mean basically the same thing. Together they can mean “very evil.” Paul may have quoted this whole phrase from the Old Testament (Deuteronomy 32:5). Here he used it to refer to the non-Christians around the Philippian believers.

crooked: The Greek word that the BSB translates as crooked literally means “twisted, bent.” Here it is used figuratively to refer to people who are crooked, unjust, or dishonest in their behavior.

perverse: This is very similar in meaning to “crooked.” The Greek word that the BSB translates as perverse literally means “distorted.” It is used figuratively to mean “perverted, corrupt.” Here it refers to people who are evil, those who are morally corrupt.

generation: The Greek word that the BSB translates as generation normally refers to people who are alive at the same time. It can also refer to a group of people who all have the same character. In 2:15b generation refers particularly to those who did not believe or obey the good news.

2:15c

in which you shine as lights in the world

- You must behave well among them like lights shining in a dark world.
- Behave among those people in a way that contrasts with their evil behavior like stars that shine in the dark sky.

in which you shine as lights in the world: This simile compares Christian believers to stars shining in the dark sky at night. They should be good people living for God in a world of evil people. This is a figure of speech comparing good behavior to light and evil to darkness. Jesus also used this comparison (Matthew 5:14–16).

If this is not a common way of speaking in your language, then you may need to make the points of comparison clear. Or you may need to avoid the metaphor altogether. For example:

The way you act should be very different from the way evil people act.

shine: The word shine means “give light.” This is a metaphor for Christians displaying God’s truth and goodness by the way they behave. The form of the verb here can be understood in two ways:

1. It is a command. Paul was telling the Philippian believers how they were to behave, that is, they were to “shine like stars”. (GNT, NLT, CEV)
2. It is a statement. It refers to what the Philippians were already doing. For example:

You shine among them like stars (BSB, RSV, NIV, NET, REB, GW, NCV)

The context, especially 2:16b, seems to imply a command rather than simply a statement. However, if you wish to follow interpretation (2), you could translate it as:

You give/shed light among them like stars give light in the sky.

lights: The Greek word can refer to

1. “heavenly lights, bodies, stars”; (NIV, GNT, NCV, GW, REB, NJB)
2. “lights” in general or “objects that shine.” This could include lamps and beacons as well as the sun and the moon and the stars. (BSB, NET, RSV, CEV, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow the majority of translations and commentaries and translate this as “stars.”

world: The Greek word kosmos means “the physical universe” or “the world [of people].” If you follow interpretation (1) above and use “stars” rather than “lights,” you should translate this as referring to the physical universe.

Philippians 2:16

Section 2:12–18: Believers should obey God so that they show other people how God wants people to behave

Paul reminded the Philippian believers that when they obeyed God as Jesus did (2:6–8), God would help them to give the gospel to those in spiritual darkness. As long as they were faithful, Paul knew that his work and even his suffering would not be in vain.

Paragraph 2:14–16

Theme: Believers should be different from those who are evil and should show people the message of life.

2:16a

as you hold forth the word of life,

- Faithfully tell the message that gives eternal life.
- Tell people the good news about how they can live forever.

hold forth the word of life: There are two ways to understand this phrase:

1. It means to hold forth the word of life, to proclaim it so that others can know God. (BSB, NIV, GNT, KJV, REB, NJB, NET, NCV)
2. It means to hold on to the word of life, to continue believing it so that the believer will not fail to trust God. (RSV, NASB, GW, NLT, CEV)

Interpretation (1) fits better in this context, and it is recommended that you follow it.

the word of life: This means the message that brings/gives eternal life.

2:16b

in order that I may boast on the day of Christ

- If you act like this, I will have every reason to be proud of you on the day that Christ returns to earth
- Do this so that I can rejoice at the time when Christ comes back.

This clause refers back generally to all the things Paul taught in 2:14–16a.

in order that I may boast: The notes on 2:16c explain what Paul would boast about. Two ways to show how this clause joins to 2:16a could be:

Do this so that I can be proud.

If you do this then I can boast.

boast: The Greek word that the BSB translates as boast here means “to be proud of someone or something” or “to be very happy and confident about

something or someone.” This Greek word occurs also in 1:26, where the BSB translates it as “exultation,” and in its root form in 3:3, where the BSB translates it as “glory.”

Some languages may have more than one word for boast. People may use a different word depending on whether they think boasting is a good thing or a bad thing to do. For example, in English, the word boast usually has a negative meaning, but the phrase “be proud of” is more positive. Paul obviously felt that it was good for him to boast here. Therefore, if your language has more than one word for boasting, choose the one with the positive meaning.

the day of Christ: See note on 1:6b.

2:16c

that I did not run or labor in vain.

- because it will be clear that all my efforts and my hard work among you have not been wasted.
- I want to rejoice that the way I made a great effort and worked hard among you brought good results.

Paul told here what he would boast about. If the Philippian believers remained faithful to God, he would be able to boast that his work among them had made a difference in how they thought and acted. In some languages the translator may need to use a direct quote. For example:

I will not have to say, “I taught them in vain.”

that I did not run or labor in vain: Paul meant that he would be proud that his hard work had proved useful or profitable. It had not been a waste of effort.

run: This does not literally mean run. Paul was using the metaphor of a person running a race in order to receive a prize (see also Hebrews 12:1 and Philippians 3:12–14). He meant making great efforts to faithfully teach the good news. Paul would be proud when he knew that the ones he taught had been faithful to Christ.

labor: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as labor means “to work hard, toil.” It implies that Paul struggled and suffered and became weary while he was taking the gospel to the Philippians.

in vain: The phrase in vain means “in vain, with no good results.”

General Comment on 2:16c

Notice that Paul used two negatives in the same phrase (“not...in vain”). This is not possible in every language. Sometimes it is necessary to restate the

phrase a positive way. The second meaning line in the Display for 2:16c gives one example of how to do this. Another way could be:

...that I finished the race and that my work was successful.

Philippians 2:17

Section 2:12–18: Believers should obey God so that they show other people how God wants people to behave

Paul reminded the Philippian believers that when they obeyed God as Jesus did (2:6–8), God would help them to give the gospel to those in spiritual darkness. As long as they were faithful, Paul knew that his work and even his suffering would not be in vain.

Paragraph 2:17–18

Even though Paul's work caused him to suffer, he was rejoicing and so should the Philippians.

2:17a

But even if I am being poured out like a drink offering on the sacrifice and service of your faith,

- I may become like wine that they pour as an offering over the sacrifice that you are making because you believe.
- I may suffer and die because I preached the good news, just as you are suffering because you believe it.

But: There are two ways to interpret how 2:16 and 2:17 connect, depending on the meaning of the Greek word *alla*, which the BSB translates as *But*.

1. The word *alla* introduces an additional thought. The main clause in 2:17 ("I am glad and rejoice with all of you") agrees with what the author said or implied in 2:16. It does not indicate a contrast to 2:16. Many commentaries support this interpretation. For example, Gordon Fee. Also Tony Popr in personal correspondence with the author. (KJV, NJB)
2. The word *alla* means "but," showing a contrast to the text preceding 2:17. (BSB, NIV, NET, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you translate 2:17 as a continuation of rather than a contrast to 2:16. This may mean that you do not need to translate *alla* explicitly. Many English translations have left it implicit, as English does not always need a conjunction to indicate a further thought. Or you may need to use a "Yes" or a "No" at the beginning of 2:17 in your translation. This will depend on what part of 2:16 the main idea of 2:17 is adding to and agreeing with. The NJB uses "indeed" to indicate how the two verses relate.

even if I am being poured out like a drink offering on the sacrifice and service of your faith: Here Paul used a figure of speech to describe his situation. He referred to two different kinds of offerings. The Jewish priests killed animals on the altar as sacrifices. To accompany this they also poured wine out on the ground or on the dead animal (Numbers 15:1–12). This was called a drink offering. Paul compared the Philippians to the animal sacrifice, and he compared himself to the drink offering that completed their sacrifice.

Unbelievers were persecuting the Philippians because they chose to worship God and obey the good news of Jesus Christ. So their lives were like a sacrifice offered to God. Paul was suffering in prison and was in danger of death because he had preached the good news to many people. So he was like the drink offering that the priest poured on top of another offering. This does not mean that either Paul or the Philippians were about to die, though the drink offering could mean that Paul's blood would soon to be poured out when he was executed.

If in your culture people do not sacrifice animals or make drink offerings, this metaphor may be very difficult for your readers to understand. If so, it will be important to make the comparison very clear in your translation. Or you may need to leave out the metaphor altogether and translate only the meaning behind it.

even if I am being poured out: The Greek verb here is in the present tense, but there are two ways in which that tense is understood here:

1. It should be translated as "even if I am to be poured out...." Paul used the present tense to refer to the future. He knew that the Romans might execute him. He was comparing the "pouring out" with the possibility of his death. (RSV, GNT, NJB, REB, NCV, CEV, NLT)
2. It should be translated as "even if I am being poured out...." Paul was referring to the suffering that he was already experiencing. (BSB, NIV, GW, NASB, NRSV, NET)

There is stronger support in commentaries and English versions for interpretation (1). Also see 2 Timothy 4:6, where Paul used the same verb to speak of his approaching death. Those who argue for interpretation (2) say that in the larger context of the letter, Paul nowhere suggested that he expected to die as the result of being in prison. In fact, Paul stated the opposite in 1:25b: "I know that I will remain [alive] and that I will continue with all of you." See also 1:24 and 2:24. When he used the image of "sacrifice" in 2:17a, referring to

the Philippian believers, Paul was not suggesting that they would die because they followed Christ. And in the same way, when Paul referred to himself as being like a “drink offering,” he did not mean that he would die rather than be released from prison. When he talked about a “drink offering” and a “sacrifice,” he was more likely referring to the fact that he and they struggled and suffered as believers. Also Paul used the present tense here (“I am being poured out”), not the future tense (“I will be poured out”). This also implies that he was talking about the suffering he was experiencing when he was writing the letter, not what would happen to him later. The following shows how this interpretation might be translated: I am suffering because of the good news, just as you are suffering because you believe it. Nevertheless, I am glad and rejoice with you all.

the sacrifice and service: This is a figure of speech in which the two words sacrifice and service refer to the same idea. So you could more clearly translate this as “the sacrificial service” or “the sacrificial offering” or “the offering of the sacrifice.” Their sacrifice is another way to say that the Philippians had been dedicated to God, as a sacrifice is dedicated to God.

of your faith: A literal translation of the Greek is “of your faith.” There are two basic ways to interpret this phrase:

1. Their faith was the reason or the motive for their “sacrifice”. (NIV, GNT, NCV)
2. Their faith was the “sacrifice.” The sacrificial offering represents the fact that they believed. For example:

Your faith in the Lord and your service are like a sacrifice offered to him. (CEV) (CEV)

The first interpretation seems to be the more likely one in this context. So it is recommended that you follow it (1). The sacrifice was broader than just faith. It consisted of their lives wholly committed to God (SSA).

General Comment on 2:17a

Here is a possible way you could translate 2:17a adding a lot of implicit information:

I may still have to die as a result of my work. When you believed God’s message, you gave yourselves to God like a priest offering a sacrifice to God. If the Romans kill me, then I will be like wine that the priest would pour over your sacrifice as an additional offering.

2:17b

I am glad and rejoice with all of you.

- But I am still happy and rejoice with you all.
- But I am nevertheless glad and I am rejoicing with you all.

I am glad and rejoice: In Greek these two verbs come from the same root verb and they can be literally translated as “I rejoice and I rejoice with [you].” Paul rejoiced because it was a privilege to suffer for Jesus Christ. And he said that he rejoiced with the Philippians because they believed the gospel that he preached, and they, like himself, were willing to suffer for their faith. See notes on 2:16c.

General Comment on 2:17

In some languages it may be necessary to reorder 2:17 and place 2:17b before 2:17a. For example:

I am glad and rejoice with you all, even though I am about to be poured out like a drink offering on the sacrifice that you offer to God because you believe.

Philippians 2:18

Section 2:12–18: Believers should obey God so that they show other people how God wants people to behave

Paul reminded the Philippian believers that when they obeyed God as Jesus did (2:6–8), God would help them to give the gospel to those in spiritual darkness. As long as they were faithful, Paul knew that his work and even his suffering would not be in vain.

Paragraph 2:17–18

Even though Paul’s work caused him to suffer, he was rejoicing and so should the Philippians.

2:18

So you too should be glad and rejoice with me.

- In the same way you too should be happy and rejoice together with me.
- And, because of that, you too should be glad and rejoice along with me.

you too should be glad and rejoice with me: Paul was asking the Philippians to rejoice about what had happened (and was happening) to them. He was also asking them to share his joy about what was happening to him. Even though he was suffering and knew that he might soon die, he still wanted them to rejoice with him. The two verbs Paul used in 2:18 (glad, rejoice) are the same ones he used in 2:17b. If it is possible, you

should use the same words here in your translation as you used in 2:17b.

Philippians 2:19

Section 2:19–30: Paul discussed sending Timothy and Epaphroditus to the Philippians

Paul wrote that, as soon as he knew what would happen to him, he would send Timothy to the Philippians to tell them his news and to bring back news from them. But first Paul would send Epaphroditus. The Philippians should welcome him back and honor him.

Paragraph 2:19–24

Paul chose to send Timothy to the church at Philippi because he was the only one willing to go who truly loved the Philippian believers. But Paul wanted to wait until he found out what would happen to himself, so Timothy could bring this news to the Philippian church. Another reason Paul wanted Timothy to go to Philippi was so that Timothy could bring back news from the Philippian believers. And Paul expected that the news would be good.

2:19a

Now I hope in the Lord Jesus to send Timothy to you soon,

- ¶ If the Lord Jesus wills/permits, I hope to send Timothy to visit you soon,
- ¶ I expect to send Timothy to you soon, if that is what the Lord Jesus wants to happen,

Now: The common Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now is a connecting word that is often translated as “but”. But there is not a contrast between this section and the previous one, such as “but” would imply in English. It is also not a time word, as “now” could imply in English. Paul used this conjunction here to introduce parenthetical information. Indicate this parenthetical comment in a natural way in your language. In some languages, it may be natural to not translate this word. Some English versions also do not translate this word.

I hope in the Lord Jesus to send Timothy to you soon: Paul was planning to send Timothy to the Philippians not long after he wrote this letter (see 2:23). He expected that the Lord Jesus wanted this to happen.

hope: The word hope in English usually means that a person wants something to happen but he is not sure it will happen. In the New Testament the Greek word that the BSB translates as hope usually means that a person is confident that something will happen. In this verse Paul probably implied that these were his plans

but he knew that all his plans depended on Jesus and what he wanted.

in the Lord Jesus: In this context this phrase probably means that Paul knew that the Lord was the one who ultimately decided whether his hopes and plans would be fulfilled. It means “if the Lord Jesus wills it” or “if this is what the Lord Jesus wants to happen” (see GNT, CEV, NLT, GW).

2:19b

that I also may be cheered when I learn how you are doing.

- so that I may also be made happy when I hear good news about you.
- in order that he may make me happy by the news he brings back about you, just as the news he brings about me will make you happy.
- so that he will encourage you and he will also encourage me when he comes back and tells me how well you are doing.

that: This indicates purpose: “in order that.” Paul’s purpose in sending Timothy would be to cheer both himself and the Philippians.

also: Most commentators think that the word also means that Paul thought both he and the Philippians would be cheered. Paul was probably thinking that Timothy would make a short visit to Philippi and that he would encourage the Philippians with news from Paul. Then Timothy would return to Paul with news of the Philippians which would cheer Paul too. To make this clear, in your translation you may need to supply some of the implied information suggested in the Display.

cheered: To “cheer” someone means to make them happy, to encourage them. Some translators express this with a negative expression such as:

it will help me not to worry about you

Philippians 2:20

Section 2:19–30: Paul discussed sending Timothy and Epaphroditus to the Philippians

Paul wrote that, as soon as he knew what would happen to him, he would send Timothy to the Philippians to tell them his news and to bring back news from them. But first Paul would send Epaphroditus. The Philippians should welcome him back and honor him.

Paragraph 2:19–24

Paul chose to send Timothy to the church at Philippi because he was the only one willing to go who truly

loved the Philippian believers. But Paul wanted to wait until he found out what would happen to himself, so Timothy could bring this news to the Philippian church. Another reason Paul wanted Timothy to go to Philippi was so that Timothy could bring back news from the Philippian believers. And Paul expected that the news would be good.

2:20a

I have nobody else like him

- There is no one here with me who is as concerned about you as Timothy is.

I have nobody else like him: There are two ways to understand this part of the verse:

1. There was no one else (except perhaps Paul) as interested in the Philippians as Timothy was. (BSB, RSV, NIV, NET, NJB, GW, REB, NLT, CEV, NCV)
2. There was no one else who understood Paul as well as Timothy did. For example:

He is the only one who shares my feelings (GNT)
(NASB, GNT)

The commentators are about equally divided, but it is recommended that along with the majority of translations you follow interpretation (1). If you wish to follow interpretation (2), you may use one of the following as a model:

There is no one else here who understands how I think....

There is no one else with me who thinks the same way I do....

2:20b

who will genuinely care for your needs.

- He is truly concerned about how you are.
- He really does care about whether things are going well with you or not.

who will genuinely care for your needs: Timothy truly wanted what was best for the Philippians. He was sincerely concerned for them and wanted to help them to firmly trust God.

who will genuinely care for: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will genuinely care for is in the future tense. However, there are two ways to translate it:

1. As a present tense; (NIV, GNT, NJB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

2. As a future tense; (BSB, RSV, KJV, NASB, NET)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and use the present tense. Timothy was already concerned for the Philippians at the time Paul wrote. Translating the verb in the future tense might not convey this meaning.

your needs: This is literally “the [things] concerning you.” This refers to the situation the Philippians were in, their circumstances. Timothy was anxious to know whether the Philippians were doing well or whether they were having problems.

Philippians 2:21

Section 2:19–30: Paul discussed sending Timothy and Epaphroditus to the Philippians

Paul wrote that, as soon as he knew what would happen to him, he would send Timothy to the Philippians to tell them his news and to bring back news from them. But first Paul would send Epaphroditus. The Philippians should welcome him back and honor him.

Paragraph 2:19–24

Paul chose to send Timothy to the church at Philippi because he was the only one willing to go who truly loved the Philippian believers. But Paul wanted to wait until he found out what would happen to himself, so Timothy could bring this news to the Philippian church. Another reason Paul wanted Timothy to go to Philippi was so that Timothy could bring back news from the Philippian believers. And Paul expected that the news would be good.

2:21a

For all the others look after their own interests,

- I say this because everyone else only thinks about what he himself wants,
- I say this because everyone else who could go to Philippi is concerned primarily/only about what is important to himself,

For: The Greek conjunction (connecting word) here means “because.” It shows that 2:21 gives the reason why Paul had said there was no one else like Timothy (2:20).

all the others: The Greek here literally means “all (of them).” Some commentators think that Paul was making an overstatement (saying more than he meant) by saying that all the others have selfish interests and don’t have the interests of Jesus Christ.” Paul wrote like this to emphasize a point. The point was probably that all the other believers who could have gone to Philippi (with the exception of Epaphroditus—see

notes on 2:25a) were only concerned about their own interests. So they were not willing to go. This left only Timothy to go to Philippi and return to Paul with news from the Philippians.

So it is clear that the phrase all the others here does not literally mean “all people.” In many languages people can use such overstatements in a figurative (non-literal) sense. But if readers of your translation understand this literally, you may need to translate the non-literal meaning of 2:21a. See 2:21a in the Display.

look after their own interests: Each person was concerned only about the things that were important to himself. This implies that each of those whom Paul referred to in 2:21a was primarily interested in his own affairs and in what he himself needed and wanted.

2:21b

not those of Jesus Christ.

- instead of thinking about what Jesus Christ wants.
- and is not thinking much/primarily about what is important to Jesus Christ.

not those of Jesus Christ: Notice there is no verb here. This is because it is the same verb “look after” that was in 2:21a. However, in some languages it may be necessary to make this verb explicit here.

General Comment on 2:21

Another way to translate 2:21 as a whole could be:

For everyone is concerned about what they want instead of what Jesus Christ wants.

Philippians 2:22

Section 2:19–30: Paul discussed sending Timothy and Epaphroditus to the Philippians

Paul wrote that, as soon as he knew what would happen to him, he would send Timothy to the Philippians to tell them his news and to bring back news from them. But first Paul would send Epaphroditus. The Philippians should welcome him back and honor him.

Paragraph 2:19–24

Paul chose to send Timothy to the church at Philippi because he was the only one willing to go who truly loved the Philippian believers. But Paul wanted to wait until he found out what would happen to himself, so Timothy could bring this news to the Philippian church. Another reason Paul wanted Timothy to go to Philippi was so that Timothy could bring back news from the

Philippian believers. And Paul expected that the news would be good.

2:22a

But you know Timothy’s proven worth,

- But you already know how Timothy has shown that he is faithful.

Timothy’s proven worth: Timothy had shown (proved) by the way he had already acted that he faithfully served Christ and God’s people. He was, therefore, different from the people Paul referred to in 2:21.

2:22b

that as a child with his father he has served with me to advance the gospel.

- He serves together with me preaching the gospel like a son serves with his father.
- He has worked with me like a son works with his father so that people will hear the good news about Jesus Christ.

as a child with his father he has served with me to advance the gospel: Timothy was not Paul’s son in a literal, physical way, but Paul had taught him to know Jesus Christ and in that way was his spiritual father. Paul compared how he related to Timothy as they worked together to spread the gospel with how a father relates to his son. One way you could translate this is:

He works with me to tell the good news, helping me like a son who helps his father.

child: The BSB translates this Greek word literally as child, as many English translations do. The image is that of a son who is old enough to help or to work with his father.

served: In Greek the verb literally means “to do the work of a slave.” But here it does not mean that Timothy was literally a slave. It is figurative and means that Timothy, along with Paul, faithfully served God, as a slave would do. See “servant”, sense II.B.1b, in KBT.

to advance the gospel: That is, Timothy worked hard to tell people about Jesus Christ.

Philippians 2:23

Section 2:19–30: Paul discussed sending Timothy and Epaphroditus to the Philippians

Paul wrote that, as soon as he knew what would happen to him, he would send Timothy to the Philippians to tell them his news and to bring back news

from them. But first Paul would send Epaphroditus. The Philippians should welcome him back and honor him.

Paragraph 2:19–24

Paul chose to send Timothy to the church at Philippi because he was the only one willing to go who truly loved the Philippian believers. But Paul wanted to wait until he found out what would happen to himself, so Timothy could bring this news to the Philippian church. Another reason Paul wanted Timothy to go to Philippi was so that Timothy could bring back news from the Philippian believers. And Paul expected that the news would be good.

2:23

So I hope to send him as soon as I see what happens with me.

- So, as soon as I learn what will happen to me, I expect to send him to Philippi.
- Therefore, I expect to send him to you just as soon as I find out what will happen to me here.

So: Timothy had proved to be worthy of being Paul's representative to the Philippians. So as a result, Paul hoped to send him.

I hope: See note on 2:19a.

as soon as I see what happens with me: Paul was probably thinking of the court trial that he was waiting for and whether the Roman authorities would free him. He was saying:

So I expect to send him as soon as I learn what will happen to me.

Philippians 2:24

Section 2:19–30: Paul discussed sending Timothy and Epaphroditus to the Philippians

Paul wrote that, as soon as he knew what would happen to him, he would send Timothy to the Philippians to tell them his news and to bring back news from them. But first Paul would send Epaphroditus. The Philippians should welcome him back and honor him.

Paragraph 2:19–24

Paul chose to send Timothy to the church at Philippi because he was the only one willing to go who truly loved the Philippian believers. But Paul wanted to wait until he found out what would happen to himself, so Timothy could bring this news to the Philippian church. Another reason Paul wanted Timothy to go to Philippi was so that Timothy could bring back news from the

Philippian believers. And Paul expected that the news would be good.

2:24

And I trust in the Lord that I myself will come soon.

- And I am sure that the Lord will permit me too to visit you soon.
- I believe that the Lord wants me too to come to visit you soon.

And I trust in the Lord: This phrase is similar to the phrase in 1:14b, and similar to the phrase “I hope in the Lord” in 2:19a. But in this verse Paul felt more certain that he would go and see the Philippians. The Lord was the one who had caused Paul to be confident in this way.

that I myself will come soon: Paul believed that he also would soon be able to go and see the Philippian believers.

come: Paul was using the word come from the Philippians' point of view. If he wrote from his own point of view he would say, “I myself will go soon.” Consider whether you would best express the word come in your language as “come,” or “go,” or “return.”

soon: In this context this word means that Paul would not delay his visit to Philippi if he was released by the authorities.

Philippians 2:25

Section 2:19–30: Paul discussed sending Timothy and Epaphroditus to the Philippians

Paul wrote that, as soon as he knew what would happen to him, he would send Timothy to the Philippians to tell them his news and to bring back news from them. But first Paul would send Epaphroditus. The Philippians should welcome him back and honor him.

Paragraph 2:25–30

Some time before this letter was written, Epaphroditus brought a gift to Paul from the church in Philippi, his home town (see 4:18). While he was with Paul, Epaphroditus had become very sick, and almost died, but God had spared his life. The Philippian believers had heard about his illness. Therefore, as soon as he got well, Paul sent him back to Philippi so that the believers there would not worry.

Epaphroditus was probably the person who brought this letter to the Philippians. Therefore, Paul used past tenses in this paragraph as though Epaphroditus had already arrived in Philippi. This was because Paul was already imagining the Philippians reading the letter after Epaphroditus arrived in Philippi. However, in

some languages it may be necessary to use a present tense. Use whatever tenses are most natural in your language.

2:25a

But I thought it necessary to send back to you Epaphroditus,

- ¶ I But I have decided that it is necessary to send back to you Epaphroditus
- ¶ I But I have decided that I must send Epaphroditus back to you first.

But: This shows contrast with what Paul had just said. In 2:19–24 he had written about sending Timothy to Philippi. Here in 2:25–30 he wrote that he would send Epaphroditus first.

send back to you: This is literally “send to you” (RSV, GNT). But Paul was sending Epaphroditus back to his home town Philippi. So in many languages, it will be appropriate to use a verb that means “to send someone back to where they came from.” However, make sure your translation does not imply that Paul was sending him back because he no longer wanted him or because he thought Epaphroditus had failed. The context makes this clear.

2:25b

my brother, fellow worker, and fellow soldier,

- my/our^(incl) brother, the one who works with me to tell the gospel and who fights like a soldier with me to defend the gospel.
- He has worked together with me to tell the good news and has helped me struggle against the enemies of the gospel.

my brother: This means “my fellow Christian who is like a brother.” In some languages it is necessary to refer to Epaphroditus as “our^(incl) brother” instead of as my brother to make it clear that Epaphroditus was a Christian brother to the Philippians as well as to Paul.

In some languages it is necessary to indicate whether someone is a younger brother or an older brother in relation to someone else. No one knows how old Epaphroditus was. However, if you must choose in your language, it is probably best to consider Epaphroditus as younger than Paul.

fellow worker: This refers to a person who works together with someone else.

fellow soldier: This means that Epaphroditus was helping Paul defend the good news against those who opposed it. You could restate the metaphor fellow soldier by using a simile: “he is like a soldier fighting by my side.” In some languages it may be necessary

to say whom Paul and Epaphroditus were fighting against. Scholars do not agree about whether these enemies were human enemies of the gospel, Satan and his evil spiritual forces, or both. It is best to use a general expression like “enemies of the good news,” without saying exactly who they were.

2:25c

who is also your messenger and minister to my needs.

- You sent him to look after my needs, as your representative.
- You sent him to represent you in helping to provide me with what I needed.

messenger: This is the Greek word *apostolos* which is often translated “apostle” in the New Testament. However, the word literally means “representative” or messenger and that is how Paul used it here. Epaphroditus was not an apostle like Peter and Paul. He simply represented those who sent him, that is, the Philippians. The Philippian believers had sent him to help Paul, especially to deliver their gift to him (4:18). See “apostle”, sense 1 in KBT.

and minister to my needs: This is literally “and [your] minister of my needs.” The NIV supplies “whom you sent,” and this model may be helpful in your language also. The Philippian believers had sent Epaphroditus to bring money gifts to Paul and in this way to provide for his needs. They also apparently sent him to help Paul in other ways while he was in prison.

General Comment on 2:25

In your language it may be necessary to change the order of phrases so that the connection between 2:25 and 2:26 is clearer. One way to do this would be:

“You have sent your messenger Epaphroditus to help provide what I need. ^bAs my Christian brother he has helped me with the work of the gospel and struggles with me against the enemies of the gospel. ^aI have decided that it is necessary that I send him back to you.

Philippians 2:26

Section 2:19–30: Paul discussed sending Timothy and Epaphroditus to the Philippians

Paul wrote that, as soon as he knew what would happen to him, he would send Timothy to the Philippians to tell them his news and to bring back news from them. But first Paul would send Epaphroditus. The Philippians should welcome him back and honor him.

Paragraph 2:25–30

Some time before this letter was written, Epaphroditus brought a gift to Paul from the church in Philippi, his home town (see 4:18). While he was with Paul, Epaphroditus had become very sick, and almost died, but God had spared his life. The Philippian believers had heard about his illness. Therefore, as soon as he got well, Paul sent him back to Philippi so that the believers there would not worry.

Epaphroditus was probably the person who brought this letter to the Philippians. Therefore, Paul used past tenses in this paragraph as though Epaphroditus had already arrived in Philippi. This was because Paul was already imagining the Philippians reading the letter after Epaphroditus arrived in Philippi. However, in some languages it may be necessary to use a present tense. Use whatever tenses are most natural in your language.

2:26a

For he has been longing for all of you and is distressed

- For he really wants to see you all again and is very upset
- I am sending him back because he is very concerned for you all, and because he is very upset

For: Paul meant “because...” 2:26 is the reason for 2:25a.

he has been longing for all of you: Epaphroditus was concerned that the Philippians were worrying too much about him. He wanted very much to see them again because he cared about them. See note on the phrase “I long for all of you” in 1:8.

distressed: This word is an emotional one. Epaphroditus was concerned and upset because the Philippians were worried about him. The only other occurrences in the NT of the Greek word translated “distressed” here relate to Jesus’ very emotional experience in the Garden of Gethsemane.

2:26b

because you heard he was ill.

- because he knows that you were concerned when you heard he was ill.
- since he knows that you heard he was sick and he knows you are worrying about him.

ill: Epaphroditus had been sick. The next verse shows that he had been seriously ill.

Philippians 2:27**Section 2:19–30: Paul discussed sending Timothy and Epaphroditus to the Philippians**

Paul wrote that, as soon as he knew what would happen to him, he would send Timothy to the Philippians to tell them his news and to bring back news from them. But first Paul would send Epaphroditus. The Philippians should welcome him back and honor him.

Paragraph 2:25–30

Some time before this letter was written, Epaphroditus brought a gift to Paul from the church in Philippi, his home town (see 4:18). While he was with Paul, Epaphroditus had become very sick, and almost died, but God had spared his life. The Philippian believers had heard about his illness. Therefore, as soon as he got well, Paul sent him back to Philippi so that the believers there would not worry.

Epaphroditus was probably the person who brought this letter to the Philippians. Therefore, Paul used past tenses in this paragraph as though Epaphroditus had already arrived in Philippi. This was because Paul was already imagining the Philippians reading the letter after Epaphroditus arrived in Philippi. However, in some languages it may be necessary to use a present tense. Use whatever tenses are most natural in your language.

2:27a

He was sick indeed, nearly unto death.

- He certainly was sick. In fact, he nearly died.
- You heard correctly that he was sick. He was so sick that he almost died.

nearly unto death: Epaphroditus had been so sick that he nearly died.

2:27b

But God had mercy on him,

- However, God was merciful to him and healed him.
- But God was kind to him and did not let him die.

God had mercy on him: God was sorry for Epaphroditus. So he healed him.

Other ways to translate this phrase are:

God pitied him.

God was kind to him.

God had compassion on him.

It may be necessary to supply this implicit information that God made Epaphroditus well again.

2:27c

and not only on him but also on me,

- God was not only merciful to him, but he was also merciful to me.
- God was kind to him and he was also kind to me.

not only on him but also on me: God not only had mercy on Epaphroditus, but he also had mercy on Paul, because (2:27d) Paul would have been greatly saddened if Epaphroditus had died.

In some languages it may not be necessary to include the phrase not only on him. So the translation of 2:27b-c could just say:

God had mercy on him and also on me.

2:27d

to spare me sorrow upon sorrow.

- He did not want me to have another reason to be sad in addition to the reason I already have to be sad.
- He did not let him die so that I would not be sadder than I already am.

to spare me sorrow upon sorrow: This gives the purpose for which God showed mercy to Epaphroditus and Paul. Paul was saying, “[God had mercy on him and on me] so that I would not be even more sorrowful than I am now.” Another way to say this would be: “[God had mercy on him and on me] so that I would not suffer more than I am already suffering.” Some commentators think that the first sorrow refers to Paul being sad because Epaphroditus was sick. Others think Paul was sad because he was in prison. Commentators agree that the second sorrow would have been Paul’s added sorrow if Epaphroditus had died.

sorrow: This refers to something that causes someone to be sad.

Philippians 2:28

Section 2:19–30: Paul discussed sending Timothy and Epaphroditus to the Philippians

Paul wrote that, as soon as he knew what would happen to him, he would send Timothy to the Philippians to tell them his news and to bring back news from them. But first Paul would send Epaphroditus. The Philippians should welcome him back and honor him.

Paragraph 2:25–30

Some time before this letter was written, Epaphroditus brought a gift to Paul from the church in Philippi, his home town (see 4:18). While he was with Paul, Epaphroditus had become very sick, and almost died, but God had spared his life. The Philippian believers had heard about his illness. Therefore, as soon as he got well, Paul sent him back to Philippi so that the believers there would not worry.

Epaphroditus was probably the person who brought this letter to the Philippians. Therefore, Paul used past tenses in this paragraph as though Epaphroditus had already arrived in Philippi. This was because Paul was already imagining the Philippians reading the letter after Epaphroditus arrived in Philippi. However, in some languages it may be necessary to use a present tense. Use whatever tenses are most natural in your language.

2:28a

Therefore I am all the more eager to send him,

- So I am sending him all the more eagerly,
- That is why I want even more than before to send him back to you,

Therefore: You could translate this as “So...” or “For this reason...” or “That is why...” In 2:27 Paul gave his reason for wanting to send Epaphroditus back.

I am all the more eager to send him: Probably Paul already wanted to send Epaphroditus back to thank the Philippian believers for their gifts and to let them know how he was doing. But after Epaphroditus got sick and then recovered, Paul wanted even more eagerly to send him back so that the Philippians would know that he was no longer sick. Therefore, Paul said here that he was all the more eager to send him.

send him: It may be necessary to supply the implied information of where Paul was sending Epaphroditus:

send him back to you

2:28b

so that when you see him again you may rejoice,

- so that you may see him again and be happy,

so that when you see him again you may rejoice: Paul wanted to send Epaphroditus back in order to make the Philippian believers happy. Presumably they would be happy to see Epaphroditus again. And they would also be happy and relieved to know that he was no longer sick.

again: Translations differ in how they understand the word again:

1. again goes with the verb “see.” The Philippians would see Epaphroditus again after his absence in Rome. (BSB, NIV, RSV, NET, GW, REB, NJB, KJV, NASB)
2. again goes with the verb “rejoice.” When they saw Epaphroditus safe and well, the Philippians would be happy once more. (GNT)

Although both interpretations are possible from the order of the Greek words, there is no reason why Paul would have spoken of the Philippians rejoicing again when he had not mentioned them rejoicing before in this letter. So it is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

2:28c

and I may be less anxious.

- and so that I also may have less to worry about by knowing that you are happy.

and I may be less anxious: Paul was sending Epaphroditus back to relieve two problems. It would mean that the Philippians would no longer worry about Epaphroditus. And it would also mean that Paul would no longer be anxious about the Philippians because they were worrying about Epaphroditus.

less anxious: The normal meaning of the Greek word that the BSB translates as less anxious is “without pain.” In this context, it does not refer to physical pain, but anxiety or sorrow. Most commentators agree that this form of the Greek word does not mean that Paul would have no sorrow/anxiety, but that his sorrow/anxiety would be lessened.

Philippians 2:29

Section 2:19–30: Paul discussed sending Timothy and Epaphroditus to the Philippians

Paul wrote that, as soon as he knew what would happen to him, he would send Timothy to the Philippians to tell them his news and to bring back news from them. But first Paul would send Epaphroditus. The Philippians should welcome him back and honor him.

Paragraph 2:25–30

Some time before this letter was written, Epaphroditus brought a gift to Paul from the church in Philippi, his home town (see 4:18). While he was with Paul, Epaphroditus had become very sick, and almost died, but God had spared his life. The Philippian believers had heard about his illness. Therefore, as soon as he got well, Paul sent him back to Philippi so that the believers there would not worry.

Epaphroditus was probably the person who brought this letter to the Philippians. Therefore, Paul used past tenses in this paragraph as though Epaphroditus had already arrived in Philippi. This was because Paul was already imagining the Philippians reading the letter after Epaphroditus arrived in Philippi. However, in some languages it may be necessary to use a present tense. Use whatever tenses are most natural in your language.

2:29

In this verse Paul strongly exhorted the Philippians to accept Epaphroditus back happily. It is not clear why Paul had to encourage them to do this. It is possible that he thought that the Philippians might have been angry at Epaphroditus for returning so soon. They had expected him to stay and care for Paul. Thus Paul tried to assure them of how valuable Epaphroditus had been to him, and to convince them that the change of plans was truly what God wanted. Or Paul may simply have been encouraging them to joyfully accept Epaphroditus back, which he expected they would do, as 2:28b implies.

2:29a

Welcome him in the Lord with great joy,

- So receive him back very joyfully as your brother in the Lord.
- Rejoice that you can welcome your Christian brother back home.

Welcome him in the Lord with great joy: The Philippians should receive Epaphroditus back very happily as their Christian brother.

in the Lord: There are several ways to understand this phrase. The two main ones are:

1. The Philippians should receive Epaphroditus as a brother in the Lord, because he too belonged to the Lord. (GNT, REB)
2. They should welcome Epaphroditus as they should welcome another Christian, in an appropriate manner. (See SSA). (CEV, NLT, GW, CEV)

Most English versions are ambiguous and it may be possible for you to leave this phrase ambiguous in your translation too. The Display illustrates interpretation (1). If you wish to follow the second interpretation (2), you could say:

Welcome him with great joy in the way you should welcome another believer.

2:29b

and honor men like him,

- You should honor him and people like him
- Respect him and others who are like him.

honor men like him: The phrase honor men like him means that they should honor him and other men also. Paul reminded the Philippians that they should respect Epaphroditus and other men who were like him.

men like him: This refers to Christians who were faithful to the Lord as Epaphroditus had been. The Greek phrase literally means “such ones.” So you could translate this so as to include women as well as men.

Philippians 2:30

Section 2:19–30: Paul discussed sending Timothy and Epaphroditus to the Philippians

Paul wrote that, as soon as he knew what would happen to him, he would send Timothy to the Philippians to tell them his news and to bring back news from them. But first Paul would send Epaphroditus. The Philippians should welcome him back and honor him.

Paragraph 2:25–30

Some time before this letter was written, Epaphroditus brought a gift to Paul from the church in Philippi, his home town (see 4:18). While he was with Paul, Epaphroditus had become very sick, and almost died, but God had spared his life. The Philippian believers had heard about his illness. Therefore, as soon as he got well, Paul sent him back to Philippi so that the believers there would not worry.

Epaphroditus was probably the person who brought this letter to the Philippians. Therefore, Paul used past tenses in this paragraph as though Epaphroditus had already arrived in Philippi. This was because Paul was already imagining the Philippians reading the letter after Epaphroditus arrived in Philippi. However, in some languages it may be necessary to use a present tense. Use whatever tenses are most natural in your language.

2:30a

because he nearly died for the work of Christ, risking his life

- because he almost died in order to serve Christ and he risked his life
- Honor him because he risked his life and almost died as a result of doing Christ’s work.

because: The Greek word could also be translated “since.” This verse explains why the Philippians should honor Epaphroditus.

for the work of Christ: That is, Epaphroditus was serving Christ when he went to help Paul.

risking his life: This repeats the same idea as “he almost died.” A person is risking his life when he does something that might cause him to die. Paul did not say what this was, but it was probably whatever caused Epaphroditus to become sick.

It may be necessary in some languages to reverse these two phrases. See the second Meaning Line in the Display.

2:30b

to make up for your deficit of service to me.

- in order to represent you in helping as you could not do in person.
- He did this so that he could help me in the ways that you are not able to do because you could not come here.

to make up for your deficit of service to me: The Philippian believers wanted to help Paul, but they could not all go to Rome. So they had sent Epaphroditus with their gifts to help Paul. He represented them as he helped Paul. One way you could translate this more clearly is:

He helped me as you would have if you had been here.

Be sure your translation does not sound as if Paul were complaining that the Philippians had not done enough for him.

Philippians 3:1

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

3:1a

Finally, my brothers, rejoice in the Lord.

- ¶ Furthermore, my brothers and sisters in Christ, rejoice because of the Lord.
- ¶ My brothers, concerning other matters, be happy because you belong to the Lord.

Finally: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Finally is to loipon, which literally means “[for] the rest.” There are different views about what it means here.

1. Some commentators say that it indicates a change to a new topic and that it is best translated as “furthermore” or “concerning other matters.” For example:

Now then... (GW)

Whatever happens... (NLT)

And now... (REB) (GW, REB, NLT)

1. Other commentators think that it indicates that Paul meant to end his letter at this point. When he changed his mind and began writing about another topic, he left this word in the middle of his letter. (BSB, GNT, RSV, NIV, NET, KJV, NASB, NJB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1). If in your language you have no way to show such a change in topic, you may need to leave to loipon untranslated (as in NCV).

my brothers: The term brothers here refers to other Christians, fellow believers, not to literal brothers. You might translate this as “brothers and sisters,” “older and younger siblings” or “relatives.” The term brothers also occurs in 1:12, 3:13, 3:17, 4:1, 4:8. See note on 1:12a.

rejoice in the Lord: The following rephrasings of rejoice in the Lord help to show what it means as well as how you might translate it:

rejoice because of what the Lord has done for you

be very happy because you belong to the Lord

rejoice: The Greek word for rejoice here means “be happy.”

Paragraph 3:1b–4a

Paul told the Philippians to be on their guard against people who called themselves Christians but were teaching that Gentile Christians must become like Jews as well as trusting Christ. Paul made it clear that

God saves people because of what Jesus has done for them, not because they obey the Jewish laws.

3:1b

It is no trouble for me to write the same things to you again,

- ¶ I do not mind repeating what I told you before,
- ¶ It does not bother me to tell you again what I told you before,

It is no trouble for me to write the same things to you again: Paul was saying that he was willing to repeat things the Philippians had heard before. He did not mind doing it, because he knew it was helpful.

the same things: This phrase has been understood as referring to

1. warnings Paul had given the Philippians earlier, in other letters or when he was with them. Translations that begin a new paragraph at 3:1b are following this interpretation. (NRSV, NJB, REB)
2. the commands to rejoice that Paul had given in 2:18 and 3:1. Paul had already talked about rejoicing in 1:18; 2:2; and 2:19. These versions put 3:1a and 3:1b in the same paragraph and begin a new paragraph with 3:2. (BSB, RSV, NET, CEV, NASB, NLT)

The first interpretation is recommended (1). Paul here began to discuss again the warnings he had given them earlier and said they were necessary for the spiritual safety of the Philippian believers.

You could translate the phrase the same things as:

the advice I gave you before

3:1c

and it is a safeguard for you.

- and it will be protection for you.
- because these things will guard you against false teachers.

it is a safeguard for you: This means that if the Philippians listened attentively to Paul’s repeated warnings, they would be protected from false teachers. Paul did not want other people to deceive the believers. He wanted to prevent the Philippians from being confused about what they believed, and he wanted to help them avoid others who would harm them spiritually.

a safeguard: The Greek here is an adjective meaning “safe.” In your language it may be possible to translate it with an adjective describing the warnings as providing safety, or describing the Philippians:

you will be safer (GNT)

Or it may be better to use a noun:

a protection (NJB)

Or a verb:

protect

Philippians 3:2

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul's example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:1b–4a

Paul told the Philippians to be on their guard against people who called themselves Christians but were teaching that Gentile Christians must become like Jews as well as trusting Christ. Paul made it clear that God saves people because of what Jesus has done for them, not because they obey the Jewish laws.

3:2

Most commentators agree that the three warnings in this verse all refer to the same group of people. These warnings are about “dogs,” “men who do evil,” and “mutilators.” These apparently were a group of Jews who had become Christians. They were called Judaizers. They were teaching that all Christians had to obey the Jewish laws in order to be true Christians. Paul strongly opposed this teaching and emphasized that people became members of God's people through spiritual, not physical, change.

3:2a

Watch out for those dogs,

- Look out for those evil people who are like dogs.
- Do not be deceived by those who are like pagans,

Watch out for: This means “beware of.” It was a warning to not believe what the Judaizers taught. Some translations say: “do not be deceived by...” or “do not believe...”

those dogs: Jews often referred to Gentiles as dogs. This was because Jews considered dogs to be unclean animals, and they thought that Gentiles were also ritually unclean. See also Psalm 22:16 and Mark 7:24–30. In this verse Paul turned the idea around. He was saying that the Judaizers were evil and were like dogs. They were like pagans because their teaching was completely wrong.

In some languages, using the term dogs may give some other meaning that is not appropriate for this context. It may be possible to use a general term for “dangerous, dirty animal” or it may be best to translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example, it may be possible to translate the phrase those dogs as:

those who act like nonbelievers

3:2b

those workers of evil,

- Beware of them because what they do is evil.
- those people who do evil deeds.

those workers of evil: This makes it clear that the term “dogs” refers to people who are workers of evil. It does not refer to a second group of people.

General Comment on 3:2a–b

In some languages it may be helpful to change the order of these two phrases. For example:

beware of those who do evil things, who are like a pack of dirty dogs

3:2c

those mutilators of the flesh!

- They wrongly insist that males who want to be Christians must be circumcised.
- They are cutting up men's bodies for nothing.

those mutilators of the flesh: This is a third description of the same group of people. They are described as mutilators, literally “the mutilation” or “the cutting up.” This is a play on the Greek word for “circumcision,” which literally means “the cutting around.”

“Circumcision” is the cutting off of a band of skin, called the foreskin, from around the end of the penis. One of the Jewish laws stated that all Jewish males

and converts to Judaism had to be circumcised as a symbol that they belonged to God. The Judaizers were teaching that non-Jewish converts to Christianity must also be circumcised. Here in 3:2c Paul opposed this teaching. He said the Judaizers were like people who destroy something by cutting it up or chopping it into pieces. Paul was saying that circumcision was no longer necessary to become part of God's people and so he used this forceful language to speak against these people by calling them mutilators of the flesh.

In some cultures where circumcision is not known, it would be helpful to explain the custom of circumcising people in a footnote or in a glossary. Make sure it is clear that they did not cut off the whole penis but only the small ring of skin around the end of it. If it is not proper in your culture to refer to sex organs, make sure you use acceptable terms here.

In most languages it will not be possible to keep Paul's play on words in the translation. But look for some way to make a contrast between "circumcision" (or "cutting around") and "mutilation" (or "cutting up").

Philippians 3:3

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul's example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:1b–4a

Paul told the Philippians to be on their guard against people who called themselves Christians but were teaching that Gentile Christians must become like Jews as well as trusting Christ. Paul made it clear that God saves people because of what Jesus has done for them, not because they obey the Jewish laws.

3:3a

For it is we who are the circumcision,

- For it is we^(incl) who are truly God's people.
- I say this because we^(incl) are God's true people not these people.

we: The word we in this verse includes the Philippians as well as Paul. In some languages it may be necessary to make it clear that the word does not include the Judaizers. For example:

It is we^(incl), not them, who are the circumcision....

the circumcision: When Paul was referred to himself and the Philippians as the circumcision, he meant that they were the true people of God.

3:3b

we who worship by the Spirit of God,

- We^(incl) are the ones who worship with the help of the Holy Spirit of God.
- God's Spirit helps us^(incl) worship [him/God].

worship by the Spirit of God: There is a textual problem with this part of the verse. The two possibilities are:

1. "worship by/in the Spirit of God"; (BSB, NIV, NET, NASB, NJB, REB, CEV, NRSV)
2. "worship God by/in the Spirit/spirit"; (RSV, KJV, NLT; probably GNT, NCV)

There is no real difference in meaning. It is recommended that you follow the first option (1). Paul was saying that true believers worship with the help of God's Spirit. However, in some languages it will be necessary to supply an object for worship. If this is true in your language, you should use "God" as the object of worship.

Some ideas for translating 3:3b are:

We worship God because his Spirit helps us.

God's Spirit is the one who helps us to worship God/him.

the Spirit of God: This refers to the Holy Spirit.

General Comment on 3:3a–b

One way to translate 3:3a–b is:

We are the true people of God, for by means of God's Holy Spirit we worship God.

3:3c

who glory in Christ Jesus, and who put no confidence in the flesh—

- We^(incl) glorify Christ Jesus and do not depend on our^(incl) own human efforts

- We^(incl) take pride in Christ Jesus and depend on him, rather than depending on what we^(incl) have done in order for God to save us^(incl).

who glory in Christ Jesus: Here Paul was saying that true believers are proud only of Christ Jesus, and depend only on Christ Jesus to save them.

glory: In this context the Greek word *kauchaomai*, that the BSB translates as glory, means “to be proud of something,” “to boast about something” or “to rejoice about something.” The same Greek word was used in 2:16 though the form and context are slightly different.

Some ways to translate the whole phrase are:

We boast because Christ Jesus is the one who saves us.

Christ Jesus is the one we are proud of.

and who put no confidence in the flesh: This says the same thing as the previous clause but in a negative way. The believer cannot depend on anything but Christ. He cannot trust traditional ceremonies, such as circumcision, or any achievements of his own.

put...confidence: In Greek this is one word, a verb that means “to trust in something, to rely/depend on something or someone.”

flesh: The BSB translates this from the Greek word *sarx*, which literally means flesh. This word *sarx* is an important term in the New Testament. However, it is used in different ways in different contexts. It is important, therefore, to make the meaning clear in each passage and not just translate it literally.

In this passage (3:3–6), *sarx* refers to human tradition, human effort, things to do with the earthly life, and more specifically, things that are outward or external. Paul made a clear contrast between the earthly (3:3–6) and the spiritual (3:7–11). See “flesh” in KBT.

Here are some ideas for how to translate the phrase “who put no confidence in the flesh”:

We do not depend on earthly/physical things.

We do not believe God will save us because of the things we do as humans.

We do not depend on earthly behavior like circumcision to save us.

General Comment on 3:2–3

Some translations have avoided using the idea of “circumcision” in 3:2–3. See 3:2c and 3:3a in the Display. However, circumcision is a very important term in the Bible and at some point you will have to decide how to translate it. Some translations say “cutting ritual,” “cutting ceremony” or “body-cutting ceremony.” Others have tried to follow the Greek and use a word that means circular cutting or cutting around. If you have a glossary in your translation, make sure that you explain the term clearly there.

Philippians 3:4

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:1b–4a

Paul told the Philippians to be on their guard against people who called themselves Christians but were teaching that Gentile Christians must become like Jews as well as trusting Christ. Paul made it clear that God saves people because of what Jesus has done for them, not because they obey the Jewish laws.

3:4a

though I myself could have such confidence.

- though I myself have good reasons to depend on my own efforts.
- This is true even though I myself have many reasons, according to the way people think, to trust in what I have done.

though I myself could have such confidence: It may be helpful in your language to make this a separate sentence. Paul is saying something that is qualifying his previous statement. To show this you may need to begin this clause with a phrase like:

However, it is true that...

I myself: The Greek emphasizes the first person singular pronoun, I. One way of doing this in English is I myself. (BSB, NIV, NJB, REB, RSV.) If you use emphatic pronouns in your language, you may be able to use one here.

could have such confidence: The text in 3:5–6 lists these reasons. The phrase could have such confidence is one word in Greek. It literally means “grounds/reason for trust.” In some languages it may be necessary to translate it with one or more verbs. For example, the SSA suggests:

could very well rely on them (SSA)

such: The BSB has included this word to connect this verse back to the “confidence in the flesh” that Paul referred to in 3:3c. Paul was referring to why he would have reasons, from a human point of view, to trust in who he was or what he had done, or to depend on human tradition.

Paragraph 3:4b–6b

Paul was saying, “If it would do any good, I could trust in my Jewish background and my custom of strictly following the Jewish laws, in order that God would consider me, more than anyone else, as one who belongs to him.”

Translator’s Notes places a paragraph break here (see also SSA) as do some English versions. Other English versions keep 3:4b together with 3:4a. This is perhaps because it divides up a single Greek sentence.

3:4b

If anyone else thinks he has grounds for confidence in the flesh, I have more:

- ¶ If anyone thinks that he has good reasons to depend on such human things, I have even more reasons than he does to think that way.
- ¶ I am better qualified than anyone else to depend on my own efforts.

Paul was not saying that he actually depended on his human background. He made it clear in 3:7–11 that it is useless to trust in such things. He was saying the if human background was important, he had a great human background to depend on. In some translations this may need to be made explicit by including a phrase such as the following at the beginning of this paragraph:

Suppose it were true that the things of this world were important....

If anyone else thinks he has grounds for confidence in the flesh: This is an “if” clause, but Paul did not intend to express doubt. He knew that some people, those he was criticizing, did rely on the flesh. In some languages a literal translation may suggest that there is doubt about whether there are any such people. So it may be necessary to say something like “Since some people think they can trust....”

he has grounds for confidence: The verb that the BSB translates as has grounds for confidence is from the same root as the noun translated as “put...confidence” in 3:3c. See note there. It could be translated as “he can rely/depend on” or “he has grounds for trusting.”

I have more: Paul was saying, “I have more reasons to trust in earthly things than he does.” Another way you could state this is:

I am better qualified than anyone else to depend on physical things and human tradition.

Philippians 3:5

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:4b–6b

Paul was saying, “If it would do any good, I could trust in my Jewish background and my custom of strictly following the Jewish laws, in order that God would consider me, more than anyone else, as one who belongs to him.”

Translator’s Notes places a paragraph break here (see also SSA) as do some English versions. Other English versions keep 3:4b together with 3:4a. This is perhaps because it divides up a single Greek sentence.

3:5a
circumcised on the eighth day,

- I was circumcised when I was a week old, just as God commanded our^(excl) ancestors.
- Here are my reasons: When I was seven days old, Jewish religious leaders circumcised me as God's law said.

In 3:5–6 Paul listed the reasons why he could have trusted in human tradition and his own efforts, if such a thing had been important. His comments fit into two groups. First he listed four things that showed that he was a true Jew (3:5a–c), things that were true about him from the time he was born, not relating to anything he did. Then he listed three things that were the result of what he himself did (3:5d–3:6b). These seven things could have given him reason to be proud of what he was as a Jew. But he chose not to depend on these things.

In your translation you might put a comment at the beginning of 3:5 to show that Paul was giving a list in 3:5–6 of the reasons why he could trust in earthly things. See the second Meaning Line in the Display for 3:5a.

circumcised on the eighth day: One reason Paul could claim to be a true Jew was that he had been circumcised. God's law, given through Moses, required this of all Jewish males; it said that they were to be circumcised on the eighth day. This was a sign that they were born as members of God's chosen people. So Paul was saying that he had been circumcised, just as the law commanded.

circumcised: See notes on 3:3a for the meaning of circumcised. If your language does not use passive verbs, you will need to say who circumcised Paul. Normally it was Jewish religious leaders who performed this ceremony.

on the eighth day: By the Jewish method of counting, the day a baby was born was his first day. So on the eighth day means when he was seven days or one week old. Make sure you use the method of counting used by your culture.

Notice that the first meaning line in the Display says "just as God commanded our (excl) ancestors." The exclusive form of "our" here means that since the Philippians were Gentiles, they did not have the same ancestors as the Jews. See also the meaning lines for 3:5d, 3:6a and 3:6b.

3:5b

of the people of Israel, of the tribe of Benjamin;

- I belong to the people of Israel. In fact, I belong to the tribe of Benjamin.

- I am a descendant of Jacob and even from his son, Benjamin.

of the people of Israel: Paul was a descendant of Jacob. God changed Jacob's name to Israel and his descendants were known as the people of Israel. So Paul could say he was related to all the Israelites.

of the tribe of Benjamin: Only a few Jews were able to list the names of their ancestors going back to the beginning of one of the tribes of Israel. But Paul knew that he was a descendant of Benjamin. This means that he belonged to the tribe of Benjamin, who was one of the twelve sons of Jacob. Some commentators say that it was a special privilege to be a descendant of Benjamin. For example, according to Hawthorne, there are many reasons why the Jews considered it a special privilege to be a descendant of the tribe of Benjamin. This list includes only a few of these reasons: (a) Benjamin was one of the two favorite sons of Jacob, whose mother was Rachel, Jacob's favorite wife. (b) Benjamin was the only one of Jacob's twelve sons who was born in the promised land of Canaan. (c) Israel's first king, Saul, came from the tribe of Benjamin. (d) Jerusalem and the temple were located in the territory of Benjamin. (e) The tribe of Benjamin remained loyal to King David when the kingdom was divided between Judah and Israel. Two ideas for translation are:

I belong to the tribe of Benjamin.

I even come from the family of Benjamin.

tribe: The sons of Jacob were the leaders of their own families, which in time became clans because each son had many descendants. They also called each clan a tribe, even though all the clans or tribes spoke the same language, Hebrew.

3:5c

a Hebrew of Hebrews;

- I am a pure Hebrew and my ancestors were also pure Hebrews.
- My parents were Hebrews, so I too am a Hebrew.

a Hebrew of Hebrews: Paul was saying that he was a true Jew and so were his parents. You could restate this as:

I am a true Hebrew, born of true Hebrews.

Hebrew: Some commentators say that the word Hebrew refers to those who were racially pure as Jews,

with no Gentile blood in them. Others say it refers to Jews who followed the traditional customs, who still spoke the Hebrew language, and who considered themselves to be religious Jews. Still others say the word Hebrew has both of the above meanings. Other Jews not called Hebrews spoke more Greek and had adopted more of the Greek ways. See Acts 6:1 for an example of conflict between these Jews and Jews called “Hebrews.” Paul was born outside Palestine, in Tarsus, but he insisted that he was a true Hebrew.

3:5d

as to the law, a Pharisee;

- As far as obeying the law of Moses I was a Pharisee.
- I very carefully obeyed all the laws that our^(excl) ancestors gave us^(excl) because I was a Pharisee.

After listing the things that were true of him since he was born, Paul here listed the three things he had done of which he could have been proud.

as to the law, a Pharisee: If anyone questioned whether Paul followed the Jewish laws, his answer was that he was (or had been) a Pharisee. In some languages it will be necessary to use the verb “to be” here. If so, it is necessary to decide which tense to use. Most likely Paul was thinking, as with 3:6a–b, of what he had been, before he became a Christian and so it is better to use a past tense: “in regard to the law I was a Pharisee.” Most English versions which supply a verb here follow this (GNT, NET, NLT, GW, NJB) and it also has good commentary support.

as to: This phrase in 3:5d and the next two phrases in 3:6 start with the same word in Greek: kata. This preposition can be translated in several ways, including, as in the NIV, in regard to. In some languages it is possible to translate it the same way each time, but in other languages it may be necessary to vary the expression.

the law: This refers to the Jewish religious laws in general and to the laws of Moses in particular, on which the religious laws were based.

Pharisee: The Pharisees were a group within Judaism who were particularly strict about obeying the Jewish laws. They were very concerned about each point in the law. Before he became a Christian, Paul had faithfully followed the teachings and practices of this group.

You could translate the word Pharisee as “the Pharisee group.” This is an important word that should be in your glossary if you have one. See “Pharisee” in KBT. Many readers know the name Pharisee because they have read the gospels. In some languages it may be

necessary to explain in this context who the Pharisees were. If this is so in your language, you could use a footnote, or include some implicit information in your translation. For example:

I was a Pharisee, which meant that I carefully obeyed the law.

I was a member of the Pharisee group, who thoroughly follow the law.

Philippians 3:6

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:4b–6b

Paul was saying, “If it would do any good, I could trust in my Jewish background and my custom of strictly following the Jewish laws, in order that God would consider me, more than anyone else, as one who belongs to him.”

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3:6a

as to zeal, persecuting the church;

- I wanted so strongly to do what I thought God wanted me to do that I made the followers of Jesus suffer.
- I was so loyal to what I thought would please God that I greatly harmed the disciples of Christ.

zeal: The word zeal means “a strong feeling in favor of something.” Here it means that Paul strongly desired to be religious and to encourage people to honor God. This was an attitude that the Jews highly respected.

You could translate the word zeal (or the phrase “as for zeal”) as:

I strongly desired to honor God.

persecuting the church: Before Paul became a believer, he had greatly harmed those who followed Christ. He beat some, put others in prison and caused others to die (Acts 8:1–3, 9:1–2). He did this because he thought they were against the Jewish laws and the Jewish religion. He thought the best way he could serve God was to get rid of Jesus’ disciples.

the church: This refers to Christ’s followers, not to any building they met in. You could translate this as “those who believed in Jesus” or “the people who followed Jesus.”

3:6b

as to righteousness in the law, faultless.

- In obeying our^(excl) Jewish laws, I was as righteous as a person could become because I obeyed them all.
- No one could find any cause for blame in me, because I obeyed all the Jewish laws.

righteousness in the law: This is literally “righteousness that is in law.” This law refers to the law of Moses, found in the first five books of the Old Testament. Paul meant that he did what was right according to the Jewish laws. He was righteous in an external or legal sense. But this is different from being righteous according to God’s standard, which is based on what people think and desire, not just what they do.

faultless: When Paul wrote this letter, he knew he was a sinner. But here in 3:6 he was thinking about the time before he believed in Christ. He claimed that at that previous time he had obeyed all the Jewish laws. No one could have blamed him or said he was at fault for disobeying any of the Jewish laws. You could translate the word faultless here as “no one could find one law that I disobeyed.” In some languages it may be helpful to reverse the order in this phrase. For example:

There is no one who can accuse me of disobeying the law, because I obeyed it all.

Philippians 3:7

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of

doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:7–11

Paul was continuing to write against the Judaizers. In the last paragraph he listed all the things that he used to be proud of (3:5–6). In this paragraph (3:7–9) he said that he now considered all these things to be useless. Nothing mattered to him besides knowing Jesus Christ better.

3:7a

But whatever was gain to me

- ¶ But the things I formerly considered to be so valuable,
- ¶ But the things I formerly depended on for God to save me,
- ¶ But the things that previously made me proud as a Jew,

whatever was gain to me: Paul was referring mainly to the things he had mentioned in 3:5–6. These were things that he could be proud of as a person and as a Jew. But in his relation to Jesus Christ, these things did not make him proud. They did not help him to know Jesus Christ better.

gain: This term was used in business transactions to refer to financial gain. But Paul was using the term as a metaphor to mean “advantage” in general. In some languages it may be necessary to drop the metaphor and translate this meaning. Some ways to do this are:

the things for which I thought God accepted me

everything I mistakenly thought I could trust in so that God would save me

3:7b

I count as loss for the sake of Christ.

- I now consider as worthless because of my relationship to Christ.
- I rejected those things because they have no value as far as my relationship to Christ is concerned.

I count as loss for the sake of Christ: After he came to know Jesus Christ, Paul thought about the things he was formerly proud of in a new way. He realized that they were worthless in comparison to knowing Christ. And he chose to count them as without value so that he could belong to Christ.

I count: The Greek verb form here could be translated as:

I have come to realize

I have come to regard [them]

loss: Like “gain” in 3:7a, loss was a term used in business transactions. It referred to financial loss. Paul was using the term as a metaphor to refer to the uselessness of his worldly advantages. There are two possible ways to translate this Greek word:

1. something that does not help, that is worthless or without value. In the context of 3:7b, you could translate this as:

these things did not help me to know Christ (GW, NLT, CEV, NCV, REB)

1. something that harms, hinders or prevents something from happening (NET). This would mean that the things Paul used to be proud of actually hindered him from knowing Christ. In the context of 3:7b, you could translate this as:

these things hindered me from knowing Christ

The immediate context (in particular 3:8) strongly supports interpretation (1). It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

for the sake of: The Greek preposition that the BSB translates as for the sake of occurs three times in 3:7 and 3:8. It could also be translated as:

because of

on account of

General Comment on 3:7

Two versions give additional ideas for translation:

But Christ has shown me that what I once thought was valuable is worthless. (CEV)

But because of Christ, I have come to consider all these advantages I had as disadvantages. (JB)

Philippians 3:8

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:7–11

Paul was continuing to write against the Judaizers. In the last paragraph he listed all the things that he used to be proud of (3:5–6). In this paragraph (3:7–9) he said that he now considered all these things to be useless. Nothing mattered to him besides knowing Jesus Christ better.

3:8a

More than that, I count all things as loss

- And even more, I consider that everything I used to depend on so that God would save me has no real value
- Even more than that, I think that everything I formerly did to please God/myself is worthless

More than that: The series of Greek particles that the BSB translates as More than that is used to intensify something. Paul apparently felt that the statement in 3:7 was not strong enough. So in 3:8 he added more to what he said in 3:7. Do not just translate More than that literally. Look for a natural way to strengthen and intensify something that has already been said. Some ideas are:

And that is not all....

Besides all that....

I count all things as loss: Paul was saying, “I consider everything that was gain to me before a loss now.” The term all things indicates that Paul is including

more than the things he listed in 3:5–6. He meant that everything he previously depended on for God to save him had no real value.

I count: The verb that the BSB translates as I count is in the present tense. This contrasts with the perfect tense Paul used in 3:7b. This change in tense is another way of emphasizing and intensifying what he was saying.

loss: This is the same term used in 3:7b. See notes there.

3:8b compared to the surpassing excellence

- when I compare it to what is far more valuable,
- in comparison with that which has much greater value,

compared to: The Greek word that the BSB translates as compared to is the same preposition translated as “for the sake of” in 3:7. In this verse it can be understood in two ways:

1. It indicates comparison. Paul was comparing his past life with knowing Christ. (BSB, NIV, NET, REB, NLT, CEV, NCV).
2. It indicates cause. Paul was giving the reason why he considered everything a loss. For example:

I consider everything a loss because of the surpassing worth.... (RSV) (GNT, NJB, RSV)

Either meaning is possible and both may be implied. The two meanings are not contradictory. Paul chose knowing Christ over everything else because it was better. So if you can translate in such a way as to make both possibilities understood, you should do so. If not, it is recommended that you follow the first interpretation.

the surpassing excellence: When Paul considered the things he formerly was proud of, they seemed worthless when he compared them with knowing Christ. All that comes with knowing Christ is far greater than all the other things people could depend on. Use the strongest terms you can to describe how great and priceless knowing Christ is, and how small and without value these other things are.

3:8c of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord,

- that is, really knowing Christ Jesus my Lord.
- which is that I personally know Christ Jesus, who is my Lord.

of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord: Paul knew Jesus Christ personally, and this was much more valuable than anything else. The idea of knowing Christ may be difficult to translate in some languages where the idea of knowing a person may only mean that you have met him and know who he is. It may not include the deeper meaning that Paul implied here in 3:8c, of knowing Jesus personally. It may be necessary to say something like “really knowing” or “knowing personally.”

3:8d for whom I have lost all things.

- Because of him, I have given up everything I depended on to be saved.
- I have abandoned/renounced all those things in order to please him.

In 3:8 the language of business and money that began in 3:7 continues. Paul was saying that he willingly gave up one thing in order to gain another thing which was worth much more. Jesus used similar words in the parable of the pearl of great price (Matthew 13:45–46) and in his teaching about discipleship (Matthew 16:26).

for whom: This means “for the sake of Christ Jesus” or “because of Christ Jesus.”

I have lost all things: Paul was describing how he willingly gave up all the things he formerly was proud of in order to know Christ. He not only considered them as loss, but he voluntarily gave them up. He did not cease to be all the things he described in 3:5a–c, but he rejected these things as worthless. See also the note on 3:8a.

In some languages, to say “I lost something” implies that a person accidentally lost it. If that is so in your language it will be better to say something like “I have thrown everything else away.”

3:8e I consider them rubbish, that I may gain Christ

- I regard them as garbage/trash/filth so that I might fully belong to Christ,

I consider them rubbish: There are two ways to interpret how this phrase relates to the phrases before and after it.

1. The phrase I consider them rubbish relates directly to the following phrase “that I may gain Christ”. (BSB, NIV, GNT, REB, NJB)
2. The phrase I consider them rubbish is a comment that Paul added, something that is separate from the main thing he was saying. It would mean that

the phrase in 3:8e “that I may gain Christ” would be the purpose of 3:8d. For example:

I have discarded everything else, counting it all as garbage, so that I may have Christ. (NLT) (GW, NET, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul regarded all his previous advantages as rubbish in order to obtain Christ.

rubbish: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rubbish can also mean “dung, excrement.” These things (3:7a–8a) were not only worthless, but Paul hated them. He considered them filthy. He was glad to get rid of them. Some ideas for translating this word “dung,” “something rotten,” “garbage” or “trash which I throw away.” Avoid using a word that might offend your readers.

that I may gain Christ: Paul continued to use the business metaphor of buying and selling here. Here it means that he wanted to belong fully to Christ, to know him more and more. Paul already belonged to Christ and knew him, but he wanted to know him better. Some ways to translate the phrase gain Christ are: “belong to Christ,” “know Christ,” “follow Christ,” “obey Christ.”

Philippians 3:9

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

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Paragraph 3:7–11

Paul was continuing to write against the Judaizers. In the last paragraph he listed all the things that he used to be proud of (3:5–6). In this paragraph (3:7–9) he said that he now considered all these things to be useless. Nothing mattered to him besides knowing Jesus Christ better.

3:9a and be found in Him,

- and so that I might be completely united with him.

and: This is a further purpose for which Paul considered everything as if it were rubbish.

be found in Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as be found was used idiomatically to refer to someone being in a certain place or situation. The meaning is “be in fact in him,” “prove to be in him” or “turn out to be in him.” It did not refer to someone else finding Paul in some way.

Some translation ideas for this part of the verse are:

so that I might belong to him

so that I might live in unity with him

so that I might be joined together with him

3:9b not having my own righteousness from the law,

- I have stopped trying to become right with God by obeying the law.
- It is not because I obeyed the Jewish laws that God declares me to be righteous.

not having my own righteousness: Paul had learned that nothing he could do as a good Jew could make him truly righteous as far as God was concerned, even if he appeared “righteous” to other people. So he no longer wanted this kind of false righteousness.

righteousness: In the context of 3:9b, this refers to Paul’s attempt to earn a right relationship to God by behaving in a morally upright manner. Before he became a Christian, Paul had thought that his own efforts would make him acceptable to God. See “righteousness”, under “just”, sense C4 in KBT.

from the law: Paul was referring to the time in the past when he tried to be right with God by keeping the Jewish laws. Notice in 3:6b he used a similar phrase “righteousness in the law” (that is, “what is right in terms of the law”). In that verse Paul claimed that he was faultless in that kind of righteousness. But here in 3:9b he stated that he had rejected that righteousness. Then in 3:9c–d he contrasted it with the righteousness that a person receives by trusting in Christ.

Some translation ideas for “my own righteousness from the law” are:

my own righteousness that comes from obeying the law

for God to consider me righteous because I did what the law says

3:9c

but that which is through faith in Christ,

- Instead, God has declared me righteous because I believe in Christ.
- It is because I trust Christ.

that which is through faith in Christ: This refers to that true righteousness, which a person receives by trusting in Christ. Paul explained this further in 3:9d.

3:9d

the righteousness from God on the basis of faith.

- God declares that I am righteous only because I believe in Christ.
- God enables me to relate to him in the right way because I trust Christ.

the righteousness from God on the basis of faith:

Here Paul made it clear what kind of righteousness he had been talking about in 3:9c. It is the righteousness that God gives to those who trust in Christ. A person is not righteous because of how he behaves or because people consider him good or right. He is truly righteous when God declares him so because he trusts in Christ.

on the basis of faith: You could translate this as “for those who believe.” It refers to those who trust Christ to save them. Notice that this is very similar to 3:9c.

General Comment on 3:9c–d

As 3:9c and 3:9d overlap in meaning, in some languages it may be better to combine them. For example:

God gives me a right relationship with him that is for those who believe in Christ.

God declares me righteous because I trust in Christ.

Philippians 3:10

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example

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3:10

This verse begins with the phrase “I want to know Christ.” Paul followed this with three phrases that show three ways that he could know Christ: by the power of Christ’s resurrection, by the fellowship of sharing Christ’s sufferings, and by becoming like Christ in his death.

3:10a

I want to know Christ

- It is my aim to know Christ more.
- I want to know and experience Christ better, like this:

I want to know Christ: This does not mean to know about Christ. It means to know and experience Christ personally. Paul already knew Christ, but he wanted to know him better.

3:10b

and the power of His resurrection

- I want to experience/feel/know the same power that God gave Christ when he became alive again after he had died.
- I want Christ to work within me with that power he has because he has risen again,

and the power of His resurrection: The power of Christ’s resurrection was already influencing Paul’s life, but he wanted to experience it more. This is one of the ways that a person can know Christ better.

There are several ways to understand the phrase the power of His resurrection:

1. It refers to the power Christ received after God raised him from the dead. This could be translated:

I want to have the power that Christ had when he rose again.

1. It refers to the God's power that raised Christ from the dead. This could be translated:

I want to experience the same power that God used when he caused Christ to live again after he had died. (NCV, CEV, NLT)

Most English versions do not specify how they understand his phrase, but both interpretations have strong support from commentators. It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1). Paul probably meant that knowing Christ included Paul experiencing the power that is now Christ's.

Paul wanted this power so that he could behave in the way that pleased God and so that he could effectively teach others God's message.

resurrection: In some languages the word resurrection can mean to come back to life as a different person or as a different living thing. This is not the meaning of resurrection in the Bible. If this is a problem in your language, you need to translate in a way that makes it clear that resurrection means a person becoming alive again as the same person.

General Comment on 3:10a–b

One way to connect 3:10a–b is:

I want to know Christ better in this way: I want to know the power of his resurrection.

3:10c

and the fellowship of His sufferings,

- I want to have fellowship with him by suffering for him as he suffered for me.
- and I want to be Christ's partner by suffering just as he suffered.

and the fellowship of His sufferings: This is the second way in which a person can know Christ better.

There are two main ways to interpret this phrase:

1. Paul was already suffering for Christ and he wanted more of the fellowship with Christ that comes from following him. He did not want to suffer, but he wanted to know Christ more and more even though that meant suffering.
2. Paul wanted to share by faith (mentally) the sufferings that Christ had.

The first interpretation has stronger support. It is recommended that you follow it (1). Paul did not want to suffer. But he knew that everyone who follows Christ faithfully should expect to suffer because those who refuse to follow Christ oppose them (2 Timothy 3:12). And he wanted the fellowship with Christ that would accompany this suffering.

fellowship: In this context this means "sharing in something with someone." See note on "partnership" in 1:5a, and "fellowship", sense A2 in KBT. This sense is brought out by the BSB when it supplies the words "sharing in."

3:10d

being conformed to Him in His death,

- I also want to become united with him in his death,
- I want to die in relation to sinning just as he died to take away sin.

being conformed to Him in His death: This is a difficult phrase to understand and most English versions translate it more or less literally. There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It is meant literally. Paul wanted to become like Christ by suffering as Christ did even to the point of death.
2. It is meant figuratively. Paul wanted to die to sin.

Both interpretations have strong support, but it is more likely that Paul was referring here to physical death, just as he had been referring to physical sufferings in 3:10c. So it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul said that he wanted to become like Christ in every aspect of his life. He even wanted to die like Christ died. This means that he was willing to have people persecute him and kill him for his faith just like people killed Christ.

Philippians 3:11

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul's example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB,

NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:7–11

Paul was continuing to write against the Judaizers. In the last paragraph he listed all the things that he used to be proud of (3:5–6). In this paragraph (3:7–9) he said that he now considered all these things to be useless. Nothing mattered to him besides knowing Jesus Christ better.

3:11

and so, somehow, to attain to the resurrection from the dead.

- and my purpose is to be one of those whom God will raise to life again.
- I want these things to happen so that God will cause me to live again after I have died.

and so, somehow, to attain to the resurrection from the dead: The Greek phrase *ei pōs* that the BSB translates as *so, somehow* can be understood in three ways:

1. It means “so that in some way....” It therefore shows purpose. Paul wanted these things (3:10) in order that he could be among those whom God would cause to live again after they died. For example:

so that somehow I also may be raised to life (CEV)
(NIV, NASB, NJB, NLT, CEV)

1. It means “in the hope of somehow....” It therefore shows hope. Paul wanted these things (3:10) because he hoped and expected that God would cause him to live again after he died. For example:

in the hope that I myself will be raised from the dead (GNT) (REB, GW, NCV, GNT)

1. It means “that if possible....” It therefore shows doubt about whether Paul would reach the resurrection. For example:

that if possible I might reach the resurrection from the dead (RSV) (RSV, KJV)

The first interpretation is recommended (1).

to attain: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *to attain* refers to reaching a place one was aiming for. Here it is used as a metaphor and it refers to reaching an objective or obtaining something one was working for. In some languages it may be necessary to remove the metaphor. Then this phrase could be translated:

that I may be among those whom God will raise from the dead

the resurrection from the dead: This refers to the time when God will make everyone come alive again.

Philippians 3:12

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:12–16

Paul wanted the Philippians to have the same attitude as he did, the attitude he had as he earnestly tried to become all that God wanted him to be.

3:12a

Not that I have already obtained all this,

- ¶ I do not claim that I have already done all these things
- ¶ I do not mean that I have already succeeded in my purpose.

Not that I have already obtained all this: This phrase means “I do not mean that I have already done all these things.”

obtained: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as *obtained* means to achieve something or to accomplish something.

all this: In the Greek text there is no object for the verb “to obtain.” That is, Paul does not say explicitly what he wanted to obtain. However, in many languages including English it is necessary either to supply an object or to use a verb which does not require an object. So the BSB has used *all this* as object, whereas the GNT has used the verb “succeed” which in English does not need an object:

I do not claim that I have already succeeded. (GNT)

There are several possible ways to understand what Paul wanted to obtain.

1. It refers to all the things about which Paul had been talking in 3:9–11. (BSB, NIV, NLT)
2. It refers specifically to the words “know Christ” in 3:10. Paul did not yet know Christ as fully as he wanted to.
3. It refers back to “the resurrection from the dead” in 3:11.
4. It refers to the perfection Paul mentioned in 3:12b. (NET, NCV)

Interpretation (1) is recommended. Paul was thinking about his life’s goal of knowing Christ and all that was involved in becoming like him.

One way you could translate 3:12a is:

I am not implying/saying that I have already achieved/accomplished all this.

3:12b

or have already been made perfect,

- nor has God already made me perfect.
- And I am not saying that I am completely all that I should be.

or have already been made perfect: The Greek word *teleios* that the BSB translates as perfect could have one of two meanings in this context:

1. Paul had not yet become a perfect person. God’s work in him was not yet finished. He was not yet completely righteous. (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NET, REB, NLT, CEV, NCV)
2. Paul had not yet reached the goal that he talked about in 3:14. (NJB, GW, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

3:12c

but I press on to take hold of that for which Christ Jesus took hold of me.

- Rather, I am trying hard to be more like Christ, which is the reason he/Christ chose me.
- But I am trying hard to become the person that Christ Jesus wanted me to be when he chose me as his own.

but I press on to take hold of that for which Christ Jesus took hold of me: Paul was trying very hard to become more and more like Christ, because that is Christ’s purpose in choosing him.

press on: The Greek word here literally means “run after” or “go after” in the sense of pursuing some-

thing. Paul was using a metaphor here to say that he was trying hard to be like Christ, just as a runner tries hard to win a race and get the prize.

take hold of: This is from the same Greek root word that the BSB translates as “obtained” in 3:12a. The form here means “to get something for yourself.”

that for which Christ Jesus took hold of me: There are two ways to understand the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as that for which:

1. It has its literal meaning “for which.” 3:12c can then be stated as Christ took hold of Paul in order that Paul would know him and become like him, as is discussed in 3:9–11. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, NASB, KJV, NJB, REB, GW, NLT)
2. It has an idiomatic meaning “because.” It gives the reason why Paul was pressing on, and it means “because Christ Jesus took hold of me”. This interpretation requires that an object be supplied after “I press on to take hold of...,” such as “the goal.” (RSV, NRSV, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

Philippians 3:13

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:12–16

Paul wanted the Philippians to have the same attitude as he did, the attitude he had as he earnestly tried to become all that God wanted him to be.

3:13a

Brothers, I do not consider myself yet to have taken hold of it.

- I am not claiming, brothers, that I already have achieved this.

- My Christian brothers and sisters, I know that I have not yet done this completely.

Brothers: The term Brothers here refers to other Christians, fellow believers, not to literal Brothers. You might translate this as “brothers and sisters,” “older and younger siblings” or “relatives.” The term Brothers also occurs in 1:12, 3:1, 3:17, 4:1, 4:8. See the note on 1:12a.

I do not consider myself yet to have taken hold of it: Paul was saying in other words what he had already said in 3:12a. He had not yet become all that God wanted him to be.

consider: This means “to regard, believe, say.” But here Paul referred to more than just his opinion of himself. He knew that he had not yet achieved what God wanted him to be.

taken hold of it: See the note on 3:12c.

3:13b

But one thing I do:

- But there is one thing that I aim to do above all else:
- But I am doing one thing that is the most important:

one thing I do: Paul was introducing the main thing that he wanted to do. He was about to explain what he wanted more than anything else. He did this by comparing himself to a man running a race to win a prize.

3:13c

Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead,

- Just as one who runs in a race does not look back but runs forward as hard/fast as he can, so I forget about what has already happened and continue to work hard to be what Christ wants me to be.
- I no longer think about the past but I concentrate on the future,

Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead: The phrase what is behind refers to Paul’s past, particularly to the things he used to boast about (3:5–6). This would include what happened before he became a Christian, and perhaps even some of what happened after he became a Christian.

Forgetting: Paul did not want to concentrate on his past. This does not mean he would completely forget but that it would not be the main thing he thought about. He compared this to a man running a race and not looking back to see who was close behind him or how far he had run. Make sure that your translation clearly means that Paul intended to forget these things. You might need to use a word meaning “ignor-

ing,” or you might need to use a negative like “not concentrating on” or “not paying any attention to.”

straining toward what is ahead: This also is using the metaphor of a race. The runner pushes himself forward as fast as he can. He tries to be the first to reach the finish line. The meaning here is that Paul was disciplining himself to become more like Christ, trying hard and doing his best to be what Christ wanted him to be.

If people run races in your culture, then it may be possible to use this metaphor. But if people in your culture do not know about racing, you may need to explain that in your translation. See the first meaning line of 3:13c in the Display. Or you may need to leave out the metaphor and translate only the meaning. For an example, see the second meaning line of 3:13c in the Display.

behind...ahead: Because Paul was using the metaphor of a race here, these words can be understood in two ways:

1. position in space: That is, within Paul’s metaphor of the race, the word behind means “in back of” or “at the rear of,” and the word ahead means “in front of.”
2. position in time: When Paul used the metaphor of a race, he was referring to his life. In this case, the word behind means “in the past, what happened before now,” and the word ahead means “in the future, what will happen later.”

Consider the following when you translate these words:

- In some languages, there may be words meaning “behind” and “ahead” which have the same dual meaning of space and time as the words do in Greek and English. If you have such words in your language, you should use them here.
- If you must decide which words to use, you should use sense (a) above, if you have used the metaphor of a race. Use sense (b) if you have not been able to retain the metaphor.

In some cultures the people think of the past as figuratively in front of them or “ahead,” because they can visualize what has already happened. They then think of the future as “behind,” something unknown that they cannot visualize. If this is true in your language, you need to be careful to use the correct terms so people understand what Paul was saying.

Philippians 3:14

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul's example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:12–16

Paul wanted the Philippians to have the same attitude as he did, the attitude he had as he earnestly tried to become all that God wanted him to be.

3:14a

I press on toward the goal to win the prize

- and I continue on until I reach my goal so that I may receive a heavenly reward.
- A runner continues running until he reaches the finish line and wins a prize. In the same way, I continue on to the end until I win the prize that God has for me.

I press on: This is the same Greek word as Paul used in 3:12c. See note there. In terms of the race metaphor here, the phrase press on means to keep on running. Paul was comparing himself to a determined runner, going toward his goal and not looking back. What he meant was that he continued trying, to work hard to become more like Christ.

goal: The Greek word that the BSB translates as goal means the “aim, end, object” of something. In the race metaphor, it refers to the finish line which each runner is trying to be the first to cross. But here Paul was probably referring to the thing he had been talking about in 3:10–13. His aim or goal was to become completely like Christ. This would include knowing him completely.

prize: A prize is a reward for winning a race or doing something well. The next note discusses what this prize was.

3:14b

of God's heavenly calling in Christ Jesus.

- And the reward is that God calls me to go up to heaven because of what Christ Jesus has done for me.
- That great prize is God calling me to heaven because Christ Jesus died for me.

of God's heavenly calling: It is not clear how this clause connects back to “the prize” mentioned in 3:14a. There are two main possibilities. There is a third possibility. The following is a comment by Dick Elkins: “Can it be that the prize was going to heaven? God must call someone to heaven before he can receive the prize. But if going to heaven was the prize, then it would seem that Paul was implying that salvation is the result not of faith alone but of faith plus extreme persistence. In the Word Biblical Commentary Hawthorne remarks: ‘In keeping with the vivid imagery drawn from the Greek games that pervades this section there is still another explanation that seems the most reasonable explanation of all. It sees in the Greek expression *tēs anō klēseōs* “the upward call” an allusion to the fact that the Olympian games, which included foot races, were organized and presided over by...highly respected officers, called *Hellenokidai*. After each event they had a herald announce the name of the victor, his father's name and his country, and the athlete would come and receive a palm branch at their hands. This is the call to which Paul was here alluding. Such an explanation as this has the virtue of not identifying “the upward call” with the prize, and allows the force of the context to determine what Paul had in mind when he spoke of that prize. For him it was to be found “in Christ,” that is, Christ was his prize. To know Christ fully and completely was the prize for which he had been striving ever since his encounter with Christ on the Damascus Road.’ Hawthorne paraphrases: “...the prize that God...will give me when he calls me up and announces my name, the prize that is contained in Christ Jesus.” You could translate this meaning as follows: I keep on going toward the goal to get that prize that God will give me when he calls me to heaven, which is this: he will cause me to become like Christ Jesus.

1. It identifies the prize. The prize was that God called Paul heavenwards to make him completely like Christ. For example:

the prize, which is God's call...to the life above
(GNT) (CEV, NET, GNT)

1. The prize that God called Paul heavenwards to receive. Paul did not identify the prize itself. (NIV, NLT, NCV, GW, REB)

The first interpretation fits the context better here. So it is recommended that you follow it (1).

heavenly: The Greek word here literally means “upwards.”

in Christ Jesus: God can call or invite people to be with him in heaven because of what Christ has done for them. So you could translate 3:14b as:

God calls me to heaven to be with him because of what Christ Jesus has done for me.

General Comment on 3:14

In some languages it may be helpful to reorder this verse. One way to do this would be:

I continue trying hard until God calls me to heaven because of Christ Jesus. In doing this I am like a runner racing toward the finish line to receive a prize.

Philippians 3:15

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:12–16

Paul wanted the Philippians to have the same attitude as he did, the attitude he had as he earnestly tried to become all that God wanted him to be.

3:15

In Greek this verse connects to the previous one with a conjunction, *oun*, that can be translated “so” or “therefore.” It indicates that Paul wanted his readers to do something because of what he had just said. The BSB leaves this connection implicit as do many other English versions (GNT, RSV, NCV, CEV, NLT, REB, GW). You should use whatever connection is most natural in your language.

3:15a

All of us who are mature should embrace this point of view.

- So then, let all of us^(incl) who are spiritually mature have the same attitude about these things that I have been talking about.

mature: The Greek word is *teleios*, which means “perfect, mature, fully developed or initiated.” This has two main interpretations here:

1. Those who are spiritually mature. Paul was referring to spiritual growth and strength. He was referring to people whose faith was strong and fully developed. (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NCV, CEV, NLT, GW, REB)
2. Those who thought they were perfect. Paul was being sarcastic. (NET)

The first meaning is recommended (1).

should embrace this point of view: This means thinking in a certain way about something. The way Paul wanted the Philippians to think was explained in 3:12–14. You could translate this as:

should have that attitude

should think like that

3:15b

And if you think differently about some issue,

- And if you disagree with me about any of these things,
- And even if you have a different attitude than I do, about any of these things,

if you think differently about some issue: It is not clear whether this implies that some of the Philippians were actually thinking differently than Paul or if it is something that Paul just thought might happen. One way to translate this is:

if any of you have an attitude that is different from what I have been talking about...

3:15c

God will reveal this to you as well.

- God will help you understand the correct way to think.
- God will show you that the attitude I have been talking about is the right way to think.

God will reveal this to you as well: What Paul had said in 3:12–14 described the right attitude for a Christian to have. So if anyone disagreed God would make clear to him that what Paul had said was correct.

Philippians 3:16

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul's example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:12–16

Paul wanted the Philippians to have the same attitude as he did, the attitude he had as he earnestly tried to become all that God wanted him to be.

3:16

Nevertheless, we must live up to what we have already attained.

- In any case, we^(incl) must obey what we^(incl) already know God wants us^(incl) to do and to be.
- The important thing is that we^(incl) act according to what God has already shown to us^(incl).

Nevertheless: The word Nevertheless implies that Paul was emphasizing an important point. In English it could be expressed as “In any case...” or “However...” or “The important thing is...”

we must live up to what we have already attained:

Paul was saying, “Let each of us act consistently with the level we have reached as Christians.” This means that believers should obey what they already know God wants them to do and to be. One way to translate this would be to follow the SSA:

we^(incl) must act/live according to what God has already revealed to us^(incl) (SSA)

Another possibility is:

let us^(incl) obey what we^(incl) know God has already revealed to us^(incl)

Philippians 3:17

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul's example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:17–21

Paul wanted the Philippians to act like citizens of heaven, as he did, and not to act like those who were proud of doing wrong.

3:17a

Join one another in following my example, brothers,

- ¶ Brothers, join together in imitating me.
- ¶ My Christian brothers and sisters, unite together to follow my good example of behaving as a Christian.

Join one another in following my example: Paul wanted the believers in Philippi to follow the same principles that he lived by. The phrase he used here literally means “become joint imitators of me.” This can be interpreted in several ways:

1. The believers should unite with one another in imitating Paul. (BSB, RSV, NJB, NCV, KJV, NASB)
2. They should join with others who imitated Paul. (NIV, REB)
3. The command just means “imitate me.” The prefix sun- on the verb “imitate,” which the BSB has translated as Join one another, has no significance and can be ignored. (NIV, CEV, GNT, NET, NLT, GW)

There is strongest commentary support for meaning (1), and it is recommended that you follow this in your translation. Paul wanted the Philippians to unite together in imitating his Christian way of thinking and acting.

brothers: The term brothers here refers to other Christians, fellow believers, not to literal brothers. You might translate this as “brothers and sisters,” “older and younger siblings” or “relatives.” The term brothers also occurs in 1:12, 3:13, 3:17, 4:1, 4:8. See the note on 1:12a.

3:17b

and carefully observe those who walk according to the pattern we set for you.

- Watch carefully and behave like those who behave as you saw us^(excl) behave when we^(excl) were with you.

carefully observe: This means to watch something carefully.

those who walk according to the pattern we set for you: Other believers were following Paul’s example and his companions’ example of how Christians should behave. Paul wanted the rest of the Philippians to watch how those believers acted, and to imitate them.

walk: The word walk here refers to acting or behaving in a certain way.

we: This probably refers to Paul and some other apostles or teachers who had gone to teach in Philippi with him (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, NET, NCV, CEV, NLT, GW, REB). It does not include the Philippians.

Philippians 3:18

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:17–21

Paul wanted the Philippians to act like citizens of heaven, as he did, and not to act like those who were proud of doing wrong.

3:18

Commentators disagree about whom Paul was referring to in 3:18–19. The main suggestions are:

1. the Judaizers Paul mentioned earlier in the chapter who were trying to make the Gentile Christians become like Jews.
2. Christians who believed they did not need to obey any moral laws.
3. non-Christian Jews.

All the Greek text (especially 3:19) implies is that they were people opposed to moral laws. You should not try and identify these people further in your translation.

Once again Paul talked about the enemies of Christ with strong feeling and emotion. Try to make this meaning clear in your translation.

3:18a

For as I have often told you before, and now say again even with tears:

- Because, as I have already told you many times, and now I am crying with sorrow as I tell you again,

For: This means that the evil lives of Christ’s enemies are one of the reasons the believers should try to imitate Paul’s godly life.

as I have often told you before: Paul had often warned the believers about the enemies he was about to describe.

and now say again even with tears: Paul was very sorrowful, even to the point of crying, when he had to tell the believers again about these enemies of Christ.

with tears: The Greek word that the BSB translates as with tears literally means “crying, weeping, wailing.”

3:18b

Many live as enemies of the cross of Christ.

- many people behave in a manner that shows they are enemies of Christ, because they do not want people to hear that/why he died on the cross.
- there are many people who act/behave in a way that shows that they are against what Christ died for on the cross.

Many live as enemies of the cross of Christ: Many people behaved in a way that showed that they opposed the good news, especially the main teaching about why Christ died on the cross. In many languages it does not make sense to say that someone is an “enemy of the cross.” The Display for 3:18b shows some ways to translate this.

Many: It may be necessary to include some implicit information here to clarify who these Many were. For example:

Many say they are Christians, but they act like they hate the message about Christ dying on the cross.

Paul does not say explicitly whether these people were Christians or not, even though they claimed to be.

live: As in 3:17b, the word that the BSB translates as live refers here to acting or behaving in a certain way.

the cross of Christ: This means “the cross on which Jesus died.” Here this is used figuratively to refer to the significance or purpose of Christ’s death.

General Comment on 3:18

In some languages it may be helpful to reorder this verse so that the main thing Paul is saying comes at the beginning. For example:

For there are many enemies of the cross of Christ.
I have told you about them before, and now I am crying as I tell you again.

Philippians 3:19

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:17–21

Paul wanted the Philippians to act like citizens of heaven, as he did, and not to act like those who were proud of doing wrong.

3:19a

Their end is destruction,

- In the end they will be ruined,

- God will finally destroy them in hell, because this is how they act:

end: The word that the BSB translates literally as end refers to the conclusion or end result of their lives.

destruction: The Greek word that the BSB translates as destruction also means “ruin.” It is the opposite of “salvation.” In some languages it may be necessary to translate this as a verb and say, “they will be ruined/destroyed.” In some languages it may be necessary to use an active verb and provide a subject. It is God who will destroy them.

3:19b

their god is their belly,

- They live only to satisfy what their bodies want.
- The only thing that controls them is the evil desires of their bodies.

their god is their belly: This Greek phrase that the BSB translates as their belly could have one of two meanings:

1. It is a figure of speech referring to the desires of their bodies, including desires for food and sex and other earthly pleasures. For example:

their bodily desires (GNT)

what their bodies want (NCV)

1. It refers to their literal stomachs. Food and drink was what they were most concerned about. (NASB, REB, NLT)

Most English versions use “stomach” or belly, which can be taken either literally or as a figure of speech. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In the context of the rest of 3:19 (the more general ideas of shameful things and earthly things), it seems that 3:19b also refers to the more general idea of the desires of the body rather than just the desire for food.

By saying that the desires of their bodies were their god, Paul meant that they obeyed these desires as they would a god.

One way to translate this is:

They care only about the things they want here on earth.

3:19c

and their glory is in their shame.

- They boast about doing shameful things.

- They are proud of doing things of which they ought to be ashamed.

their glory: This means that these people glory in something or are proud of something.

their shame: This refers to the shameful things these people do. For example, it refers to the sort of things Paul talked about in 3:19b.

The things they did were shameful and they ought to have been ashamed of them, but they were not. In fact, they were even proud of the way they behaved. The whole phrase then means that they were proud of the things they did, things of which they ought to have been ashamed.

In many languages it will not be possible to use nouns like “glory” and shame, but it will be necessary to use verbs. For example:

They are proud of what they should be ashamed of (GNT)

They...brag about the disgusting things they do (CEV)

3:19d

Their minds are set on earthly things.

- The only things they think about are the things that affect life here on earth.
- All they give attention to are the things that people here on earth think are important.

Their minds are set on earthly things: These people constantly thought about the things on earth. In fact, the only things they paid attention to were things on the earth, things like food, clothes, pleasure. One way to translate this is:

They only ever think about the things on earth.

General Comment on 3:19

In some languages it seems better to place 3:19a at the end of the verse, because it gives the result of the other things Paul talked about in this verse. For example:

So as a result of this God will finally destroy them.

However, if you think this might be helpful in your language, consider carefully how you will then maintain the contrast Paul made by putting “earth” (3:19d) and “heaven” (3:20a) close together.

Philippians 3:20

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:17–21

Paul wanted the Philippians to act like citizens of heaven, as he did, and not to act like those who were proud of doing wrong.

3:20a

But our citizenship is in heaven,

- But as for us^(incl), we^(incl) are citizens of heaven, not earth.
- But we^(incl) should act differently, because heaven is where we^(incl) really belong.

But: In 3:20, Paul contrasted Christians with the people he had just been talking about in 3:18–19. These people were only interested in things affecting life on earth, but Christians do not belong to earth, they are citizens of heaven, and so they focus on things in heaven.

our citizenship is in heaven: This implies that those who believe in Christ really belong to heaven, not earth. The way they act on earth should show that heaven is their homeland, not earth.

our: Paul meant “as for us....” He was contrasting the true believer’s attitude with the attitude of those he described in 3:18–19. The word our includes Paul and those he was writing to.

citizenship: The Greek word that the BSB translates as citizenship can have several meanings:

1. It means “citizenship”; (BSB, NIV, NASB, GNT, NET, REB, GW, NLT, CEV)
2. It means “state,” “commonwealth,” “homeland”; (RSV, NJB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1). Paul was reminding the Philippians that all believers

were citizens of heaven, not earth. When you translate the word citizenship, think of how you would normally say that you are loyal citizens of your country.

In some languages there may be no word that means “citizen.” If this is true in your language, you could translate this part of the verse:

Heaven is where we^(incl) really belong.

3:20b

and we eagerly await a Savior from there, the Lord Jesus Christ,

- We^(incl) are eagerly expecting a/our^(incl) Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ, to return to earth from heaven.
- We^(incl) are looking forward to the return from heaven of the one who saves us (incl)—he is the Lord Jesus Christ.

we eagerly await: Paul and the Philippians were looking forward to something that they very much wanted and expected to happen. So they were eager and impatient to see it happen.

a Savior from there, the Lord Jesus Christ: This was whom Paul and the Philippians were eagerly awaiting. They were impatiently looking forward to the day when Christ would return from heaven.

Savior: This refers to someone who would come and save God’s people.

from there: That is, from heaven.

Philippians 3:21

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul’s example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 3:17–21

Paul wanted the Philippians to act like citizens of heaven, as he did, and not to act like those who were proud of doing wrong.

3:21a

who, by the power that enables Him to subject all things to Himself,

- He has the power that makes him able to subject everything there is to himself, and by that power
- Using the power by which he is able to rule over all things,

the power that enables Him: This means the ability to be strong and to do great things. The power that Christ has makes it possible for him to take control of everything.

subject all things to Himself: This refers to taking control of all things.

In some languages it will not be possible to talk about controlling or ruling things. If this is true in your language, you could translate this “take control of all people/beings.”

Some other possible translations are:

make everything be under his authority

cause everything to happen as he commands

all things: That is, all that God has created. This could be translated as “heaven and earth” or “all the world.”

3:21b

will transform our lowly bodies to be like His glorious body.

- he will change our^(incl) weak earthly bodies so that we^(incl) will have new bodies like the wonderful body he received when God brought him back to life.

transform: This means to change something from what it was into something different.

our lowly bodies: The phrase our lowly bodies refers to the bodies we now have, bodies get sick and die.

to be like His glorious body: When Christ changes these earthly bodies, they will become like his heavenly body—the sort of body Christ had after God raised him from the dead. God not only caused Christ’s body to live again but he made it a different sort of body (see 1 Corinthians 15:35–58), one that was no longer able to die.

His glorious body: This refers to the body Christ had after God raised him from the dead. Through this new body, God showed his power and his glory.

General Comment on 3:21

In some languages it may be helpful to reorder this verse so that 3:21b comes before 3:21a. One way to do this is:

He will change our weak, human bodies to be like his glorious body. He will do this by his power that makes him able to bring all things under his control.

Philippians 4:1

Section 3:1–4:1: The Philippians should follow Paul's example and trust Christ to make them righteous

Paul told the believers to watch out for those who were teaching that believers must be circumcised. He also warned them against those who were proud of doing evil. He encouraged them to follow his example instead. Paul tried to be like Christ and depended on him alone in order to become righteous.

In both 3:1 and 4:1, Paul talked about being joyful. Therefore, it is possible to consider that 3:1 is an introduction to this section and 4:1 is a summary of this section. However, some English versions consider that 3:1a is the final statement in the previous section and so attach it to the end of chapter 2 (REB, NJB, NRSV). You may want to follow whatever the national language version in your area does here.

Paragraph 4:1

Paul encouraged the believers to be faithful to the Lord.

4:1 is a summary of what Paul talked about in 3:12–21.

4:1a

Therefore, my brothers, whom I love and long for,

- ¶ So, my Christian brothers, whom I love and long to see again,
- ¶ Therefore, you who are my brothers and sisters in Christ, I desire to see you again because I love you very much.

Therefore: This connecting word indicates that what Paul had been saying in chapter 3, especially in the latter part, was the reason why he then said what he did in 4:1.

my brothers: The term brothers here refers to other Christians, fellow believers, not to literal brothers. You might translate this as “brothers and sisters,” “older and younger siblings” or “relatives.” The term brothers

also occurs in 1:12, 3:1, 3:13, 3:17, 4:8. See the note on 1:12a.

whom I love and long for: Once again Paul told the Philippians how much he loved them. The phrase long for means to wish strongly to see someone because you love him very much. See note on “I long for all of you” in 1:8, where the same Greek word is used.

4:1b

my joy and crown,

- you who make me happy and who are my reward,
- You cause me to be joyful and you are my prize for the work I have done.

my joy: When Paul called the Philippians his joy in this verse, he meant that they caused Paul to be happy. Some possible ways to translate this are:

you give me joy

you make me happy

and crown: When Paul called the Philippians his crown, he meant they were his reward for the work he had done. The Greek word that the BSB translates as crown refers to the ring of leaves that was placed on the head of someone who had just won a race or competition. It was his reward/prize for winning. Therefore, it is possible that Paul was thinking of the reward that he would get in heaven because of how he had discipled the Philippians. They were like his reward because they had believed in Christ and were following him. Here is an idea for translating the word crown:

you are the reward for my work

Paul also used the ideas of “joy” and crown together in 1 Thessalonians 2:19.

4:1c

that is how you must stand firm in the Lord, my beloved.

- Dear friends, on the basis of all I have told you, remain strong in your faith in the Lord in this way.
- You should continue firmly trusting and obeying the Lord like that, my dear friends.

that is how: The Greek word houtōs that the BSB translates as that is how can also be translated as “in this way” or “so.” Paul encouraged the Philippians to stand firm in the way he had just been describing in the previous verses.

stand firm in the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stand firm is also used in 1:27c–d. It literally just means “stand,” but Paul used it figuratively to mean “be steadfast.” Paul wanted the Philippians to be strong in their faith no matter what happened to them. A possible rendering for the phrase stand firm in the Lord in this context is:

remain loyal to the Lord

my beloved: The BSB translates this phrase from the same Greek word from which it translates the phrase “whom I love” in 4:1a. Think about whether it is better in your language to repeat the same idea or to use a different expression here in your translation. See also the note on “my beloved” in 2:12a.

Philippians 4:2

Section 4:2–9: Paul taught the Philippians how to find peace

Paul asked the believers in Philippi to behave peaceably toward one another. This was important, especially in the context of suffering for their faith. As a way to help them do that, he encouraged them to help one another, to be happy, to pray rather than worry, and to focus on thinking about good things.

Paragraph 4:2–3

Paul pleaded with two of the women among the Philippian believers to be at peace with one another. And he asked another believer to help them agree together.

4:2

I urge Euodia and Syntyche to agree with each other in the Lord.

- ¶ I Euodia and Syntyche, I beg you, agree with each other because you both belong to the Lord Jesus.
- ¶ I beg both Euodia and Syntyche to stop arguing and to accept each other’s opinions because you both follow the Lord.

I urge: This means “to ask strongly, to plead, to beg someone to do something.”

Euodia and Syntyche: These were two female members of the church in Philippi. They were obviously strongly disagreeing with each other about something.

agree with each other: Paul was asking these women to stop arguing and to agree with one another. He wanted them to be at peace with each other.

In 2:1–2 Paul had already pleaded with the whole church to agree with each other. This is the same expression that the BSB translates as “being like-

minded” in 2:2. In this verse, Paul was pleading with two of the church members by name to do the same thing.

in the Lord: In this context Paul used this expression to mean “because you belong to the Lord Jesus.”

Philippians 4:3

Section 4:2–9: Paul taught the Philippians how to find peace

Paul asked the believers in Philippi to behave peaceably toward one another. This was important, especially in the context of suffering for their faith. As a way to help them do that, he encouraged them to help one another, to be happy, to pray rather than worry, and to focus on thinking about good things.

Paragraph 4:2–3

Paul pleaded with two of the women among the Philippian believers to be at peace with one another. And he asked another believer to help them agree together.

4:3a

Yes, and I ask you, my true yokefellow, to help these women

- Moreover, I ask you^(sing), reliable partner, help these two women to agree with one another,
- My faithful companion, I ask you^(sing) to assist these two women to live in peace with one another,

Yes: This particle here is used to strengthen or emphasize Paul’s request. It is not necessary to translate it with the same word you use to indicate agreement (the normal use of the English word Yes). Other English versions have used “indeed” or “moreover.”

you: The word you is singular here. This is the only time in the letter to Philippians that Paul addressed just one person.

my true: This refers to what is true or genuine. Paul was referring to a person who was not false but true to his claim of being a faithful disciple of Christ. People could depend on him.

yokefellow: The Greek word *suzugos* here means “fellow worker” or “partner.” There are two ways to interpret this term:

1. It is a common noun, not a name. Paul very likely was referring to someone in the church who could help the two women agree. But Paul did not say who that person was. It is also possible that this person was one of Paul’s companions whom he had left behind to work in Philippi. That would help explain why Paul addressed him specifically to help Euodia

and Syntyche.. (BSB, RSV, NIV, NET, GNT, KJV, NASB, REB, NLT, NCV, CEV)

2. It is a name. The person Paul was talking to was a member of the church at Philippi and his name was Syzygos. Paul was using both the name and its meaning, as he did with the name “Onesimus” in Philemon 11. (NJB, GW)

Interpretation (1) has strong commentary support. Also the name Syzygos is not known elsewhere in Greek literature. So it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

to help these women: In some languages it may be necessary to say explicitly what Paul wanted this man to help the women to do. If you need to do this in your language, you could say “help these women to live in peace with each other” or “...to agree with one another.”

4:3b

who have labored with me for the gospel,

- because they have worked hard with me to help me proclaim the good news about Jesus Christ.
- because they have struggled together with me to help people hear the good news of Christ.

who have labored with me for the gospel: Paul reminded his “yokefellow” that Euodia and Syntyche had worked hard with Paul to defend the gospel and to tell people about Christ.

who: The Greek term that the BSB translates as who has been understood in several ways:

1. It introduces a reason: “for they, since they...” (RSV, GNT, NLT)
2. It defines the women: “[the women] who...” (BSB, NIV, NASB, KJV)
3. It begins a new clause that comments on the women’s work: “they [contended]...” (NET, GW, NJB, REB, CEV, NCV)

The first interpretation has the strongest commentary support and is recommended (1).

labored with me: The Greek word that BSB translates as labored is the same word that Paul used in 1:27 (see note on 1:27c–d). It means to join someone else in a struggle to do something. It means to work hard together to overcome something.

for the gospel: This is literally “in the gospel.” You may need to supply a verb such as “spreading” or “defending.”

4:3c

along with Clement and the rest of my fellow workers,

- And so have Clement and the others who have been working with me.
- These women have worked hard together with Clement and the rest of those who have helped me spread the gospel.

along with Clement: These women were not the only people who had helped Paul to defend and spread the gospel of Christ. Clement and others had also helped Paul in this way.

Clement: This is a man’s name. We know nothing else about him except that he was a believer and a co-worker of Paul’s.

and the rest of my fellow workers: Other believers had also worked with Paul to help people know what was true about Jesus Christ.

So in 4:3, Paul mentioned three groups of people who had helped him spread the gospel: the two women (Euodia and Syntyche), Clement and the rest of his fellow workers.

4:3d

whose names are in the Book of Life.

- God has written all their names in his book, which lists those who will live forever.

whose names are in the Book of Life: Although this may appear to relate only to the phrase “the rest of my fellow workers,” it does not exclude the other people mentioned in 4:3. The names of Euodia, Syntyche and Clement are also in the book of life.

the Book of Life: The phrase the Book of Life refers to God’s record of true believers who will live forever.

Philippians 4:4

Section 4:2–9: Paul taught the Philippians how to find peace

Paul asked the believers in Philippi to behave peaceably toward one another. This was important, especially in the context of suffering for their faith. As a way to help them do that, he encouraged them to help one another, to be happy, to pray rather than worry, and to focus on thinking about good things.

Paragraph 4:4–7

This paragraph contrasts with 4:2–3 where Paul talked about arguing. In 4:4–7 he encouraged the Philippian believers to be happy and gentle, to pray and not to worry. He wanted them to experience the peace of God in their hearts and in their Christian community.

4:4

Rejoice in the Lord always. I will say it again: Rejoice!

- ¶ Be glad at all times because of the Lord. I say it again, be glad!
- ¶ Always be very happy because you belong to the Lord. I repeat: be happy!

Rejoice in the Lord: This is the same Greek phrase as Paul used in 3:1a. See the note on that verse.

always: Here Paul made the expression “Rejoice in the Lord” stronger. He added the idea of always. He meant for the believers to continue rejoicing as they obeyed the Lord Jesus. They express their joy all the time as they thought about the Lord and all that he had done for them. Even when others persecuted them because they believed in Jesus, they could still be happy because they belonged to God.

I will say it again: Rejoice!: Paul was repeating what he had just said to give it emphasis and to show that it was very important.

Philippians 4:5

Section 4:2–9: Paul taught the Philippians how to find peace

Paul asked the believers in Philippi to behave peaceably toward one another. This was important, especially in the context of suffering for their faith. As a way to help them do that, he encouraged them to help one another, to be happy, to pray rather than worry, and to focus on thinking about good things.

Paragraph 4:4–7

This paragraph contrasts with 4:2–3 where Paul talked about arguing. In 4:4–7 he encouraged the Philippian believers to be happy and gentle, to pray and not to worry. He wanted them to experience the peace of God in their hearts and in their Christian community.

4:5a

Let your gentleness be apparent to all.

- Show that you are gentle by the way you behave toward everyone.
- Let everyone see that you are reasonable and patient with others.

Let your gentleness be apparent to all: That is, Paul wanted the Philippians to display a gentle attitude, to act in a patient way as they related to everyone, including unbelievers.

gentleness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gentleness has a wide meaning. A gentle person means someone who is calm and moderate, who considers what others need and not just what he himself needs. It means someone who does not insist on his own rights or his own way of doing things. It also

means someone who is reasonable and fair-minded, and patient when others misunderstand him.

be apparent: In languages with no passives it will be necessary to translate this with an active verb. Some ways to do this are:

Show all people that you are gentle.

Let everyone see that you are gentle.

to all: This means to all human beings, not just to all believers.

4:5b

The Lord is near.

- Don't forget that the Lord Jesus will return soon.
- Remember that the Lord is about to come back.

The Lord is near: There are two ways to interpret this expression:

1. It refers to time, that is, Paul expected the Lord to return to earth soon. (GNT, CEV, NLT, NCV)
2. It refers to location. The Lord is close to all his people.

Most English versions are ambiguous, as is the Greek. If it is possible in your language, you could choose a word or phrase that can mean both close in space and close in time. However, if you must make a choice, choose interpretation (1). Paul probably meant that believers should continue to expect the Lord to return at any time. This should cause all believers to act properly as his true disciples.

The Lord: This refers to the Lord Jesus.

Philippians 4:6

Section 4:2–9: Paul taught the Philippians how to find peace

Paul asked the believers in Philippi to behave peaceably toward one another. This was important, especially in the context of suffering for their faith. As a way to help them do that, he encouraged them to help one another, to be happy, to pray rather than worry, and to focus on thinking about good things.

Paragraph 4:4–7

This paragraph contrasts with 4:2–3 where Paul talked about arguing. In 4:4–7 he encouraged the Philippian believers to be happy and gentle, to pray and not to worry. He wanted them to experience the peace of God in their hearts and in their Christian community.

4:6a

Be anxious for nothing,

- Do not worry about anything.
- Be anxious about nothing.

Be anxious for nothing: Paul was saying, “Do not worry about anything.” He did not mean the believers should not be concerned about serious problems or important things. But he did not want them to worry habitually as unbelievers did because they did not trust in God to help them.

4:6b

but in everything, by prayer and petition, with thanksgiving, present your requests to God.

- Instead, in every situation, pray to God about what you need. And while you are praying and asking him for things, thank him too.

but in everything: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase which the BSB translates as in everything:

1. It refers to every situation or problem. (BSB, NIV, RSV, NASB, REB, NLT, NJB, NCV, CEV, KJV, GW)
2. It refers to every prayer and petition. (GNT, NET)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1), which is supported by the great majority of commentaries and translations. Whatever problem the believers were having, they should pray to God and not worry.

by prayer: This refers to praying to God in a general sense.

and petition: This refers to a specific kind of prayer: when a person asks God for something.

with thanksgiving: This also is how believers should pray—thanking God. It implies that whenever the believer prays to God, he should thank God. Paul did not say what the Philippians should thank God for, but it could include his goodness and love to them, previous prayers he had answered and many other things.

present your requests to God: This means:

ask God for what you need (GNT)

Philippians 4:7

Section 4:2–9: Paul taught the Philippians how to find peace

Paul asked the believers in Philippi to behave peaceably toward one another. This was important, especially in the context of suffering for their faith. As a way to help them do that, he encouraged them to help one another, to be happy, to pray rather than worry, and to focus on thinking about good things.

Paragraph 4:4–7

This paragraph contrasts with 4:2–3 where Paul talked about arguing. In 4:4–7 he encouraged the Philippian believers to be happy and gentle, to pray and not to worry. He wanted them to experience the peace of God in their hearts and in their Christian community.

4:7a

And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding,

- And as a result of all this, God will give you peace. This peace is much greater than people can understand.

And: 4:7 is the result of 4:6.

the peace of God: This refers to the peace that God gives his people. See note on 1:2. See also peace, section A3c in KBT.

surpasses all understanding: The peace that God gives is much greater than people can ever imagine or understand.

4:7b

will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.

- It will help you not to feel fearful or think worried thoughts in difficult circumstances, because you belong to Christ Jesus.
- This peace will protect you and prevent anxious thoughts from making you feel afraid. This protection is because you belong to Christ Jesus.

will guard your hearts and your minds: When God’s people pray to him and trust and depend on him, he gives them peace, which protects them and helps them not to worry or be afraid.

guard: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as guard is a military term which was used to describe soldiers guarding a city. Paul used it as a metaphor—God’s peace is like a soldier or sentinel which watches over believers and keeps them safe.

your hearts and your minds: The words hearts and minds refer to the inward part of a person. Commentators do not agree on how the two terms are different, but the term “heart” may refer to feelings and the term “mind” to thoughts.

in Christ Jesus: God gives his people this peace because they trust in Christ and belong to him.

Philippians 4:8

Section 4:2–9: Paul taught the Philippians how to find peace

Paul asked the believers in Philippi to behave peaceably toward one another. This was important, especially in the context of suffering for their faith. As a way to help them do that, he encouraged them to help one another, to be happy, to pray rather than worry, and to focus on thinking about good things.

Paragraph 4:8–9

In this paragraph, Paul told the believers another way that they could achieve peace among themselves: they should keep their minds on things that are good and follow the example that Paul had already set for them.

4:8a

Finally, brothers,

- ¶ And now, brothers and sisters in Christ,
- ¶ So then, my Christian brothers,

Finally: With this Greek phrase in 4:8–9, Paul was finishing this part of his letter, in which he was exhorting his readers to do certain things. This was not the end of the whole letter. Paul used the same expression in 3:1a. See note there.

brothers: The term brothers here refers to other Christians, fellow believers, not to literal brothers. You might translate this as “brothers and sisters,” “older and younger siblings” or “relatives.” The term brothers also occurs in 1:12, 3:1, 3:13, 3:17, 4:1. See the note on 1:12a.

In the rest of this verse, Paul listed the sort of things that he wanted the Philippians to think about, meditate on, concentrate on in their thoughts.

4:8b

whatever is true, whatever is honorable,

- Think about things that are true, things that deserve respect,
- Think about genuine and honorable things.

whatever is true: This refers to things that are real or genuine. Because they are true, they are dependable. These things fit with the nature of God, who represents all that is true.

whatever is honorable: This refers to things that are noble, things that deserve to be respected.

4:8c

whatever is right, whatever is pure,

- things that are right, things that are without sin,

- Think about whatever God considers righteous and whatever is free from sin.

whatever is right: This phrase refers to things that God considers right and good, things that God approves. This is the Greek word often translated “righteous.”

whatever is pure: This refers to things that are free from sin.

4:8d

whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—

- things that are lovable and things that deserve to be admired.
- Think about things that are easy for people to love and things that have a good name/reputation.

whatever is lovely: This phrase refers to things that people can easily love, things that are worthy for people to love. It means things that are pleasing to people, things that are agreeable.

whatever is admirable: This refers to things that people like and admire, things that have a good name or reputation.

4:8e

if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—

- In fact, concentrate on whatever is excellent and what people praise.
- So think about things that are very good and things that people speak well of.

if anything is excellent: This means “whatever is very good.” Paul used the Greek word that the BSB translates as excellent in a moral sense, meaning something that is free from sin. In this sentence the word if does not mean that Paul did not know whether there was anything excellent or not. He knew there were many very good things in the world.

praiseworthy: This refers to things that deserve to be praised. People speak well of things they admire and approve.

General Comment on 4:8a–e

In some languages it may be hard to know how some of these eight things are different from one another, and so it may be necessary to combine some. For example, it may be possible to translate the Greek words that the BSB translates as “honorable” and “admirable” together as “things that people respect.”

4:8f

think on these things.

- These are the things you should concentrate on.
- These are the kinds of things I want you to focus on.

think on these things: Paul concluded his list by saying that he wanted the Philippians to keep focusing on the things he had mentioned and thinking about them.

things: This does not refer to objects that a person can touch. It refers to what people say, what they do, what people think and how they act toward other people.

General Comments on 4:8

In some languages it may be necessary to reorder the verse in some way.

One possible reordering is to put 4:8f at the beginning of the verse as an introduction. For example:

Finally, brothers and sisters, these are the things you should think about: things that are true, things that are noble....

Another possibility is also to reorder the list itself. The last two qualities (4:8e), “excellent” and “praiseworthy,” are a sort of summary of the first six qualities. So in some languages it may be helpful to begin the list with these qualities. The GNT has done this:

In conclusion, my friends, fill your minds with those things that are good and that deserve praise: things that are true, noble, right, pure, lovely, and honorable. (GNT)

Philippians 4:9

Section 4:2–9: Paul taught the Philippians how to find peace

Paul asked the believers in Philippi to behave peaceably toward one another. This was important, especially in the context of suffering for their faith. As a way to help them do that, he encouraged them to help one another, to be happy, to pray rather than worry, and to focus on thinking about good things.

Paragraph 4:8–9

In this paragraph, Paul told the believers another way that they could achieve peace among themselves: they should keep their minds on things that are good and follow the example that Paul had already set for them.

4:9

Scholars do not agree about how the first four verbs in 4:9 (“learned,” “received,” “heard,” “seen”) connect together. There are three possibilities:

1. There are two pairs of verbs. The first two verbs refer to the instructions Paul gave the Philippians

when he was away from them. The last two verbs may refer to what the Philippians learned from Paul when he was with them. (GNT, NJB, REB, GW, NCV)

2. The four verbs are all separate and do not fit into any smaller group. (KJV, RSV)
3. The first three verbs go together, and the last one is by itself. (BSB, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow the first option as it has the strongest support from commentaries (1).

4:9a

Whatever you have learned or received

- Continue doing the things that I taught you and that you accepted.

Whatever you have learned or received: This refers to the things the Philippians had learned and accepted from Paul. Some versions have combined this into one phrase, for example:

the teachings I gave you (CEV)

all you learned from me (NLT)

4:9b

or heard from me, or seen in me, put it into practice.

- Do the things which you heard me say and saw me do.

heard from me, or seen in me: This refers to the messages the Philippians heard Paul preach and the things they saw him do while he was with them.

in me: Paul was telling the believers at Philippi how he had acted when he was among them. They saw in what he did an example of each of the qualities he described in 4:8. The phrase in me is thus related in meaning to all four verbs “learned,” “received,” “heard,” and “seen,” but grammatically it is connected just to “seen.” It may be necessary to supply “from me” with the other three verbs, as the BSB has done.

put it into practice: Paul was asking them to follow his example, to obey his teaching and to imitate how he had acted.

4:9c

And the God of peace will be with you.

- And as a result, God, who gives you peace, will be with you.

And: That is, “as a result of doing all this.”

the God of peace will be with you: God would give the Philippian believers peace of heart and peace with

one another if they would follow the instructions that Paul had been giving them.

the God of peace: This means “the God who gives peace” (GNT, GW, CEV, NCV).

Philippians 4:10

Section 4:10–20: Paul thanked the Philippians for their gift

Paul now began to write about the gift that the Philippians had sent him. He reminded them that when he had been preaching the gospel in their area, they were the only group of believers that had sent gifts to him. He made it clear that Christ enabled him to be content in every situation. But their loving gift made him very happy. He also said that God would also supply all they needed. This should cause God’s people to praise him.

Paragraph 4:10–14

Paul had learned to be content whether he had less than he needed or whether he had more than he needed. But he was very happy that the Philippian believers had sent him a gift to help him when he needed it.

4:10

In this verse, Paul wrote that he was extremely happy because of the gift the Philippians had sent him. He rejoiced because by sending him a gift the Philippians had shown him that they still loved him. They were concerned that he should have the things that he needed.

4:10a

Now I rejoice greatly in the Lord

- ¶ Because I belong to the Lord, I am very joyful

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now (de) implies that Paul was starting to write about something different from what he had been writing about. It is not a time word. Many English versions, including the NIV, do not translate this Greek word. But your language may have a word or phrase that shows when the speaker or writer changes to a different topic. If so, it may be appropriate to use that word or phrase here.

I rejoice: In Greek the verb that the BSB translates as I rejoice is in the past tense. That indicates that Paul was happy when he received the gift. However, most English versions use a present tense. This is probably to make it clear that Paul began rejoicing when he first received the gift and was still rejoicing at the time he wrote the letter to the Philippians. You should use the tense in your language that best gives this meaning.

greatly: In the Greek this word is emphasized. Make sure this is an important word in your translation: Paul rejoiced “exceedingly” or “immensely.”

in the Lord: Paul did not rejoice for selfish reasons (that is, because of the gift alone) but in the Lord, that is, because he belonged to the Lord.

the Lord: That is, the Lord Jesus.

4:10b

that at last you have revived your concern for me.

- because finally you have demonstrated again that you care about me.
- because after a long time of not helping me, you have again shown by sending me a gift that you think about me and want to help me.

that: Paul now gave the reason why he was rejoicing. This can also be translated “because.”

at last: It had apparently been a long time since Paul had heard from the Philippians or received a gift from them. The phrase at last means “now, after a long time.” It does not imply that Paul was angry or irritated that he had not heard from the Philippians earlier.

you have revived your concern for me: Paul meant “You have shown again that you are concerned for me.” The Philippians had never stopped being concerned about Paul (4:10c) but by their gift they also showed this concern.

concern: The Greek word that the BSB translates as concern literally means “to think about someone.” It implies that the Philippians loved Paul and wanted to help him.

4:10c

You were indeed concerned,

- I know that you have always cared about me,
- I realize that you never stopped thinking about me,

You were indeed concerned: This phrase clarifies what Paul said in 4:10a–b. He did not want the Philippians to think he was accusing them of neglecting him.

indeed: The Greek idiom that the BSB translates as indeed literally means “for which.” Here it introduces a phrase to clarify a preceding statement and remove a wrong impression. So it can be translated as “indeed,” “actually” or “I know that.”

4:10d

but you had no opportunity to show it.

- but you had had no chance to express that concern by helping me.

- but until recently, you had no way to show that you still cared about me.

but you had no opportunity to show it: One reason why Paul had not received a gift from the Philippians for a long time was probably that they had no way until then to send a gift to him. Finally, they had sent the money with Epaphroditus, who traveled from Philippi to Rome to take it to Paul.

Philippians 4:11

Section 4:10–20: Paul thanked the Philippians for their gift

Paul now began to write about the gift that the Philippians had sent him. He reminded them that when he had been preaching the gospel in their area, they were the only group of believers that had sent gifts to him. He made it clear that Christ enabled him to be content in every situation. But their loving gift made him very happy. He also said that God would also supply all they needed. This should cause God's people to praise him.

Paragraph 4:10–14

Paul had learned to be content whether he had less than he needed or whether he had more than he needed. But he was very happy that the Philippian believers had sent him a gift to help him when he needed it.

4:11a

I am not saying this out of need,

- But the reason I just told you that is not because I am worried that I lack something I need.
- I say this, but not to tell you I do not have all I need.

I am not saying this out of need: By the word this, Paul was referring to what he had just said in 4:10. Paul did not want to imply, by the fact he rejoiced at the gift the Philippians had sent, that he needed or did not need anything.

out of need: This could refer to:

1. material, financial need—poverty; (BSB, NIV, RSV, REB, CEV, GW, NLT, NCV, NJB, NET, KJV)
2. a feeling of neglect. For example:

because I feel neglected (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

4:11b

for I have learned to be content regardless of my circumstances.

- In fact, I have learned to be content in whatever situation I am.
- I have learned by experience how to be satisfied whatever happens in my life.

I have learned to be content regardless of my circumstances: Paul meant that Christ (4:13) had taught him how to be satisfied no matter what happened to him. In 4:12 he gave specific examples.

I have learned: Paul meant that he had discovered through what he had experienced how to be content whatever the circumstances.

regardless of my circumstances: The Greek is literally “in which [things] I am.” This can be understood in two ways:

1. It means “in whatever circumstances I am”. (BSB, RSV, NIV, NET, KJV, NASB, REB, GW)
2. It means “with the possessions which I have”. (GNT, NJB, NRSV, NLT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). 4:12 makes it clear that Paul had learned to be content in whatever situation God put him.

Philippians 4:12

Section 4:10–20: Paul thanked the Philippians for their gift

Paul now began to write about the gift that the Philippians had sent him. He reminded them that when he had been preaching the gospel in their area, they were the only group of believers that had sent gifts to him. He made it clear that Christ enabled him to be content in every situation. But their loving gift made him very happy. He also said that God would also supply all they needed. This should cause God's people to praise him.

Paragraph 4:10–14

Paul had learned to be content whether he had less than he needed or whether he had more than he needed. But he was very happy that the Philippian believers had sent him a gift to help him when he needed it.

4:12a

I know how to live humbly,

- That is, I know how to be satisfied when I do not have what I need.
- I am able to live with very little,

I know how to live humbly: Paul knew what it was like not to have the things he needed. He was capable of living with very little.

I know how: This has two possible meanings:

1. “I know how...”; that is, this means the same as “I have learned to be content” in 4:11b. (BSB, RSV, KJV, NASB, NJB, GW, NLT, NCV)
2. “I know by experience” or “I have experienced [need]”. (NIV, GNT, NET, NRSV, REB, CEV).

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul was expanding what he has said in 4:11. In this verse he was giving specific examples.

to live humbly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to live humbly can be understood as referring to two things:

1. It refers to a lack of physical resources such as food, clothes and money. (NIV, GNT, NET, REB, NASB, NRSV, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)
2. It refers to a mental state and means that Paul was humbled or humiliated. (BSB, RSV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

4:12b

and I know how to abound.

- I also know how to be satisfied when I have enough.
- and I am able to live when I have all that I need.

I know how to abound: Paul had experienced times when he had lacked things he needed, but he had also had times when he had had enough. And he had learned how to be satisfied or content in both sets of circumstances.

I know: This has the same two possible meanings as in 4:12a and you should interpret it in the same way in both parts of the verse.

4:12c

I am accustomed to any and every situation—

- I have learned to be satisfied in all sorts of circumstances.
- I have learned how to be content no matter what happens to me,

I am accustomed to any and every situation: Here Paul repeated the main idea of what he had said in 4:11b. He had learned to be happy no matter what happened to him.

I am accustomed to: Paul was not talking here about learning something “secret,” something unknown to other people. He just meant that he had learned “how to...”

any and every situation: The Greek phrase here can be literally translated as “in every and in all.” This can be interpreted in different ways.

1. “Every” and “all” both refer to circumstances or situations. Together they mean “all sorts of situations”. (BSB, NIV, RSV, NASB, NET, NLT, CEV)
2. “Every” and “all” refer to different things. For example:

anywhere, at any time (GNT) (NCV, KJV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

4:12d

to being filled and being hungry,

- I know how to be satisfied whether I have eaten all I want or whether I am hungry.
- when I have plenty to eat and when I have too little to eat,

to being filled and being hungry: Paul had learned to be satisfied whether he had plenty of food or not enough food. Consider whether it would be a more natural order in your language to reverse the order and say “...whether hungry or filled.”

4:12e

to having plenty and having need.

- I have learned to be satisfied whether I have more than I need or less than I need.
- when I have all I need and when I do not have enough.

to having plenty and having need: Paul was content whether he had all he needed or less than he needed. He was repeating the main idea of what he said in 4:12a–b.

Philippians 4:13

Section 4:10–20: Paul thanked the Philippians for their gift

Paul now began to write about the gift that the Philippians had sent him. He reminded them that when he had been preaching the gospel in their area, they were the only group of believers that had sent gifts to him. He made it clear that Christ enabled him to be content in every situation. But their loving gift made him very happy. He also said that God would also supply all they needed. This should cause God’s people to praise him.

Paragraph 4:10–14

Paul had learned to be content whether he had less than he needed or whether he had more than he needed. But he was very happy that the Philippian believers had sent him a gift to help him when he needed it.

4:13

I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength.

- I am able to cope with all these things because Christ empowers me.

I can do all things: There are two ways to understand all things in this context:

1. all the conditions Paul has just mentioned; (GNT, REB, CEV)
2. all things in general; (BSB, RSV, NIV, NET, NJB, GW, NLT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul was able to be content in all situations that he had just mentioned.

Christ who gives me strength: Paul was referring to Christ, who gave him the strength to face any situation.

General Comment on 4:13

Paul did not mean that he could physically do anything or do things like live without food, but that Christ would strengthen him to continue to trust him even when he did not have enough food.

Philippians 4:14

Section 4:10–20: Paul thanked the Philippians for their gift

Paul now began to write about the gift that the Philippians had sent him. He reminded them that when he had been preaching the gospel in their area, they were the only group of believers that had sent gifts to him. He made it clear that Christ enabled him to be content in every situation. But their loving gift made him very happy. He also said that God would also supply all they needed. This should cause God's people to praise him.

Paragraph 4:10–14

Paul had learned to be content whether he had less than he needed or whether he had more than he needed. But he was very happy that the Philippian believers had sent him a gift to help him when he needed it.

4:14

Nevertheless, you have done well to share in my affliction.

- Even so, you are kind to have send help to me when I was having difficulties.
- However, thank you for helping me in this hard situation I am in.

Nevertheless: Even though Paul had learned to be content when he did not have what he needed, he still thanked the Philippian believers for their gift.

you have done well to share in my affliction: Paul expressed his gratitude to the Philippians for the gift they had sent him.

you have done well: This is literally “you did well.” Paul was praising what the Philippians did. He was recognizing that what they did was kind and generous. In this way, he was thanking them for the gift they had sent to him.

to share in my affliction: The Philippians had shared in Paul's troubles by sending financial help to him. In this way, they became his partners. See notes on “partnership” in 1:5a.

to share: The Greek word that the BSB translates as share is the same as the word used in 1:7, where the BSB translates it as “partners.”

Philippians 4:15

Section 4:10–20: Paul thanked the Philippians for their gift

Paul now began to write about the gift that the Philippians had sent him. He reminded them that when he had been preaching the gospel in their area, they were the only group of believers that had sent gifts to him. He made it clear that Christ enabled him to be content in every situation. But their loving gift made him very happy. He also said that God would also supply all they needed. This should cause God's people to praise him.

Paragraph 4:15–20

Paul told the Philippians that he had received the generous gift they had sent to him with Epaphroditus. He told them that God would also supply what they needed.

4:15

During Paul's travels after his first visit to Philippi, the believers there sent him gifts to help pay the expenses of his ministry. They were the only church that did that at that time. This is what Paul was talking about in 4:15.

4:15a

And as you Philippians know,

- ¶ Indeed, you Philippians already know that,

And as you Philippians know: The Greek word that the BSB translates as And can also be translated “indeed” or “and.” Paul was saying that they already knew what he was going to tell them in 4:15–16.

4:15b **in the early days of the gospel,**

- at the time when you were first learning the good news about Jesus Christ,

in the early days of the gospel: This is literally “in the beginning of the gospel.” The phrase can be interpreted in several ways:

1. It focuses on the Philippians and the time when they first heard the good news about Jesus Christ. It may also include the years when they were still new believers. (NIV, NLT)
2. It focuses on Paul and the time when he first preached the gospel in Macedonia. For example:

in the early days of preaching the Good News (GNT) (NET, REB, CEV, NCV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is most likely here that Paul was writing from the point of view of the Philippians.

4:15c **when I left Macedonia,**

- specifically when I left your province of Macedonia,

when I left Macedonia: There are two ways to translate the form of the Greek verb in this part of the verse:

1. It refers to the precise time when Paul actually left Macedonia to go to Athens and Corinth (Acts 17:14–15). (NIV, REB)
2. It refers more generally to some time after Paul had left Macedonia to go to Athens and Corinth. For example:

After I left there.... (CEV) (NASB, CEV)

Many English versions are ambiguous. However, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The first gift Paul received from the Philippians was when he was in Thessalonica (4:16). Since Thessalonica was also in Macedonia, this favors interpretation (1).

4:15d **no church but you partnered with me in the matter of giving and receiving.**

- you were the only group of believers to help me by giving me gifts of money.
- you were the only group of believers that gave/sent gifts to me.

no church but you partnered with me: No other church sent gifts to Paul at that time. The church at Philippi was the only one that did.

partnered with me: The Philippian believers became partners with Paul in his work by sending money and perhaps other things to help him. See the note on 1:5a.

in the matter of giving and receiving: Paul was probably using a business or financial term here that means “in an accounting of expenses and receipts.” He was referring to the gifts of money and perhaps other things that the Philippians had sent to him and his companions. The use of both giving and receiving can be understood in two ways:

1. The Philippians gave and Paul received. The Philippians gave physical (material) gifts to Paul, and he told them that he had received them. (NCV, NLT)
2. The Philippians both gave and received. They had already received Paul’s gift of the gospel, and, in return, they gave him physical gifts (see 1 Corinthians 9:11). (GW, CEV)

Either interpretation is possible here, and many English versions are ambiguous. If you need to make explicit who was giving and who was receiving, it is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1).

Philippians 4:16

Section 4:10–20: Paul thanked the Philippians for their gift

Paul now began to write about the gift that the Philippians had sent him. He reminded them that when he had been preaching the gospel in their area, they were the only group of believers that had sent gifts to him. He made it clear that Christ enabled him to be content in every situation. But their loving gift made him very happy. He also said that God would also supply all they needed. This should cause God’s people to praise him.

Paragraph 4:15–20

Paul told the Philippians that he had received the generous gift they had sent to him with Epaphroditus. He told them that God would also supply what they needed.

4:16a **For even while I was in Thessalonica,**

- Even while I was still in Macedonia in the city of Thessalonica,

For: This Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* indicates 4:16 is an example and proof of the Philippians’ generosity which Paul had just been talking about.

even: This implies that Paul had been surprised that they sent gifts to him so soon after he left Philippi.

Thessalonica: Thessalonica was another town in Macedonia, not far from Philippi. Paul went there after he had left Philippi. Perhaps that is why Paul seemed surprised to receive a gift from them there. One way you could express 4:16a could be:

You sent help to me...even while I was still in Thessalonica before I left Macedonia.

4:16b

you provided for my needs again and again.

- you sent gifts of money to me not once but twice when I needed help.

you provided for my needs: Paul did not specify what sort of help the Philippians had sent him. However, the gifts were probably gifts of money.

again and again: In the Greek this literally means “both once and twice.” Scholars do not know the exact meaning of this idiom. There are three possibilities:

1. It means “twice.” The Philippians sent gifts to Paul twice. (NJB, GW)
2. It means “more than once.” They sent gifts more than once, but Paul did not say how many times. (GNT, NET, NASB, REB, NLT, CEV)
3. It means “repeatedly.” They sent gifts repeatedly, that is, several times. (BSB, NIV, NCV)

The first meaning has stronger commentary support and it is recommended that you follow it in your translation (1).

Philippians 4:17

Section 4:10–20: Paul thanked the Philippians for their gift

Paul now began to write about the gift that the Philippians had sent him. He reminded them that when he had been preaching the gospel in their area, they were the only group of believers that had sent gifts to him. He made it clear that Christ enabled him to be content in every situation. But their loving gift made him very happy. He also said that God would also supply all they needed. This should cause God’s people to praise him.

Paragraph 4:15–20

Paul told the Philippians that he had received the generous gift they had sent to him with Epaphroditus. He told them that God would also supply what they needed.

4:17

In this verse Paul one again used business language. He used the metaphor of a bank account. The good things the Philippian believers were doing to help Paul

preach the good news were like adding interest to their bank account (that is, putting more money into their account). He implied that God was keeping a record of these things they were doing for his kingdom and would reward them.

4:17a

Not that I am seeking a gift,

- I am not telling you this so that you will continue to send me gifts.
- It is not because I am eager to receive another gift from you that I am saying this.

Not that I am seeking a gift: Paul was not telling the Philippians that he appreciated their help so that they would continue to send him gifts. Even though he needed it, the money was not what he was mainly concerned about. You could translate this as:

The thing I am mainly concerned about is not the gifts that you send.

seeking: Paul was referring to how he was thinking, not to the physical action of seeking or looking. He meant that he was not hoping and expecting that the Philippians would send him another gift.

a gift: It may be helpful to translate this as “another gift,” to indicate that Paul was referring to possible future gifts.

4:17b

but I am looking for the fruit that may be credited to your account.

- I want to see God bless you for generously helping me as you have.
- But I am eager to see good acts like this added to the list of good things you have already done and for which God will reward you.

I am looking for the fruit that may be credited to your account: Paul meant that the main thing he wanted was to see them continue serving the kingdom of God, which would result in God rewarding them. This is the same idea as people “storing up treasures in heaven” (Matthew 6:19–21 and Luke 12:33–34).

the fruit that may be credited to your account: This is a financial expression referring to profit or interest building up in a bank account. Paul was using it in a spiritual sense here to mean that their generosity to Paul pleased God. Do not keep this financial metaphor, unless it has the same meaning in your language. Use a term or expression in your language that would make clear what Paul was really referring to here.

Philippians 4:18

Section 4:10–20: Paul thanked the Philippians for their gift

Paul now began to write about the gift that the Philippians had sent him. He reminded them that when he had been preaching the gospel in their area, they were the only group of believers that had sent gifts to him. He made it clear that Christ enabled him to be content in every situation. But their loving gift made him very happy. He also said that God would also supply all they needed. This should cause God's people to praise him.

Paragraph 4:15–20

Paul told the Philippians that he had received the generous gift they had sent to him with Epaphroditus. He told them that God would also supply what they needed.

4:18

This verse connects to the previous one with a Greek particle, *de*, that often indicates a slight contrast or change of the direction of the thought. Many English versions omit any explicit connection here, but if you have a way in your language to show such a connection you may use it here.

4:18a

I have all I need and more,

- So then, I have now received everything you sent to me and it is more than enough.

I have all I need and more: Paul continued his business metaphor by saying, in effect,

Here...is my receipt for everything (GNT)

He meant that he had received their gift and it supplied all he needed.

and more: The Philippians' gift was more than enough for what Paul needed.

4:18b

now that I have received your gifts from Epaphroditus.

- Since Epaphroditus has now brought me the things you sent, I have everything that I could possibly need.

I have received your gifts from Epaphroditus: Epaphroditus was the one who brought the Philippians' gift to Paul. See the note on 2:25c.

your gifts: The Greek literally means "the things you sent." Apparently different people from Philippi sent things to help Paul, and this explains why the term gifts is in the plural.

General Comment on 4:18b

The three events in this part of the verse actually happened in this order:

1. the Philippians sent Paul gifts;
2. Epaphroditus handed them to Paul;
3. Paul was amply supplied.

In some languages it will be necessary to reorder this verse so that the events are in the right order. For example:

You sent me gifts, and Epaphroditus has given them to me. So now I have all that I need.

4:18c

They are a fragrant offering, an acceptable sacrifice, well-pleasing to God.

- It is as if you have given an offering to God that smells sweet. He accepts it and it pleases him very much.

They are a fragrant offering, an acceptable sacrifice, well-pleasing to God: Paul again thought of the gifts from the Philippians in a collective sense, as a single large gift. He was saying that the help they sent was pleasing to God in the same way that the sort of sacrifice God required was pleasing to him.

a fragrant offering: This is literally "an odor of a sweet smell." It refers to an offering to God that smells good. The Jewish people brought offerings to God as a way of worshiping him. When the priest burned these sacrifices, whether animals or grain and incense, God said that the smell was pleasing to him (See, for example, Leviticus 1:9, 2:1–2). Paul used these Jewish sacrifices as a metaphor for the gift the Philippians had sent. It may be necessary in some languages to translate this as a simile: "Your gift is like a sweet-smelling sacrifice...."

an acceptable sacrifice: Some sacrifices people made to God had something wrong with them or the people who offered them had the wrong attitude, and God did not accept those sacrifices. But God did accept the things the Philippians sent to Paul because they sent them lovingly.

well-pleasing to God: God approved of what the Philippians had done and the gifts they had sent to Paul. Their attitude and their gift were right.

Another way to translate 4:18c would be:

Your gifts to me are like the sweet-smelling offerings and sacrifices the priests offer to God. He accepts those offerings and they make him happy.

Philippians 4:19

Section 4:10–20: Paul thanked the Philippians for their gift

Paul now began to write about the gift that the Philippians had sent him. He reminded them that when he had been preaching the gospel in their area, they were the only group of believers that had sent gifts to him. He made it clear that Christ enabled him to be content in every situation. But their loving gift made him very happy. He also said that God would also supply all they needed. This should cause God's people to praise him.

Paragraph 4:15–20

Paul told the Philippians that he had received the generous gift they had sent to him with Epaphroditus. He told them that God would also supply what they needed.

4:19

And my God will supply all your needs according to His glorious riches in Christ Jesus.

- And my God will give you everything you need from out of his abundant wealth/resources because of what Christ Jesus has done.
- And because of what Christ Jesus has done, God, whom I worship, is able to supply all that you need, and he will do this.

The Philippian believers had given Paul what he needed. And here Paul said that God would also give them what they needed.

my God: This means “the God whom I worship and serve.” It refers to the God that Paul belonged to. It does not mean that God belonged to Paul.

will supply all your needs: Paul said that God would provide/supply everything that the Philippians needed.

according to: This expresses the relationship between God's riches and the Philippians' needs. God's riches are sufficient for meeting every need.

glorious: The Greek expression *en doxē* that the BSB has translated glorious literally means “in glory.” There are three main ways to interpret this phrase here:

1. It relates to the word “riches.” In this case, it means “his glorious riches” or “his abundant wealth”. (BSB, NIV, GNT, NCV, CEV, NLT, REB)

2. It relates to the verb that the BSB translated “will supply.” In this case, it would mean:

God will gloriously [that is, abundantly, completely] supply everything you need (GW)

1. It has its literal meaning and refers to a location “in glory”. (RSV, KJV, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

riches: The word riches in this verse refers to God's power or ability to supply all that people need physically and spiritually. It is not limited to money or material things.

in Christ Jesus: There are two ways to interpret this phrase here:

1. It means “through Christ Jesus,” that is, because of what Jesus has done for them. (GW, GNT, CEV)
2. It means because the Philippians belong to Jesus.

Most English versions translate the phrase literally. The Greek probably implies both meanings. It was because of what Jesus had done for them that the Philippian believers belonged to him. And this is why God had a way to supply so abundantly what they needed.

You could translate 4:19 something like the following:

And God, whom I serve, will give you everything you need according to his wonderful and unlimited riches because of what Christ Jesus has done for you.

General Comment on 4:19

In some languages it will be helpful to reorder this verse. One way to do this would be:

Moreover, God, whom I serve, has an unlimited supply of everything that we^(incl) need. And as a result, he will completely supply everything that you need because Christ Jesus has died for us^(incl). (SSA)

Philippians 4:20

Section 4:10–20: Paul thanked the Philippians for their gift

Paul now began to write about the gift that the Philippians had sent him. He reminded them that when he had been preaching the gospel in their area, they were the only group of believers that had sent gifts to him. He made it clear that Christ enabled him to be content

in every situation. But their loving gift made him very happy. He also said that God would also supply all they needed. This should cause God's people to praise him.

Paragraph 4:15–20

Paul told the Philippians that he had received the generous gift they had sent to him with Epaphroditus. He told them that God would also supply what they needed.

4:20

To our God and Father be glory forever and ever. Amen.

- Let us^(incl) always praise God, who is our^(incl) heavenly Father. Amen.
- May we^(incl) acknowledge forever that our^(incl) Father God is great. Let it be so.

To our God and Father be glory: This phrase is like a prayer. It expresses the desire that people would glorify God, that is, praise him and acknowledge that he is great and glorious. See the note on 1:11c.

our God and Father: The word *our* modifies both God and Father. It means that God is the God we worship and that he is like a father to us. See the note on 1:2 on “our Father.”

forever and ever: God's people should praise him forever, without end, for all ages to come.

Amen: This is from a Hebrew word which means to approve and confirm as true what someone has just said. In many languages people will already be familiar with it and so it is possible to transliterate it. Otherwise it can be translated “This is true” or “Let it be so.”

Philippians 4:21

Section 4:21–23: Paul and those with him sent greetings to all the Philippian believers

With these verses, Paul ended his letter to the Philippian believers. As he did in many of his letters, he sent his greetings and the greetings of the believers who were with him. He ended the letter with a brief prayer or blessing (4:23).

4:21a

Greet all the saints in Christ Jesus.

- ¶ Greet every one of God's people who trusts in Christ Jesus.
- ¶ Give my greetings to all God's people who belong to Christ Jesus.

Greet all the saints in Christ Jesus: Paul told those who would read or hear his letter to give his greetings to the rest of the believers in Philippi.

Greet: This is a command addressed to more than one person. Probably Paul was addressing the church leaders, who would have read the letter first.

all the saints: See notes on 1:1b for the meaning of saints. Paul wanted to greet every believer in Philippi. In some languages it may be necessary to supply the word “other” to indicate that those who would pass on Paul's greetings were also Christians.

in Christ Jesus: There are three main ways that this phrase can be understood here:

1. It explains the word “saints.” The “saints” are those who are united with or are in Christ Jesus. For example:

Greetings to each one of God's people who belong to Christ Jesus. (GNT) (GW, NLT, GNT)

1. It relates to the verb “greet.” This would mean, “Greet in Christ Jesus' name all God's people.” For example:

Give my greetings, in the fellowship of Christ Jesus. (REB)

1. It means “because of Christ Jesus.” For example:

Give my greetings to all who are God's people because of Christ Jesus. (CEV)

The first interpretation is the most likely, and it is recommended that you follow it (1).

4:21b

The brothers who are with me send you greetings.

- Our^(incl) brothers here with me also greet you.
- The Christian brothers who are with me here also send their greetings to you.

The brothers who are with me send you greetings:

This probably refers to the believers who worked closely with Paul. They also sent their greetings to the believers in Philippi. It does not mean that these believers were with Paul in the Roman prison. But they would have been in the city of Rome. These co-workers were probably all men, and it is not necessary to translate brothers as “brothers and sisters” here.

Philippians 4:22

Section 4:21–23: Paul and those with him sent greetings to all the Philippian believers

With these verses, Paul ended his letter to the Philippian believers. As he did in many of his letters, he sent his greetings and the greetings of the believers who were with him. He ended the letter with a brief prayer or blessing (4:23).

4:22a

All the saints send you greetings,

- All the rest of God's people who live in this city also send greetings to you.

All the saints send you greetings: The phrase All the saints apparently represents the larger group of believers in Rome, all those who were followers of Christ in that city.

4:22b

especially those from the household of Caesar.

- Those believers who are servants of the Roman emperor especially send you greetings.

especially those from the household of Caesar: The phrase household of Caesar refers to those believers who in some way worked for the Roman emperor.

those from the household of Caesar: It is not likely that Paul was referring to the emperor's relatives. He probably meant people who worked in the emperor's palace as slaves or other servants as well as those who worked for the emperor as scribes, soldiers or administrators throughout the city of Rome.

Caesar: This was originally the proper name of the Roman emperor, but it came to be used as the title of the emperor or leader of the Roman Empire. It is better, therefore, to translate it as "Roman emperor" or "Roman king" than to transliterate it as a proper name.

Philippians 4:23

Section 4:21–23: Paul and those with him sent greetings to all the Philippian believers

With these verses, Paul ended his letter to the Philippian believers. As he did in many of his letters, he sent his greetings and the greetings of the believers who were with him. He ended the letter with a brief prayer or blessing (4:23).

4:23

The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit.

- I pray that the Lord Jesus Christ will be very favorable to you all.

- May the Lord Jesus Christ be kind and loving to you all.

The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit:

Paul ended many of his letters with a form of blessing or prayer. The form varied from letter to letter. See also 1 Thessalonians 5:28 and Philemon verse 25.

grace: The idea of grace here implies both physical and spiritual blessing. It refers to God being kind and favorable toward people.

be with your spirit: It seems that Paul used the phrase be with your spirit here as meaning simply "be with you" or "be with you all" (see 4:23 in GNT). He was probably using the singular word translated spirit to refer to the group of believers in Philippi as a whole, as a unified group. But he also could have been using the singular form to apply his blessing to each individual in the group. See also Galatians 6:18; 2 Timothy 4:22 and Philemon verse 25.

(NIV:) Amen: See note on 4:20. The word amēn is in some Greek manuscripts here and not in others. The KJV, NAB, and NIV include it, but the BSB and some other modern English versions omit it. You must decide whether you want to include this ending (Amen) in your translation. It is recommended that you follow the national language version in this.